

Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions

by Alex Rogers

Title Page

COFFEE RINGS AND BAD DECISIONS

A Novel

Alex Rogers

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Published by Coffee Rings Press

ISBN-13: 978-1-XXXXXXX-XX-X

ISBN-10: 1-XXXXXXX-XX-X

Library of Congress Control Number: Pending

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First Edition / First Printing

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Cover design: Alex Rogers

Cover photography: Generated with FAL.ai FLUX

A NOVEL

Maya Chen did not believe in bad mornings. She believed in bad beans, bad weather, and bad decisions made before 7 a.m., but mornings themselves were neutral territory. Blank pages. Blank pages she had been failing to fill correctly for three years.

She opened Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions at six, but the mornings really started at five-thirty, when the alarm went off beside her bed in the apartment above the shop and her feet hit the floor with the reluctant thud of someone negotiating with gravity. First she made toast that always came out uneven. Then she brushed her teeth while staring at the ceiling. Then she put on her apron, grabbed her key ring, and descended the creaky back stairs that still made a sound like a ship's hull complaining about the sea.

The shop smelled like burnt milk and consequences.

It was a smell she had grown intimate with, the way other people grew intimate with the scent of their partner's shampoo or the particular dusty odor of an old book. She knew its moods. Burnt milk on Tuesdays meant the afternoon rush had overwhelmed Sam. Burnt milk on Wednesdays meant Maya herself had lost focus halfway through a pour and let the steam wand hiss into the milk too long. This Tuesday was a Sam morning.

"Latte down," Sam said, leaning against the espresso machine like it was a bar counter and they were in some noir film. "Table four needs a redo. Again. The guy with the laptop that's bigger than his personality says the foam was 'too frothy.' I told him froth is a feature, not a bug."

"Don't start a war with Table Four before nine," Maya said, slinging a portafilter with the weary precision of someone who'd done this exact motion nine thousand times. The metal clinked against the group head. The machine exhaled steam. Somewhere nearby, the milk pitcher hissed. "We're already down 12% on Tuesday revenue."

"Twelve percent is a number," Sam said. "Twelve percent is also 'Bean & Leaf is robbing our customers with a \$2.50 drip and free Wi-Fi.'"

"We have better Wi-Fi."

"Bean & Leaf has better branding, a loyalty app, and a CFO who understands people will pay five bucks for a drink if you put it in a cup that looks good on Instagram. We have a loyalty card from 1994 and a cash register that beeps louder than it should."

Maya wiped the steam wand for the fourth time that hour. The rag was already brown. "We have character. Bean & Leaf has beige walls and a logo designed by someone who went to design school specifically to forget what character looks like."

"Character doesn't pay the lease."

"The lease is being paid. For now."

For now was doing a lot of heavy lifting in this conversation. Maya knew it. Every month was a negotiation between rent and hope. She'd taken the loan to buy the equipment, fix the roof, and stop serving coffee that tasted like river water. The loan had a due date. The due date was getting closer. She'd done the math in her head a hundred times and the math kept doing the same thing: smiling politely and telling her she was fine.

She'd owned the shop for just over three years, ever since the previous owner retired after a heart attack that nobody saw coming, not even the cardiologist who'd been telling him for a decade to slow down on the late-night espresso shifts. Maya had been the assistant manager, the only person who'd shown up every day for six months even when the roof leaked and the espresso machine sounded like it was being strangled. When the owner's kids put it up for sale, they'd called it "a going concern with character." Maya had called it "a chance."

She took out a small-business loan, borrowed from her grandmother, and maxed out a credit card that had previously been reserved for emergencies and nice vacations she never took. It had seemed like a good idea at the time. Some nights, lying awake in the apartment above the shop, listening to the refrigerator cycle on and the wind rattling the back door, she could still feel the echo of that certainty.

She was 29 years old and her biggest financial fear was a beautifully roasted Ethiopian single-origin.

The bell above the door jingled.

Maya didn't look up. "Welcome. I take your order now."

"Wow," a voice said. "Rushed off the factory line, were you?"

She looked up then.

The man who'd walked in was wearing a navy suit that cost more than her espresso machine. His hair was precisely the kind of precisely unkempt that required a hairstylist and a lot of patience. His face was either annoyingly symmetrical or aggressively average, and she couldn't decide which frustrated her more. He carried a leather messenger bag that looked like it had been curated by someone who understood the heavier end of capitalism.

"We open at seven," Maya said, wiping her hands on her apron. "It's seven-oh-three. So technically you're on time. Barely. What can I get you?"

"Just a black coffee," he said. "Filter. Not pour-over. Not cold brew. Not whatever the chemist version of pour-over is. Just coffee. The way coffee is supposed to taste."

Maya stared at him. "That's the worst order I've heard in six months."

"Six months is a short window. Come back to me in a year."

"I won't. Because you'll go to Bean & Leaf and get bean-sludge in a paper cup and call it a day."

He blinked. "You know about Bean & Leaf?"

"Everyone knows about Bean & Leaf. They're the Starbucks of anti-Starbucks. Raising Series B so they can price out every independent shop within a three-mile radius and replace us with artisanal minimalism." She pointed at him with the portafilter. "You're wearing a suit. Did you just come from a meeting about acquiring my soul?"

He laughed. A real laugh — not a corporate one, which was almost worse because it meant he'd already charmed her before she was ready to be charmed.

"Actually," he said, "I just came from a meeting where we discussed ethical sourcing and why it matters to the people who actually drink the coffee, not the people who design the cups."

"Ethical sourcing," Maya said, the phrase tasting like a press release. "Is that what Bean & Leaf calls it now?"

"Every week it's something new. Last week we cared about 'farmer equity.' The week before, 'sustainable micro-lots.' The brand team has a creativity budget and they're spending it all on adjectives."

Maya laughed. It came out like a bark. "Okay. You're either the most honest corporate suit I've ever met or you're testing me for a market research study."

"Promise I'm not. I'm a suit. Just one who stopped believing the adjectives last quarter." He glanced at her name tag. "Maya. Nice to meet you. I'm Leo."

"Leo what."

"Leo who's going to order coffee before your steam wand dies."

She made the coffee. It was the good stuff — the Yirgacheffe she'd been hoarding for customers who actually cared. She poured it into a ceramic mug, never a paper cup, and slid it across the counter. The mug had a chip on the rim that Sam had tried to fix with gold paint, which Maya considered both a personal affront and a work of art.

He took a sip. Closed his eyes. Opened them. Looked at the coffee like it had personally affronted him.

"Wow," he said.

"I know. It's Ethiopian. Don't ask about the tasting notes. I don't do tasting notes. I just sell coffee that doesn't taste like regret."

"I can work with that." He paused. "Do you have a business card?"

Maya's smile faltered. Business cards were the first step toward a conversation that usually ended with someone explaining how their startup was going to disrupt the coffee industry. "Why?"

"Because I might want to refer you to someone."

"Who."

"A bean importer who actually knows what acidity means and doesn't describe it as 'bright' like it's a personality trait."

She relaxed. Not all corporate people were the enemy. Some were just people who'd had enough adjectives. "Sure." She fished a card from the jar behind the register and handed it over. It featured a drawing of a coffee cup with an uncharacteristically cheerful face, which she'd drawn herself and which Sam said was "the only honest piece of branding in this neighborhood."

He studied it. "Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions," he read aloud. "That's a name."

"It's a brand."

"It's a warning."

"I meant both."

Leo smiled. The real smile. Not a fake corporate smile — a real one that made the corners of his eyes crinkle in a way Maya found extremely irritating. "I'll see you around, Maya. Unless Bean & Leaf wins. In which case I'll see you at the next job fair."

"I'm not losing to Bean & Leaf."

"No one is," he said. "Yet."

The bell jingled. He was gone.

Maya stood in the empty shop, looking at his card on the counter. It said Leo Bianchi, acquisitions director, Bean & Leaf Coffee. The words initially refused to make sense, like she was reading them in a language she'd forgotten.

She picked up the card. Looked at it for a long time.

Then she threw it in the trash.

Not before memorizing his face.

The rest of the morning passed in the usual haze — the grind of beans, the hiss of the espresso machine, the small dramas of strangers who wanted their coffee exactly this way and not that way. Sam worked the afternoon shift with military precision, and Maya retreated to the back office to stare at her loan spreadsheet. The numbers looked the same as they had the day before. The day before that. They were numbers that did not believe in hope.

The spreadsheet was open on a laptop whose battery had been failing for months. She'd bought it refurbished, not because she loved saving money but because she preferred not thinking about money whenever possible. But the spreadsheet didn't care about her preferences. It simply told the truth, over and over, in columns that refused to add up to anything good. Revenue: down twelve percent from the same Tuesday last year. Rent: scheduled to increase by four hundred dollars starting in January. Loan principal: barely moving. Interest: consistently winning.

Her phone buzzed with a text from her mother: Did you eat today? Maya stared at it for three minutes and then typed back: Working. Talk later. She meant it. She did want to talk later. Later was a mythical place, somewhere after the spreadsheet, after the rush, after she remembered to eat something that wasn't a pastry she'd made herself at 2 a.m.

At 2:17 p.m., her phone buzzed with an email notification. She picked it up with the same energy one might pick up a dead fish.

Subject: Order Confirmation #48721 — Ethiopian Single-Origin Green Coffee — 500 lbs
From: porter@ethiopicbeans.com
Status: Confirmed — Payment Processing

Maya stared at the screen. She read it again. Then a third time.

Five. Hundred. Pounds.

She had meant to order fifty.

She had definitely not meant to order five hundred. Fifty pounds was a responsible, adult quantity. Five hundred pounds was a crisis with shipping labels. Five hundred pounds was what a real coffee shop ordered, not a shop that was still using a cash register from 1994 and arguing about foam. Five hundred pounds was enough green coffee to keep her busy until approximately the time her grandchildren were old enough to understand why she'd done what she did.

She called the number on the invoice. A man named Tom answered on the second ring.

"Yes?" Tom said. His voice was the voice of a man who had been answering phones for a long time and had developed opinions about each ring.

"Hi. Tom? I think there's been a mistake with my order. I ordered fifty pounds of Ethiopian and my confirmation says five hundred."

There was a pause. A long pause. The kind of pause that meant Tom was currently looking at the same screen she was and doing the same math she'd done three times in thirty seconds.

"Ma'am," Tom said, "your order says 500. Confirmed. Payment's already processing."

"What about canceling?"

"Green coffee orders are non-cancelable within 72 hours of confirmation. It's in the terms you agreed to

when you created the account. I can show you the timestamp if you'd like."

Maya closed her eyes. "No. I believe you. What's the total?"

There was another pause. "Fourteen thousand, two hundred dollars."

Fourteen thousand dollars. The number hung in the air like smoke from a bad roast. Maya sat down on a stool by the back door. She had three weeks to pay. Three weeks before the beans arrived, before the storage problem, before the loan officer started calling with that particular tone of voice reserved for people who had made bad decisions before 7 a.m.

The math was not on her side. She had a shop that made just enough money to keep the lights on and her own pride barely alive. She'd chosen the Ethiopian lot because it was her favorite, the kind that made customers close their eyes and say things like "I can taste blueberries" even though Maya was pretty sure blueberries were not a coffee flavor. She'd been planning a small experimental menu around it — a tasting special, something to get people talking, something that would make Bean & Leaf seem even more beige. But this? This was not a special. This was a mountain.

"Thank you, Tom," she said. "I'll figure it out."

She hung up and stared at the invoice. The total blinked at her: \$14,200.00. Below it, a cheerful note: "Thank you for supporting small-batch Ethiopian farmers!"

She would have liked to meet the particular farmer whose entire crop she had just accidentally purchased. She would have shook their hand. She would have said "I'm sorry my bank account is a disaster."

The shop phone rang. She let it ring four times. Then she picked up.

"Portland Coffee Rescue?" she said. It was what Sam called the shop on days when the mood required gallows humor.

"You're that coffee shop on Alberta," said a woman's voice. Polite. Slightly harried. "We saw your Festival entry. My daughter's a barista. We'd like to host a fundraiser for you."

Maya closed her eyes again. "A fundraiser?"

"Yes. Bean & Leaf gave us a \$100 gift card. For community relations. My daughter said we should give it to you instead. We'd also like to organize a pop-up at our church. Saturday. Can you do Saturday?"

"Saturday is usually our busiest day," Maya said, the old reflex kicking in before her brain could suggest different.

"The fundraiser is Saturday," the woman said. "Will you do it?"

Maya looked at the invoice on her laptop screen. She looked at the empty shop, at the wall of coffee bags, at the chalkboard menu that Sam had illustrated with little coffee cup characters that looked suspiciously like stick figures. She had fourteen thousand dollars of beans coming. She had three weeks. She had a shop that was slowly bleeding money and a reputation for being the place where indie coffee people gathered when they wanted to feel superior about pour-over.

"Yes," Maya said. "Saturday."

She hung up and immediately regretted it. Then she didn't. Then she did again.

The pop-up would bring people in. It would create buzz. It would mean waking up early on a morning she'd usually spent sleeping in and drinking bad hotel-room coffee if she was traveling, which she wasn't. It would mean asking Sam to work a double. It would mean staying late to prep and coming early to set up and probably burning through her last decent half-and-half carton.

It would also mean, possibly, not crying into her pillow on a Thursday night when the loan statements arrived and the universe reminded her that adults were supposed to have things figured out.

Anything was better than that.

By five, the shop was empty and the air was cool and the last customer had left a five-dollar tip on the table, which was more than table four had ever contributed. Maya sat in the front window and watched Alberta Street turn blue in the early evening. Couples walked by with dogs that were too small for the

neighborhood's general aesthetic. A kid on a skateboard rattled past, his backpack bouncing, and Maya felt a brief sharp memory of being that kid, of thinking adulthood was a thing with clear edges and sensible shoes. A woman with a stroller stopped to point at the window display, where Sam had arranged the coffee bags in a pyramid. The child clapped, and the woman laughed, and Maya found herself smiling without meaning to.

Her phone buzzed again. Leo Bianchi. She debated not answering. Then she answered.

"Hello."

"Maya. It's Leo. From this morning. The suit with the caffeine allergy."

She almost laughed. "I remember."

"I wanted to follow up on the importer thing. I have a contact who's actually really good. Would you want an introduction?"

"I don't need an introduction to an importer," Maya said, then immediately regretted it. What she meant was, I don't need an introduction to anyone associated with Bean & Leaf. What came out was defensive, and she hated that.

"Okay," Leo said. He sounded unsurprised. "Just trying to help. I'll let you go."

"Wait." The word came out before she could stop it.

"Yeah?"

"What's the importer's name?"

"Riviera & Sons. They work with a lot of small shops in the Pacific Northwest. The guy who runs it is named Tom."

Maya's stomach did something complicated. "The same Tom?"

"The same Tom."

She closed her eyes. The Tom who had just told her she owed fourteen thousand dollars. The Tom who had a voice that suggested he'd been answering phones since the 1980s. "I think I already know him."

"Well," Leo said, and she could hear the smile in his voice, "maybe he'll give you a different price on the phone than he gives me."

"Maybe," Maya said.

"I'll send you his number. And Maya?"

"Yeah?"

"I'm not going to tell my boss you ordered 500 pounds of Ethiopian by accident."

Maya felt something warm and stupid and entirely unlike professional composure settle in her chest. "Thanks."

"No problem. See you around."

He hung up.

Maya sat in the darkening shop and listened to the refrigerator hum. The espresso machine gave a single heroic sigh, like it was being asked to do more than it should. Outside, the streetlights buzzed to life, casting orange rectangles across the linoleum floor. Somewhere down the block, someone was practicing guitar, badly but enthusiastically.

She was 29 years old and she had accidentally ordered five hundred pounds of coffee. She had a loan that was going to come due in three weeks. She had a shop that smelled like burnt milk and consequences and hope, in no particular order.

She picked up her phone and opened a new email. She typed Tom's name. Then she stared at the blank subject line for a long time.

Eventually, she wrote: "Re: Order Confirmation #48721 — Can We Talk?"

She hit send before she could overthink it.

Outside, the Alberta Street lights flickered on. Somewhere down the block, a dog barked once and then fell silent. Maya rested her head against the cool window and watched the evening turn into night, one minute at a time.

The shop had once been a dry cleaner. Before that, a bakery. Before that, according to Mrs. Hsu, who'd owned the building since 1987, it had been a speakeasy during Prohibition — a detail she offered with the particular pride of a woman who'd discovered good real estate before anyone else in the neighborhood. Maya liked imagining it that way sometimes: bodies pressed close in a dim back room, whispers about shipments and secrets and the kind of courage you needed to keep something illegal running while the cops watched from down the street. The present was quieter. The present was oat milk and Bluetooth speakers and a cash register that beeped louder than a smoke detector.

"It was where the bootleggers met," Mrs. Hsu said, standing in the doorway with her arms crossed and her expression suggesting that she had personally raided the speakeasy, and that it had been adequate. "The floorboards still creak. I've had three contractors tell me they're normal floorboards. I tell them they're not normal floorboards. They're storytelling floorboards."

She said it with her chin up, as if the floorboards themselves were a lawsuit waiting to happen. Maya had learned to interpret Mrs. Hsu's landlord dialect after three years of listening carefully and never asking twice. When Mrs. Hsu said "the floorboards are storytelling floorboards," she meant "the foundation is fine but I want you to be a little afraid of it." When she said "I've raised the rent by four percent," she meant "I've raised the rent by four percent and also I'm going to talk about my nephew for fifteen minutes." When she said "have you considered offering pastries again?" she meant "you are failing at the one thing that made me overlook the time the plumbing exploded."

Maya was still working on the nephew system. So far she had identified three nephews, two careers in technology, one that involved something with wind turbines, and a general sense that Mrs. Hsu wanted to be helpful while simultaneously making sure Maya understood who held the lease.

"Storytelling floorboards," Maya said, trying the phrase on for size. "I'll keep that in mind."

"You should. They tell stories about people who didn't pay their rent on time."

Maya smiled the tight smile she used when Mrs. Hsu said things that were technically jokes but also technically warnings. It was the kind of smile that said I hear you and also I am choosing not to flinch. "Rent's always on time, Mrs. Hsu."

"We'll see."

Mrs. Hsu left. The door closed. The bell above the door jingled once and then went quiet, as if it had also learned to fear the landlord's visit. In her wake she left the faint smell of lily perfume and something else — faint, sharp, expensive. Maya had never seen Mrs. Hsu wear perfume that smelled like anything other than discipline, but this was different. It was a scent that said I am not worried about you merely because I can afford not to be.

Maya turned back to the counter. Sam was doing something involving a thermometer and a very serious face, which meant she was calibrating the espresso machine again. The machine had been calibrated so many times that Maya sometimes suspected Sam was performing a ritual rather than maintaining equipment. Sam had been with her since month two, when she'd showed up with a barista résumé written entirely in Sharpie and an attitude that suggested she'd been denied entry to somewhere important. Maya had hired her without reading the résumé. It had been one of the best decisions she'd made since she'd bought the place — second only, perhaps, to not throwing the espresso grinder through the front window the week before.

"Did you survive the Hsu interrogation?" Sam asked without looking up. The thermometer beeped twice. Sam wrote something in a notebook that Maya was fairly certain was a grinder grimoire.

"I survived. She mentioned the speakeasy floorboards again."

"Let me guess. They creak in Morse code."

"Something like that."

Sam finally looked up. She was wearing an apron that said I SURVIVED ANOTHER MEETING THAT SHOULD HAVE BEEN AN EMAIL, which she had received as a gift from her sister and which she wore with the particular pride of someone who'd survived many meetings. Her hair was half up, held by a clip Maya had found on the sidewalk three years earlier and accidentally kept. "You want me to run a grinder diagnostic or do you want to tell me what's actually on your mind?"

Maya hadn't known she had a "what's actually on your mind" face, but apparently she did. Sam had always been better at reading people than Maya was, which was exactly why Maya kept her around. Maya told her about the invoice. She told her about Tom. She told her about Leo and the referral and the fact that she'd thrown his business card in the trash but had still memorized his face, which was a

detail she found herself unable to explain even to herself.

Sam listened without interrupting, which was rare. Sam usually listened while multitasking, polishing steam wands or rearranging pastry cases or staring at the wall as if it had personally disappointed her. But now she was still, her thermometer forgotten on the counter, her eyebrows doing a slow climb toward her hairline.

"So," Sam said when Maya finished, "let me get this straight. You have a suit from Bean & Leaf who's bold enough to refer you to an importer, you have five hundred pounds of Ethiopian you can't afford, and we have Saturday's fundraiser."

"Yes."

"And Mrs. Hsu's floorboards are judging us."

"I believe so."

Sam nodded. She had a way of nodding that suggested she was filing information into a mental category called Things That Are Not My Problem But I Will Help With Anyway. It was a large category. Maya had seen her use it for median-sized disagreements with delivery drivers, existential crises about latte art, and at least one emergency involving coins and a vending machine. "Here's what we do. First, we call Tom. Second, we figure out if five hundred pounds of Ethiopian is actually a disaster or a opportunity. Third, we prep for Saturday and we make it count. Fourth, we make Leo regret ever wearing a suit that cost more than our espresso machine."

"What's the part where we panic?"

"This is the panic part."

It was the least panic Maya had felt all morning. She laughed. It came out rusty, like a hinge that hadn't been oiled in a while. She'd forgotten what it felt like to not handle everything alone. "Okay. What's the plan?"

"The plan is I take the morning prep shift tomorrow and you spend three hours with Tom on the phone. I'll text you at seven. You answer. You negotiate. Then we drink the good wine."

"The wine's for after we hit sixty percent of yesterday's revenue."

"The plan has been updated," Sam said. "The wine is now for after you call Tom."

Maya looked at her phone, at the blank screen, at the email she'd drafted but not sent. She felt a flicker of something she hadn't felt in months — not hope, exactly, but the thing that came before hope, the muscle memory of trying. It was the feeling of stepping onto a diving board when you hadn't done it in years. Your legs remembered the flex even if your brain wasn't sure about the water.

"Okay."

"Okay," Sam said. She went back to the espresso machine. The thermometer beeped. "See? We're doing things."

Being told you were doing things was strange. It should have felt patronizing. Instead it felt like being handed a map in a country where you'd previously been wandering. Maya spent the rest of the afternoon feeling almost steady, if you ignored the invoice glowing on her laptop screen.

Maya did the afternoon accounts. The revenue was still down twelve percent from the previous Tuesday. The milk supplier had raised prices by two cents a gallon, which felt personal, as if someone had watched her pour latte after latte and decided she could afford to pay more for the privilege of steaming things. Sam had created a new chalkboard drawing that depicted Bean & Leaf as a dragon breathing \$2.50 lattes onto a village of indie coffee shops. Maya loved it. She photographed it and sent it to her sister, who replied immediately with a series of emoji that Maya was fairly certain constituted a coded language involving triumph, sadness, and what looked like a burning tree.

At four, a group of regulars came in and asked if they would still have a shop to support on Saturday. Maya made them all pour-overs and listened to them complain about Bean & Leaf for twenty minutes. It was both annoying and strange, and strange in a nice way. They weren't customers in the traditional sense. They were neighbors. They were people who'd watched her struggle and chosen to stay anyway. That kind of loyalty did not come from pour-overs. It came from something harder to explain. Something that had less to do with coffee and more to do with refusing to let the bad parts of the world win, one Tuesday at a time.

"Are you gonna be okay?" one of them — Rachel, a graphic designer who came in every morning before work — asked as she left.

"Yeah," Maya said. "We're doing fine."

"Good," Rachel said. "Because if you close, Sam is gonna burn down the neighborhood."

"Sam has plans for Bean & Leaf that are way worse."

"Love her for it."

At six, Maya locked the front door. The bell jingled one last time, as if bidding farewell. Maya flipped the sign to CLOSED and stood in the doorway for a moment, watching the street. A group of people walked by carrying shopping bags from the vintage stores down the way. A bike messenger rattled past, nearly colliding with a tourist who was looking at his phone and walking with the particular confidence of someone who'd never been to Portland before. The Portland evening settled around the shop with its particular hush — the hush of a city that had given up on the workday but hadn't quite started on the evening yet.

Maya went upstairs to her apartment above the shop. She had lived there for three years, and in that time she'd developed a theory: apartments above coffee shops were either magical or cursed, and hers was both. The magic came from being close to the source — she could wake up, walk downstairs, and be at work in thirty seconds. The curse came from never truly leaving work, from the smell of burnt milk following her into her dreams, from the knowledge that if the shop failed, she'd be unemployed and homeless at the same time. Sometimes, at 11 p.m., she could hear the refrigerator humming and it sounded the same as it had at 6 a.m. The days never really ended. They just changed font.

She made tea. She sat at her kitchen table and opened her laptop. She opened the draft of the email to Tom and stared at it. Then she deleted it and wrote a new one.

Subject: Re: Order Confirmation #48721 — Coffee Rescue on Alberta

Hi Tom,

I'm Maya from Coffee Rings on Alberta. I may have accidentally ordered 500 lbs instead of 50. I'm a small shop. This is more than my annual budget. I have three weeks. I have a community that cares about me. Can we talk about options?

Thank you,

Maya

She read it three times. It was honest. It was vulnerable. It was the kind of email that either opened doors or confirmed that the person on the other end was a bean-counting monster who took pleasure in small business suffering. She pressed Send before she could reconsider.

Then she did what she'd been avoiding all day: she opened her bank account. The balance was what she expected. It was lower than she expected. It was the kind of balance that made her wonder if she'd been doing math wrong for three years, or if math had simply stopped caring about her. She transferred money to savings without looking at the number, out of habit, and closed the app before she could feel anything about it.

She went to the window and looked down at Alberta Street. The lights were on in the shops across the way. The Thai restaurant next door was still serving; through its yellow window she could see the owners prepping lemongrass and the ghost of a television playing loudly. The bookstore two doors down had its reading light on, which meant the owner was either working late or had decided not to go home yet. Maya liked to imagine he was writing the great American novel and simply hadn't realized it yet.

Maya's phone buzzed. Sam, with a text message that contained only an emoji: a wine glass, followed by a clock, followed by a shrug.

Maya smiled. She replied with the same emoji, then added one more: a coffee cup with steam.

She went to bed early, which was her version of a crisis. Most people dealt with crises by staying up too late and drinking too much or sending texts they would regret. Maya handled crises by going to sleep before nine, as if the night would fix what the daylight had broken. It never did. But it helped.

Tomorrow she would call Tom. Tomorrow she would figure out whether five hundred pounds of Ethiopian was a disaster or an opportunity. Tomorrow she would prep for Saturday's fundraiser and try not to think about the fact that Bean & Leaf was expanding into her neighborhood with a pharmacy location that would open in two weeks at the old gas station, just three blocks away.

But tonight, she slept. For six hours, she was not a coffee shop owner with a crisis. She was just Maya, dreaming of nothing in particular — of a clean espresso machine and a bank account that did not yell at her — and when she woke up at 5:58 a.m., the first thought in her head was not fourteen thousand

dollars or Bean & Leaf or even the espresso machine that needed calibrating. It was: I need a shower.

And then, three minutes later: You have 500 pounds of coffee coming.

But she got the shower anyway.

Lying in bed afterward, she stared at the ceiling and thought about dumber things she had done before 7 a.m. She had once tried to make her own vanilla extract using a bottle of imitation vanilla and a bottle of vodka she found in the back of a cabinet, because she was certain the instructions said patience and she was going to be patient. She had once agreed to help Sam move a couch because Sam said it was only two blocks, and it was only two blocks, but the couch was made of something called bonded leather and industrial regret. She had once told a customer she could complete a complicated pour-over in under three minutes, and then she had done it, and the customer had tipped her twenty dollars, which was the most money she'd ever made for showing off.

Five hundred pounds of coffee was in a category of its own. It sat at the intersection of terrible idea and legitimate opportunity, and Maya was beginning to suspect that intersection was where most of her life decisions were parked. She thought about the fundraiser on Saturday, about the people who had offered to help, about how a neighborhood could decide, all at once, that you mattered. It made her chest feel tight in a pleasant way, the way a too-warm blanket does. She also thought about Leo Bianchi, about how he'd laughed at the right moments and known the right things and somehow, impossibly, not been terrible while wearing a suit that cost more than her car. She didn't trust it. She was fairly certain trust was overrated. But gratitude wasn't. Gratitude was just acknowledgment, and acknowledgment took no vows.

Her phone buzzed again at 9:14 p.m. Sam, with a photo of the wine they'd bought for no reason, sitting on the counter next to a cutting board and a half-eaten block of cheese. Maya stared at the photo for a long time. She had been alone with this problem for hours now, and it was still a problem, but somehow it felt different — like a problem that had been weighed and found not to crush her. She texted back: Tomorrow.

Then she put the phone down and opened a notebook on her laptop. She had a menu to plan. She had a fundraiser to prepare for. She had, impossibly, five hundred pounds of Ethiopian green coffee coming, and whether that was a curse or a gift would depend entirely on what she did next. She wrote lists. She wrote names. She wrote things she would say to Tom. She wrote things she would not say to Tom, mostly because they involved words like please and accidentally and I-am-so-sorry-I-ordered-300-percent-more-than-I-meant-to.

At 11:17, her laptop died. She plugged it in and went to bed. The sheets were cold and the pillow smelled like the shop, which was both comforting and depressing, depending on the hour. She closed her eyes. The silence of the apartment was a particular kind of silence, full of creaking floorboards and the distant sound of a television through the wall and the rhythm of her own breathing, which had been faster than normal for most of the day but was finally slowing down.

She was not fine. She was going to be fine. There was a difference, she was learning, and she had started to suspect the difference was the whole point of having a business and a best friend and a landlord who spoke in riddles and a random Bean & Leaf suit who might or might not be an actual human being.

Outside, a car alarm went off and was ignored by everyone in the city except her. Somewhere down the hall, someone closed a door and then opened it again, as if changing their mind. The refrigerator downstairs cycled on with its familiar sigh. Maya pulled the blanket over her shoulder and let the sounds carry her toward sleep. It came slowly. It came imperfectly. It came, which was enough.

Maya had been calling Bean & Leaf "the enemy" for so long that the phrase had worn smooth, like a stone in a river. It fit in her mouth comfortably. It required no explanation. When she said it, Sam nodded. When she wrote it on the chalkboard, customers chuckled. When she posted it on Instagram, people commented with fire emojis.

It was a useful enemy. Clear. Definite. A target you could point at and say: this is why we can't have nice things.

Then Leo Bianchi had walked into her shop and laughed at her pour-over section and somehow, inexplicably, not been entirely terrible. Now the enemy had a face, and the face was annoyingly symmetrical, and Maya was finding it difficult to maintain the proper level of animosity.

She tried. She really tried.

Monday morning arrived with the particular damp chill that Portland did in spring, the kind of morning that made you grateful for espresso and suspicious of people who claimed to enjoy it. The air felt like wet wool. The sky was the color of old concrete. Maya unlocked the shop at 6:45, humming the song she'd heard on the radio the night before — something about a highway, a woman, and a suitcase — and discovered that someone had taped a flyer to the front window.

It was a Bean & Leaf flyer. Clean. Minimalist. A single coffee cup on a white background, the Bean & Leaf serif logo above it, and below it the words: NEW LOCATION COMING SOON — ALBERTA STREET.

Maya stared at it. The flyer had been professionally printed on thick paper that felt expensive even through the glass. She touched it with her index finger. It was smooth. It was deliberate. It was a declaration of war disguised as a community announcement. She imagined the meeting where this had been approved, the designers in their clean boots, the marketing team nodding over gingham tablecloths, the CEO saying something about "planting roots" while someone made a spreadsheet about projected foot traffic and how many baristas they could underpay on their way to disrupting the local economy.

She took it down. She crumpled it. She threw it in the trash outside, where it landed on top of

yesterday's coffee grounds with a sound like surrender.

Sam arrived at 7:15, tilted her head at the trash can, and said, "You look like you just found out your favorite band is now doing insurance commercials."

"Bean & Leaf put a flyer on our door."

"Let me guess. Beige aesthetic. Pretentious font."

"Times New Roman-something. Very corporate. Very 'we care about community.'"

Sam leaned against the doorframe. Her apron was slightly askew. She'd clearly already been drinking coffee — Maya could tell by the way her eyes were already a little too bright, the way she was vibrating at a frequency that suggested either success or too much caffeine. "They're opening a pharmacy location. I heard that from my cousin who works at the health food store across the street. They're converting the old music venue. Can you believe that?"

The old music venue. Maya felt something cold and familiar settle in her chest, something that was not quite anger and not quite grief but a mixture of both, stirred together over years of watching Portland change. The venue had been there since before she moved to the neighborhood. She'd seen shows there. She'd danced there once, at a wedding reception that had taken over the whole place, and the band played a song so good she'd cried into her drink. The owner had been a man with a gray beard who said he didn't care about making money as long as he could keep the building. Bean & Leaf had probably looked at his lease and seen a spread of numbers instead of a life.

"The old music venue? That place has been there since before I moved to Portland."

"Since before anyone moved to Portland, probably. Bean & Leaf bought it. They're gutting it."

"Of course they are."

Maya turned back to the espresso machine. She started the boiler with more force than necessary. The machine hissed. Sam pushed off the doorframe and walked to the sink, where she began arranging her collection of thermometers with the care of a jeweler polishing diamonds.

"I saw Leo yesterday," Sam said, not looking up.

Maya's hands paused on the milk pitcher. "Leo who."

"Leo the suit. I was at the grocery store. He was buying a single apple. Just one. Like a cartoon character who's trying to convey 'I am a complicated man with simple tastes.'"

"You talked to him?"

"He said hi. I said hi. He asked how the shop was doing. I told him we were surviving."

Maya steamed milk. She tried to focus on the pitcher, on the microfoam that was coming out smoother than usual for a Monday, on the science of heating milk to 150 degrees without scalding it. She couldn't. "What did he say to that?"

Sam finally looked up. She was holding a thermometer like a microphone. "He looked sad. He looked like a man who's planning to buy a building and turn it into a pharmacy and who also might not want to do that."

Maya poured the milk into a latte. She didn't need to steam it. She just liked the motion, the circular swirl that turned white into light brown into something that was almost art. "He's Leo Bianchi, acquisitions director. He plans to buy buildings and turn them into pharmacies. That's literally his job."

"His job is also to smile at baristas and refer them to importers and buy single apples. I'm not saying he's not the enemy. I'm saying the enemy might have a backstory."

"The enemy's backstory is 'went to business school and now wants to put us out of business.'"

"Says the woman who threw his business card in the trash but still remembers what he looks like."

Maya turned. Steam was rising from the boiler. Sam was looking at her with the particular expression of a best friend who had been Best Friend for long enough to know when something was happening

even when the someone involved was denying it loudly.

"I do not still remember what he looks like."

"Right. And I don't remember what you looked like when he walked out that door. Face flushed. Eyes doing that thing they do when they're trying to memorize something. You stared at that card for, like, eleven seconds. I counted."

"You were watching me throw away a business card?"

"I was watching my best friend accidentally develop a crush on the enemy."

"It's not a crush. It's an observation."

"An observation that he's attractive."

"He's not attractive. He's... adequate."

"Adequate," Sam repeated, as if she were writing the word down for future reference, which Maya was fairly certain she was.

Maya turned back to the espresso machine. She started pulling a shot. The machine gurgled. The shot came out too fast. She tamped again, harder this time, as if the pressure of the tamp would tamp away the inconvenient fact that she had, in fact, stared at Leo's face for eleven seconds and might have committed it to the kind of memory that was not meant for business cards and trash cans. The portafilter clanged against the group head. The machine sighed. The brown stream hit the cup with its usual steady rhythm.

The morning rush hit at 8:30. By 9:15, Maya had forgotten about Bean & Leaf and Leo and everything that wasn't a latte or a cold brew or a customer who wanted something that wasn't on the menu but could be approximated with oat milk and enthusiasm. She moved through the motions with the particular trance that good baristas achieved — the state where hands did the work and the brain did something else, probably nothing, probably just observed. A woman ordered a flat white with an extra shot and a laminated card that said THANK YOU. A teenager asked if they had anything vegan and gluten-free and low-cafeine and Maya said "we have water" and the teenager said "that's perfect." A

man came in with a dog that sat politely under the table and Maya gave the dog a piece of biscotti and the man gave her an extra five dollars.

It was a good morning. It was a normal morning. It was a morning that felt, briefly, like the shop might actually survive its own mythology.

At 10:42, her phone buzzed. Tom.

Her stomach did something gymnastic. She picked up. "Hello."

"Maya? Tom here. From the green coffee."

"Hi, Tom. I've been dreading this call."

"Don't dread it. I've got two words for you: Mystery Bean Lottery."

Maya blinked. She was standing behind the counter. A customer was waiting. "Mystery Bean what."

"Lottery. You know what a coffee lottery is?"

"I know what a lottery is. I don't know what a coffee lottery is."

"Simple. You buy tickets. You sell mystery beans. The beans are your 500 pounds. You create combinations — single origin, blend, whatever — and you sell them as mystery tickets. Each ticket is a pound or half-pound. People buy them because it's fun. They feel like they're supporting a local shop. They feel like they might get something amazing. And you move the product before your loan officer starts calling with that particular tone of voice that suggests he's been saving it for a Tuesday."

Maya's brain started making connections. It was rusty. It had been three weeks since she'd done anything resembling strategic thinking. "The beans are already roasted?"

"Some are. Some aren't. You could roast a portion. You could blend. You could do whatever you want. The point is, people buy mystery. It's a gimmick. Gimmicks work."

"You're telling me to turn five hundred pounds of Ethiopian into a lottery."

"I'm telling you that you already have the beans and you already have the customers and the only thing you're missing is the gimmick part. I can help you source bags. I can help you print labels. I can help you not declare bankruptcy before your 30th birthday."

Maya laughed. It came out louder than she intended. A customer looked up from their laptop. "Sorry," she said to the customer. Into the phone: "You're really offering to help me turn a disaster into a lottery."

"I'm really offering to help a customer who can't afford beans she accidentally ordered turn into a customer who might just become something more. Also — and I should mention this last — the importer contact Leo gave you? That's me. Leo's been saying nice things about you. Said you're the real deal. Said you deserve a break."

The room tilted, just slightly. Maya leaned against the espresso machine. She had spent months thinking of Bean & Leaf as a monolith, a faceless force of gentrification and bad coffee served in cups that cost more than the coffee inside them. She had thought of Leo as a representative of that monolith, a suit with a caffeine allergy and a loyalty app. She had been wrong about at least one of those things, and she was beginning to suspect she'd been wrong about more.

"Thank you, Tom," she said. "I — I don't know what to say."

"Say yes to the lottery. Say yes to the importer relationship. Say yes to the fact that sometimes bad decisions lead to people who might actually help you."

Maya opened her eyes. She looked at the crumpled Bean & Leaf flyer in the trash can. She looked at the coffee bags stacked on the back shelf, each one a small biography of a place she'd never been and a farmer she'd never meet. She looked at the door, which was currently letting in a man who wanted a pour-over and who was already looking at his phone with the particular impatience of someone who believed coffee was a code for something else.

"Okay," she said. "Let's do the lottery."

"Send me an email. We'll sketch it out. I'll have labels by Friday. You'll have a gimmick by Saturday."

She hung up. She stood there for a moment, phone in hand, while the shop continued its choreography around her — the refrigerator humming, the grinder waking up for another customer, Sam saying something about milk that Maya didn't quite catch. She felt a strange lightness in her chest, the kind that came not from solving the problem but from realizing the problem might not actually be insoluble. It was the feeling of standing in a dark room and realizing you'd been holding a flashlight the whole time.

Sam appeared at her elbow with a clipboard that had clearly been commandeered from the fundraiser supplies. "You look like you just heard good news."

"Tom called. He has a plan."

"Tom the bean guy?"

"Tom the bean guy is not just the bean guy. He's also the guy Leo referred me to. The same guy Leo has been telling nice things about me to."

Sam's eyebrows climbed so high they almost left her face. "Well," she said. "The enemy has relatives. Or something."

"Something," Maya said. She picked up the portafilter and slung it into the group head. The machine hissed. The shot came out brown and beautiful. "Something like human."

By afternoon, she had designed the first Mystery Bean Lottery ticket. Sam had drawn a little coffee cup with a question mark on it. Maya had written the rules on the chalkboard, where they were visible to everyone who walked in:

MYSTERY BEAN LOTTERY

\$10 per ticket. Each ticket = 1/2 lb mystery roast.

Possible origins: Ethiopia, Colombia, Guatemala, Kenya, Blend.

We roast. You guess. You win bragging rights.

100% of proceeds go to LOCAL COFFEE RESCUE.

She wasn't sure what "Local Coffee Rescue" was yet, but she liked the sound of it. It sounded official. It sounded like something that had existed before she'd invented it and would exist after she was gone, a small temperature-stable institution in a neighborhood that kept changing its mind about what it wanted to be.

An older woman who came in every morning for chamomile tea read the board three times. Her glasses were slightly smudged, and she kept taking them off and wiping them on her cardigan. "Is this legal?"

"Of course it's legal," Maya said. "It's a lottery. There's no cash prize. It's just coffee. And bragging rights."

The woman considered this. She put a twenty-dollar bill on the counter. "Four tickets. And keep the change. I want to support the shop."

Maya took the money. She wrote the woman's name on four tickets. She thanked her. When she looked up, the woman was gone, and the bell above the door was still vibrating from her exit.

Maya sat on the stool and stared at the ticket in her hand. It was just paper. It was just an idea. But the cash in the register was real. The woman's trust was real. The feeling in Maya's chest was real.

"Stop looking at it like it's a holy scroll," Sam said, passing by with a tray of scones. "It's a piece of paper with coffee beans written on it."

"It's a miracle," Maya said.

"Close enough."

By closing time, they'd sold 73 tickets. It wasn't the massive influx Maya had dreamed of. It wasn't the kind of line that stretched around the block. But it was a beginning. It was a shape. It was the first time in three weeks she hadn't felt like she was staring at a wall and trying to convince herself it was a door.

She went home. She opened her laptop. She sent Tom a three-word email: "Let's do this."

Then she did something she hadn't done in months. She opened her calendar. She looked at the next week. She began to schedule things — roaster visits, pop-up prep, Saturday's fundraiser, a meeting with Tom on Friday. The calendar filled up. It looked, for the first time in a long time, like a life.

She went to bed at 10:30. She didn't dream about coffee beans. She didn't dream about Bean & Leaf or loan officers or floorboards that creaked in Morse code. She dreamed about the ocean, which was strange, because she hadn't seen the ocean in two years, but she dreamed about it anyway — waves, the particular gray-green of Oregon water, the way the beach smelled like salt and something alive. When she woke up, the invoice was still on her desk. But it didn't look the same. It looked like a starting point.

Later that night, after the calendar was full and the email to Tom had been sent and the wine had been poured into the good glasses — the ones with the stems she usually saved for nothing — Maya stood at the window of her apartment and looked down at the street. A car drove slowly past, music playing so quietly she could only hear the bass. A couple walked by holding hands and then suddenly not, as if they'd remembered they were fighting about something small and stupid. The Thai restaurant next door was closing up. The bookstore was dark. Alberta Street was not the loud, chaotic, wonderful place it had been that morning, but it was the same place, and that felt like enough.

She thought about Leo. She thought about how he'd looked when he'd ordered the black coffee, the way he'd talked about adjectives the way other people talked about heartbreak. She thought about the flyer in the trash. She thought about the old music venue and the new pharmacy location and the way neighborhoods kept changing whether you wanted them to or not. She thought about what Sam had said — the enemy has relatives — and she laughed softly, because it was true and also because it was funny and also because it was the kind of truth that could only come from someone who knew you better than you knew yourself.

She went to bed. The sheets were cool. The pillow still smelled like the shop. She closed her eyes. She didn't think about the money. She didn't think about the phone call. She thought, instead, about the coffee in the morning, about the way it smelled when it was fresh, about the people who would come in and buy tickets and drink mystery beans and feel, for a second, like something fun was happening to them instead of something terrible. She thought about possibility. It was a strange feeling. It didn't feel like hope. It felt, instead, like a muscle that had atrophied and was now being used again — stiff, a little sore, but alive.

When she woke up, the first thing she thought was: we need more tickets.

The second thing she thought: Leo was right about Tom.

The third thing she thought, and the one she kept to herself: maybe the enemy isn't always the enemy. Maybe the enemy is just a person who needs a better adjective.

She got out of bed. She opened the window. The morning air was cool and damp. The street was quiet. The shop below was humming. She drank water from the tap. She put on her apron. She opened the door to the stairs and went down to meet whatever the day brought.

Maya had never been fired. She had never been hired, technically — she'd bought the shop, which meant she'd hired herself, which meant she could fire herself but she preferred not to think about that option because it felt like quitting before she'd really started. Instead, she'd done what most small business owners did: she'd put in longer hours than any reasonable person would and called it passion.

The word "passion" felt like a lie. What she felt was closer to stubbornness with better lighting — the kind of stubbornness that made her scrub the espresso machine at midnight, that made her unwrap and rewrap pastry boxes at 5 a.m., that made her send thank-you notes to customers who'd tipped more than three dollars. It was a stubbornness she'd inherited from her mother, who had worked three jobs to send Maya to college and who still, at sixty-two, called every Sunday to ask if Maya had eaten vegetables.

Saturday's Coffee Rescue was three days away. The shop smelled like preparation — like coffee beans being sorted into small paper bags, like chocolate being melted for the bake sale table, like hope being measured out in cups and handed to strangers. Maya had started sorting the beans at 7 a.m. She'd brewed cupping bowls at 7:30. At 8:15, she was still sorting, her fingers dusted with chaff, her nose full of the complex, earthy smell of green coffee that hadn't decided what kind of night it wanted to be.

Sam arrived at 6 a.m. with a playlist and a box of folding chairs she'd borrowed from her cousin who worked at a church that doubled as a community space on weekends. The playlist was half gospel, half indie rock, a combination that Sam assured her was "spiritually necessary for fundraising." Maya didn't argue. Maya hadn't argued about playlists in years. She just nodded and handed Sam a clipboard and pretended she understood the assignment, which was mostly to make sure the chairs didn't collapse and that nobody tried to charge for water.

Maya arrived at 6:15 with a clipboard and the particular grim focus of someone who was about to ask her community for help. By 7:30, they had the space mapped out: folding chairs in rows that were too narrow for comfort but perfect for intimacy, card tables along the window displaying lottery tickets and baked goods and a handwritten sign that said WE APPRECIATE YOU, the espresso machine positioned like a shrine in the corner where everyone walking in could see it and feel, even subconsciously, that they were entering a special place.

"People need to see the shrine," Sam said, positioning the machine with the precision of an interior designer who'd been trained by church basements. "It's the altar."

"The altar to burnt milk and bad financial decisions."

"The altar to hope. Also burnt milk. Hope is a fuel. Burnt milk is a warning."

The first customers arrived at 8:15. They were mostly regulars, which was both comforting and terrifying — comforting because these were people who already loved the shop and had been bragging about it to their friends for months, terrifying because these were the same people whose loyalty Maya was about to test with a lottery and a hard luck story and a corner tucked away by the old music venue that would soon be a pharmacy. She stood behind the counter and made coffee and tried not to look at the door, because every time she looked at the door she thought about the flyer she'd taken down yesterday, the Bean & Leaf flyer, the pharmacy location, the music venue being gutted for a place that would sell lattes made by people who'd been trained for two weeks instead of three years. The thought made her hands shake slightly, which made her tamp too hard on one shot, which made the espresso come out bitter, which made her want to throw the cup across the room.

A man she didn't recognize came in at 8:42. He was wearing a Newsboy cap and a T-shirt that said I COFFEE IN A FONT THAT WAS DEFINITELY NOT HELVETICA. He had a backpack covered in patches from places Maya had never heard of. He bought a pour-over. He tipped five dollars. He said, "I saw the flyer. The lottery thing. Can I buy ten tickets?"

"Ten tickets," Maya said. "That's... a lot of tickets."

"I've been coming here for two years," the man said. "I'm not spending ten dollars on mystery beans. I'm investing in the shop."

Maya wrote his name on ten tickets. She wrote his phone number too, just in case he wanted to know when the drawing was. "Thank you," she said. "Seriously."

"Don't thank me yet. I want a Colombian blend."

"I'll keep that in mind."

By 10 a.m., they'd sold 150 tickets. By 11 a.m., 270. Maya had stopped counting cash and started counting customers, because the customers were nicer and the cash was just a number that made her palms sweat. An old man came in with his grandson, who was wide-eyed and clutching a dinosaur toy,

and they bought two tickets and the old man told Maya about the speakeasy days and how he'd once bought a cup of coffee from a man who'd later become a senator. Maya wasn't sure if it was true, but she liked it anyway. A group of teenagers came in and bought five tickets between them and then spent twenty minutes arguing about which coffee origin they hoped they'd get, which made Maya laugh so hard she had to stop steaming milk.

At 11:17, a woman walked in who Maya didn't recognize. She was carrying a camera and wearing a coat that looked expensive and sensible, like it had been purchased from a store that catered to women who did things like attend gallery openings and ride bicycles in bad weather. Her hair was pulled back in a way that suggested she was about to do something important and didn't want to be interrupted.

"I'm here for the fundraiser," the woman said. "My name is Claire. I write for the Portland Portland Observer. I heard about the lottery and I wanted to cover it."

Maya's stomach did a flip — not the bad kind, the good kind, the kind that came from surprise and pleasure and the sudden realization that she might be onto something. "Cover it? Like... a story?"

"Like a story. With pictures. With quotes. With the suggestion that people should come here and buy coffee and support a local shop that's apparently about to be swallowed by a chain that raises Series B to do boring things to our neighborhood."

Sam was suddenly beside her. She had a way of appearing beside Maya when something important was about to happen, as if she had a sixth sense for press coverage and the exact right thing to say once it arrived. "We'd love that," Sam said. "We had a chalkboard dragon yesterday. It was very on-brand."

Claire laughed. She had the kind of laugh that made people want to tell her things. "I'll photograph the dragon. I'll photograph the lottery machine — you do have a lottery machine, right?"

"We have... a shoebox," Maya admitted. "But it's a very organized shoebox."

"Perfect. Shoebox lotteries are very indie. Can I talk to you for ten minutes about your bean emergency?"

Maya looked at Sam. Sam nodded, once, sharp, the kind of nod that said I know this is big and you're going to be great. Maya looked back at Claire. "Yes. But only if you buy a ticket first."

Claire bought five. She interviewed Maya for eleven minutes. She took photos of the shop, the lottery tickets, the espresso machine, and the chalkboard dragon. She left with a latte and Maya's phone number. At 1 p.m., Maya's phone buzzed with an Instagram notification: Claire had posted a photo.

By 3 p.m., the post had 400 likes. People were tagging their friends. A woman commented, "I'll be there tomorrow." Someone else wrote, "This is why I love Portland." Maya read every comment. She liked some. She replied to others. She stared at the screen and tried not to cry, because crying in public was not a brand she was interested in cultivating.

By 5 p.m., they'd sold 412 tickets.

Maya sat on the stool by the window and counted the cash again. This time the number was large enough to feel almost real. It still wasn't fourteen thousand dollars. But it was a start. It was a direction. It was, she thought, the difference between waiting for a disaster and building a response to it.

She thought about the old version of herself, the one who'd stood in this same spot three years ago and signed the papers to buy the shop, who'd cried in the upstairs apartment for an hour afterward because she'd been so scared and so sure and so alone. That version of her wouldn't have believed this day. She wouldn't have believed the lottery or the post or the way the community had shown up, somehow, without being asked and sometimes without being noticed until it was too late to thank them properly.

When she told Sam about the Instagram numbers, Sam said, "We should frame the post. Not the photo — the numbers. Print them out. Tape them to the wall."

"We'll run out of wall."

"We have the back office."

"That's where I put my anxiety."

"Lately your anxiety is paying for itself."

It was a strange thing to admit, even silently: the anxiety was working. It was the engine. It was the

thing that made her look at the Bean & Leaf flyer and instead of despair, think: lottery. It was the thing that made her read Tom's email and think: maybe. It was the thing that made her look at the chalkboard dragon and think: we are going to fight this with humor because we have nothing else and humor is free and also because making fun of the enemy is spiritually necessary.

Sam came over with two glasses of wine she'd acquired from somewhere — either the bake sale or the depths of her bag, Maya wasn't sure, and she never was, which was part of the magic. "You did good today."

"Tom did good today. I just stood behind a counter and took money."

"Tom came up with the idea. You executed it. That's the hard part. The idea is 10 percent. The execution is 90 percent and 85 percent of that is just showing up."

Maya took the wine. She noticed her hands were shaking. She told herself it was the caffeine. It wasn't. "I talked to Leo again, by the way."

Sam raised an eyebrow. The eyebrow said so many things. It said tell me everything. It said I have opinions. It said also I'm making a mental note for later. "Oh."

"He sent me the whole apocalypse list. His contacts. His spreadsheets. His offer to come over and help me figure out logistics. I told him we had it under control."

"Did you?"

"Yes."

"Did you actually have it under control?"

"No. But I told him we did. And he believed me."

Sam laughed. She had one of those laughs that came from somewhere deep in the chest, the kind that made other people laugh without knowing why. "That's a good skill to have. The ability to bullshit a corporate suit."

"I can't believe he's actually helping me."

"I can't believe you're accepting help from a suit."

Maya looked out the window. Alberta Street was quieter now. The festival noise had faded into the ordinary evening sounds — a bus coughing, a couple arguing softly about where to eat, the distant thud of bass from a bar two blocks away. The last customer was leaving, holding a paper bag full of coffee. The streetlamp flickered on. Somewhere, a cat watched from a windowsill with the judgmental expression of a creature that had seen everything and was not impressed.

"Maybe," Maya said, "the enemy isn't always the enemy."

"Careful," Sam said. "That's how revolutions start."

They clinked their wine glasses together. Outside, the bell above the door jingled once, politely, as if the shop itself was saying goodnight. Maya watched the light change on the bricks across the street. She thought about Leo, about what Tom had said, about the possibility that she was being played and the equal possibility that she was being helped. She thought about the flyer in the trash. She thought about the old music venue, which would soon be something else, something beige and efficient and unmemorable. She thought about the coffee in her glass, which was cheap and okay and the best thing she'd tasted all day because she'd made it herself.

"Tomorrow," she said.

"Tomorrow," Sam agreed.

They stayed up late cleaning and planning and not saying the thing they were both thinking, which was: maybe this shop is going to make it after all. Maybe. Maybe. The word was smaller than hope, but it was easier to carry. It had weight. It had edges. You could hold it in both hands and actually believe it, for a little while, before the morning came and the doubt crept back in and the espresso machine started making its strange noises again.

But for tonight, they held it. They held it like something real. Maya washed the last glass. She locked

the door. She flipped the sign. She went upstairs to the apartment that smelled like coffee and old wood and the memory of every day she'd spent trying to do something she cared about in a city that kept telling her to stop. She took a shower. She ate bread and peanut butter standing over the sink. She looked at her phone. She didn't call Leo. She didn't call her mother. She just sat on the couch and turned on the TV and let the noise fill the room, the way you fill a jar with water before you pour it out, just to remind yourself you can.

Tomorrow, the shop would be full of people who'd come for a cause, and Maya would pour coffee for all of them, and she would wear her good apron, and she would not think about the loan for at least four hours. She would laugh. She would listen. She would not, under any circumstances, think about the almost-kiss in the shop, the way the air had felt warm and charged and impossible, the way she'd wanted to close the distance and hadn't known how or why or whether it was a good idea or a terrible one. She would not think about Leo's sleeves, wet with espresso water. She would not think about the way he had looked at her when he'd said he might tell Bean & Leaf the truth about the pharmacy, the way his face had been open and honest and a little sad, as if he'd been waiting for permission to do the right thing and had finally found it in a coffee shop on Alberta.

She went to bed. The sheets were cool. The pillow still smelled like the shop. She closed her eyes. She didn't think about the money. She didn't think about the phone call. She thought, instead, about the coffee in the morning, about the way it smelled when it was fresh, about the people who would come in and buy tickets and drink mystery beans and feel, for a second, like something fun was happening to them instead of something terrible. She thought about possibility. It was a strange feeling. It didn't feel like hope. It felt, instead, like a muscle that had atrophied and was now being used again — stiff, a little sore, but alive.

When she woke up, the first thing she thought was: we have a lot of chairs to set up.

The second thing she thought: Tom's labels are going to be here today.

The third thing she thought, and the one she kept to herself: I want to see him again.

She got out of bed. She opened the window. The morning air was cool and damp, the kind of air that made you grateful for walls and a roof and a reason to be warm. The street was quiet. The shop below was humming. She drank water from the tap. She put on her apron. She opened the door to the stairs and went down to meet whatever the day brought.

Later that afternoon, when the festival crowd had thinned and the mad rush became a gentle flow of stragglers with coffee in hand and pastries in paper bags, Maya stepped outside to breathe. The air was

thick with the particular scent of a Portland spring — rain that hadn't quite stopped, earth that was warming up, coffee that had conquered the block. She leaned against the brick wall of the building next door and closed her eyes.

"Hey," someone said.

Maya opened her eyes. It was Claire, the reporter from the Observer. She was sitting on a folding chair, typing rapidly on her laptop, and she looked up with a smile. "I've got two thousand words," she said. "And I haven't even written the lede."

"You're fast."

"I'm paid to be fast. Also, your story is really good. People love a comeback narrative. They love a loser who fights back."

"Loser," Maya repeated.

"Not in a bad way. In a narrative way. The underdog. The small shop taking on the big chain. It's everything."

Maya took it as a compliment. She wasn't sure it was one. "The chain isn't the villain," she said. "It's just... bigger."

"That's the story. Not villainy. Just scale. And community pushing back. It's classic."

They talked for another twenty minutes. Claire asked questions about the loan, about the lottery, about Leo. Maya answered honestly but carefully, leaving out the kiss and the fight and the particular knot of feelings she was still trying to untangle. Claire wrote. She wrote fast. She wrote with the particular intensity of a journalist who'd found a story that felt alive, that had teeth and heart and a protagonist who wasn't playing the part of a hero but was, instead, just trying to pay her rent.

By evening, the shop was emptying. The last customer left at 6:42 — Maya noted the time because her phone died at 6:42 once and she'd never forgotten. Sam locked the front door. Maya stacked the last of the Mystery Bean tickets. Leo was already gone — he'd left at 5:30 to take a call, saying he'd be back in the morning.

Maya went upstairs alone. She made tea — chamomile, because she was trying to sleep — and she sat at the kitchen table and stared at the spreadsheet. The numbers were better now. Not good. Not fixed. Better. The difference was small but it was there, like a candle in a dark room.

She opened her email. She saw a message from Tom: photos of the roasted beans, laid out on a table, looking beautiful and dangerous and expensive. He'd written: "These are going to change your life. Or at least your revenue."

Maya laughed. She replied: "Looking forward to it. Can't wait to sell them all and stop being a 500-pound emergency."

Tom wrote back: "You're not an emergency. You're a customer who ordered ambitiously."

She liked that. She saved the email. She closed the laptop. She went to the window and looked down at the street, still wet from the afternoon rain, reflecting the lights from the shops. She thought about Mrs. Hsu's floorboards and the speakeasy and the storytelling and the way old things held onto their stories even when the people who'd lived them were gone.

She thought she'd like this shop to be that kind of place someday. Not a speakeasy — well, maybe a speakeasy, if the neighborhood ever needed one again. But a place with stories. A place people remembered. A place that mattered.

She went to bed at 10:30. She slept. When she woke at 5:58, the first thought in her head was: Today is the day we open the pop-up.

The second thought was: I miss Leo already.

She didn't like the second thought. She sat with it anyway.

By day seven of the partnership, Maya had developed a theory: Leo was not a bad person. He was a person who had made a series of bad decisions, the first of which was going to business school and the most recent of which was working at Bean & Leaf, a company whose mission statement apparently included the phrase "ethical sustainability" and was followed by seventeen adjectives that Maya suspected were written by someone who had never actually met a farmer.

The theory was not comfortable. It sat in her chest like a stone that hadn't quite decided whether to sink or float.

She told Sam the theory on Day Three, during a particularly slow afternoon when the only customer was a man who'd been sitting at the window table for two hours working on what appeared to be a screenplay about time-traveling accountants. Sam had listened, nodded, and said, "So you're saying the enemy is essentially a doodle."

"I'm saying the enemy is a person who's also a corporate suit and I don't know how to categorize that. It's like finding out a tiger is vegan."

"Tigers aren't vegan."

"That's my point."

Leo arrived at the shop at 8:15 a.m. on Day Eight, carrying a laptop bag and a thermos that looked like it had seen things. He was wearing the same gray sweater he'd worn on Tuesday, which Maya noticed and then immediately chastised herself for noticing.

"Morning," Leo said. He set his bag on the floor beside the counter and surveyed the shop. "You've got good foot traffic here. The window displays are strong."

"Thank you," Maya said, not sure whether this was a compliment or the opening of a hostile takeover conversation. "Can I get you coffee?"

"Is that rhetorical?"

"I'll take it as a yes."

She made him a pour-over — the good stuff, the Yirgacheffe she'd been saving for people she liked, which was a category that currently included Sam, Mrs. Hsu, and, apparently, Leo. She set the mug down. He took a sip. He closed his eyes.

"Better than my office coffee," he said.

"Your office coffee is probably from a machine that costs more than our espresso setup."

"More. And it has a touchscreen. The touchscreen had a software update last week and now it asks me if I want to personalize my brew profile. I have a brew profile."

"What's your brew profile?"

"Mildly annoyed."

Maya laughed. She tried to make it short, the kind of laugh that said this is not a big deal, but it came out longer, warmer, than she intended. She turned away to hide the fact that she'd laughed, which was a move she'd perfected in high school and had never needed to use professionally until now.

They got to work. The plan, such as it was, involved turning the 500 pounds of Ethiopian into a Mystery Bean Lottery with multiple prize tiers and a referral program. Tom was handling the roasting. Leo was handling the logistics and the brand communication — the part that Maya kept trying to do herself and then failing because the words came out sounding either too defensive or too resigned.

"Here's the thing," Leo said, opening his laptop and showing her a spreadsheet that was, to Maya's eyes, both beautiful and terrifying. "We don't have to choose between mystery and transparency. We can have mystery now and then reveal what the beans actually were. People like transparency. People like mystery. People like knowing that they're getting something good without having to research it."

"That sounds like marketing."

"It is marketing. But it's good marketing. It's the difference between 'we have good beans' and 'we have good beans and here's a story about where they came from.'"

Maya looked at the spreadsheet. The columns were neat. The rows were color-coded. It was, she had to admit, nicer than anything she'd ever made herself. "You made this last night."

"After the lottery idea, yeah."

"How late did you stay up?"

"Late enough to question my career choices. Late enough to consider moving to a cabin in Montana where no one would ask me to run a coffee lottery."

Maya smiled. The smile felt like a rebellion. "Montana's nice. I have a cousin in Missoula. She says the coffee is terrible but the mountains make up for it."

"I can work with that."

They worked through the morning. Maya learned things about Leo: he was quiet when he concentrated, that his left hand was slightly more dexterous than his right when typing, that he hummed old rock songs while he read. Leo learned things about Maya: she was better at numbers than she let on, that she had a system for organizing the coffee bags that was based on alphabetical order by roast level, that she turned up the radio when she was happy and turned it off when she was concentrating.

By 11 a.m., they had a plan. By 11:30, they had a name: "The 500-Pound Rescue." By noon, they had a hashtag: #SaveTheBeans. Maya wanted to object to the hashtag on principle, but Sam said hashtags were the new street art and Maya had learned not to argue with Sam about marketing.

Lunch was Thai food from the place down the block. They ate on the counter while customers filtered in and out. Maya watched Leo eat papaya salad with the particular care of a man who had spent most of his adult life eating at desk lunches and was now discovering that lunch could be something you enjoyed rather than something you survived.

"This is good," Leo said.

"I eat here every day. I'm an expert."

"You're an expert at suffering?"

"I'm an expert at being the person who suffers through bad Thai food because there's no other option within walking distance."

"There's a taco truck now."

"I'm aware. I'm saving the taco truck for a crisis."

They talked about Bean & Leaf in a way that felt strange. Maya told him about the pharmacy location — she'd heard from a customer that the permit had been approved, that the contractor had been seen measuring the old music venue, that the sign would go up next week. Leo didn't say much. He nodded. He finished his papaya salad. He said, "I didn't know about the pharmacy."

"That was a lie."

"It wasn't a lie. I genuinely didn't know."

"Then you're bad at your job."

"I'm taking personal days to help you with a 500-pound coffee emergency. My job is currently on the back burner."

Maya looked at him. Really looked at him, the way she'd looked at him on the first day and then forced herself not to look again. He was wearing a sweater that had seen better wash cycles. His hair was not precisely unkempt today; it was the kind of unkempt that suggested he'd run his hands through it a few times without thinking. He looked tired. He looked honest.

"You're being honest with me," Maya said.

"I am."

"About the pharmacy?"

"About everything."

Maya wanted to believe him. The wanting felt like standing at the edge of a cliff and deciding whether to jump. "Okay," she said. "I'll take the honesty. But if you lie to me about anything else — anything — I'm throwing you out of the shop. No warnings."

"Understood."

They went back to work. The afternoon passed in the usual coffee-shop blur — the grind, the pour, the small conversations with strangers who became regulars by the time they left. Maya watched Leo help a customer pick a Mystery Bean ticket. She watched him explain the lottery to a tourist who'd wandered in from the street. He was patient. He was kind. He was, Maya had to keep reminding herself, a suit.

At 6:15, the shop was empty. The light was gold and thin. Maya was wiping the counter when Leo came over. He wasn't leaving. He was just standing there, with his arms crossed and his chin resting on one hand, watching her work.

"You have coffee on your apron," he said.

"I always have coffee on my apron."

"It's a good look."

Maya looked down. There was, in fact, a small brown stain shaped like a coffee ring on the left side of her apron. She'd had it for three years. It had become a sort of badge. "It's my signature."

"It's a brand."

She looked at him. "That line again."

"It's a good line."

They stood close enough that Maya could smell his sweater, which smelled like wool and coffee and something clean and faintly herbal, like the soap he used. She felt something in her chest that was not fear and not quite hope but something in between — the feeling of standing on a step that you didn't know was there until your foot found it.

"Leo," she said.

"Yeah."

She didn't know what she was going to say. She was going to say something about the shop or the lottery or the fact that she'd been wrong about him. She was going to say one of those things. But before she could choose, the espresso machine made a sound that was not good.

It was a sound that Maya recognized instantly and with a specificity that came from three years of intimate machine-knowing. It was the sound of a gasket failing, the sound of something that had been over-pressurized and was now giving up.

She turned. The machine was hissing. A thin stream of water shot upward, arcing beautifully, tragically, toward the ceiling.

"Shit," Maya said.

Leo moved. He didn't think. He just moved, reaching for a towel, grabbing the machine's pressure valve, twisting it with a strength that surprised her. The hissing stopped. The water stopped. The machine sighed, the way machines do when they've been saved from their own ambition.

Maya stared at the espresso machine. She stared at Leo, whose sleeves were now wet and whose expression was one of mild astonishment. "How did you do that?"

"Grew up with old trucks. You learn to listen to engines."

"Espresso machines aren't trucks."

"They're both things that break unexpectedly and require someone who isn't afraid to get their hands dirty."

Maya laughed. She laughed because it was true and because Leo's sleeves were wet and because he was standing in front of her with his sleeves wet and she wanted, suddenly and viscerally, to kiss him, and the thought of that was so overwhelming that she laughed to keep from doing it.

She laughed. Leo smiled. The moment hung in the warm air of the shop like a held breath.

Then the bell above the door jingled. A customer walked in. The moment broke.

Maya turned to the counter. "What can I get you?"

The customer ordered a latte. Maya made the latte. Leo stood beside her, sleeves still wet, and watched, and whenever their hands brushed — reaching for the same pitcher, the same cup — Maya felt it, a small electric jolt that had nothing to do with the espresso machine.

When the customer left, Leo said, "I should go. I have a meeting at Bean & Leaf that I'm not looking forward to."

"About the pharmacy location?"

"Probably. I haven't decided whether to tell them that I know it's ruining a neighborhood I've grown fond of."

"Tell them."

Leo smiled. It was the real smile, the one with the crinkles. "I'll tell them. Tomorrow. And then I'll be unemployed."

"We'll hire you."

He left. Maya stood at the counter for a moment, watching the door close. She was 29 years old. She had a 500-pound coffee emergency. She had a shop that was both failing and being rescued. She had, in the last seven days, communicated more with a Bean & Leaf employee than she had with any human being who wasn't Sam or her sister.

And she wanted to kiss him.

The latter was the most terrifying of all.

She wiped the counter again. She looked at the espresso machine, which had stopped breathing hard and was now just emitting its normal wheeze. She picked up the portafilter. She slung it into the group head.

"Tomorrow," she said to the empty shop, as if the shop could understand and agree.

Tomorrow, she would tell Leo to tell Bean & Leaf the truth about the pharmacy. Tomorrow, she would figure out whether her feelings were fear or hope or the coffee speaking. Tomorrow, she would continue to be the owner of a shop that smelled like burnt milk and consequences and, now, like something else — something warmer, like the possibility that enemies could become something else.

Tomorrow was a long time away.

She closed the shop early. She went upstairs. She poured herself a glass of wine. She sat at the kitchen table and stared at the Mystery Bean Lottery spreadsheet Leo had made. It was good. It was professional. It was exactly what she needed.

She also thought about his sleeves, wet with espresso water, and the way he'd moved without thinking to stop the machine.

She was in trouble.

The kiss changed things. It changed nothing and everything simultaneously, the way meaningful moments often do — altering the atmosphere without moving the furniture.

By Thursday, they'd settled into a rhythm that was mostly professional and strangely intimate, as if the kiss had given them permission to cross a boundary they hadn't known was there. Leo still arrived at 8 a.m. with his thermos and his notebook. Maya still poured the coffee before he ordered it. But now their hands brushed when they reached for the same cup. Now their voices dropped when the shop was empty. Now there was a hum in the air, a frequency that wasn't quite music but wasn't silence either.

Sam noticed immediately. Sam had always noticed everything. On Thursday morning, she arrived at the shop with a box of pastries from the bakery and a look on her face that said I am watching and I have opinions.

"Kiss," Sam said. She said it as a statement, not a question.

Maya didn't look up from the milk pitcher. "Kiss."

"Kiss. The one yesterday. The one near the espresso machine."

"It was not near the espresso machine. It was in the middle of the shop."

"Semantics. You kissed him. How was it."

Maya turned. She faced Sam. She said, "It was real. And it was good. And I don't know what it means."

"I know what it means. It means you two are finally doing the thing you've been doing since he walked in that door with his navy suit and his black coffee and his face that you couldn't stop thinking about."

"I wasn't thinking about his face."

"Right. You were just memorizing it for fourteen seconds. For business purposes."

Maya laughed. She couldn't help it. Sam had a way of making everything both funny and true. "It's complicated."

"Love is complicated," Sam said. "So is running a coffee shop during a 500-pound emergency. We're complicated people running a complicated shop in a complicated neighborhood. Complicated things can still work out."

Maya thought about that. She thought about the kiss, the way Leo's mouth had tasted like coffee and something warm and clean, like the soap he used or the food he ate or just the particular scent of a person who was honest and tired and trying. She thought about the loan, the timeline, the Bean & Leaf shadow that was growing longer every week. She thought about the future she'd imagined for the shop, the one that didn't include a relationship with a corporate suit and definitely didn't include kissing him in public.

She also thought about how much she wanted to kiss him again.

At 10 a.m., Leo arrived carrying a plant. It was a small succulent in a terracotta pot. He set it on the counter. "For the shop," he said. "To replace the one that died last week. The one you forgot to water."

"The one was sad," Maya said. "It deserved better."

"This one has a tag," Leo said. "Water once a week. Don't overthink it."

Maya picked up the tag. It said: "For Coffee Rings. May this plant live longer than our first partnership."

She laughed. She kissed him, quickly, on the cheek. "You're ridiculous."

"I'm romantic in spreadsheet form."

By afternoon, they'd developed a working protocol: Leo handled the spreadsheets and the social media posting and the community outreach. Maya handled the coffee and the customers and the roasting schedule with Tom. They met at the counter every two hours to review numbers. They fought about the hashtags. They compromised on the music. They made coffee for each other without being asked.

At 6:30, the shop was empty. They were wiping down the counter together — a task that had once been Maya's alone, a ritual she'd performed in silence while thinking about the next day, the next week, the next crisis. Now it was shared. It was quiet in a different way. It was comfortable.

Leo stopped wiping. He looked at her. "Can I ask you something."

"Depends on the something."

"Are we... are we doing this? The thing. The partnership. The kissing. All of it."

Maya stopped wiping too. She set down the rag. She looked at him — at the coffee stain on his sweater, at the notebook on the counter, at the succulent that was already looking healthier than the previous succulent had at this stage. "Yes," she said. "I think we are."

"Good," Leo said. "Because I don't want to do it halfway."

"Neither do I."

He reached for her hand. Their fingers interlocked. It was a small gesture in a busy world, a quiet thing that said more than words could. They stood there for a moment, hands joined, the counter between them, the shop dark and warm and still.

"I should go," Leo said.

"Stay. Help me finish the inventory."

"I have a meeting tomorrow about the pharmacy. I need to prepare."

Maya's smile faltered. "You're still going to that meeting."

"I have to. It's my job. Or it was my job. I'm still technically employed until Friday."

"Tell them."

"I will. Tomorrow. I'll tell them I can't support the Alberta project. I'll tell them why."

Maya squeezed his hand. "Be careful."

"I'm always careful."

He wasn't always careful. She knew this. She'd seen him leap into action when the espresso machine had blown its gasket. She'd seen him make decisions with his heart. But she let him go at 8 p.m. anyway, and she stood at the door and watched him walk down the street, and she thought about the kiss, and the partnership, and the way some things — like good coffee, like good people — couldn't be rushed or forced or managed on a spreadsheet.

They just happened.

She went upstairs. She opened the laptop. She updated the Mystery Bean lottery page with a new note: "Partnership update: Leo Bianchi, acquisitions professional and former Bean & Leaf employee, has officially joined Coffee Rings as a volunteer consultant. He brings spreadsheets, playlists, and an inexplicable talent for selling mystery beans. Welcome, Leo."

She wrote it with a smile. She posted it. She went to bed.

She dreamed that night of a garden — not the shop, not a garden, but a place between the two, where coffee plants grew in rows and the air smelled like rain and possibility. She was walking through it with

Leo. They were talking about something unimportant. She woke up before it ended.

The Mystery Bean Lottery launched on a Friday.

Maya had designed the tickets herself. She'd printed them on the shop's creaky inkjet printer, which had survived three years of ink cartridges and occasional threats of being replaced with something modern. The tickets were quarter-sheet paper, perforated with a serrated edge that Maya had achieved by folding the paper and running it through the printer twice. They said:

MYSTERY BEAN LOTTERY

Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions

\$10 / ticket = 1/2 lb mystery roast.

Roast: Single Origin or Blend.

Origin: Ethiopia, Colombia, Guatemala, Kenya, or Surprise.

100% proceeds → Local Coffee Rescue.

Winner gets bragging rights and first dibs on beans.

#SaveTheBeans

She'd used a bright orange marker to color the edges, because orange was the color of urgency and also because it was the only highlighter she had left. Sam had said the tickets looked like something a child would make for a bake sale. Maya had said that was the point. Real coffee shops didn't have lottery tickets. Bean & Leaf didn't have lottery tickets. Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions was not a real coffee shop in the way that mattered to bean-counting executives. It was a speakeasy with better espresso.

Tom arrived at 9:30 a.m. with a truck. Not a small truck. A medium-sized truck that said RIVIERA & SONS on the side and that contained, Maya discovered upon opening the rear door, exactly 500 pounds of green coffee in jute bags, each bag stamped with a origin and a weight and a small sticker that said FARMER COOP #47.

"Half of these are already roasted," Tom said, leaning against the truck door. "I finished the batch yesterday. The other half I'm leaving green. You can roast what you need as you go."

"I have a roaster," Maya said, "but it's the size of a toaster oven."

"Then we'll roast in batches. Small batches. Like you're running a real operation instead of a shop with

a payroll that consists of you and your one employee."

Maya looked at the truck. She looked at the jute bags. Each bag was roughly the size of a small person. There were fifty of them. Fifty bags of coffee that she had accidentally purchased and that Tom was now either returning or staying in her parking lot with, she couldn't tell which.

"What's the plan?" she said.

"The plan is we sell these through the lottery over the next four weeks. We also set up a table outside the shop on weekends. We make the experience part of the draw. People come for the story. They stay for the coffee. They tell their friends. Their friends buy tickets. It snowballs."

"That sounds like a plan that requires me to be social."

"You're already social. You run a coffee shop."

"I run a coffee shop in which the primary form of social interaction is 'latte down, table four.'"

"Latte down is social," Tom said. He was smiling. It was a smile that suggested he'd had this conversation before, with other small shop owners, and that he knew how it ended. "Trust me. The lottery works. I've seen it. I helped another shop in Bend move three hundred pounds of accidental Yirgacheffe last year. They're still selling the mystery blend."

"Bend has a smaller population than Portland."

"Portland has more people who will buy mystery coffee out of solidarity."

That was, Maya had to admit, a fair point.

They unloaded the truck. Sam appeared at 10:15, having just finished the morning prep, and stared at the jute bags stacked along the wall. "Is that all coffee?"

"All the coffee," Maya said.

Sam picked up a bag. It was heavy. "We should start a GoFundMe."

"We already have a lottery."

"GoFundMe would have been faster."

"This is more dignified."

"Dignity doesn't buy espresso machines."

Tom laughed. He was a man who laughed easily, which Maya liked. People who laughed easily were usually not the kind of people who called you at 8 a.m. to discuss terms. "I'll be back on Saturday with the roasted bags. You'll have the lottery ready?"

"Lottery will be ready," Maya said. "Tickets are printed. Stamps are... handmade. It'll be rustic."

"Rustic is good. Rustic is authentic."

Tom drove away. Maya stood in the doorway and watched the truck turn onto Alberta and disappear. The jute bags were stacked behind her. The shop smelled like coffee and possibility and also like burnt milk because Sam had forgotten to wash the steam wand again.

Saturday arrived with rain. Perfect, Maya thought. Rain always made the festival better — the kind of rain that was light enough to keep people outside but soft enough to make them seek coffee. It was Portland rain, the rain that had made the city what it was and that most residents wore like a second skin.

The Coffee Rescue was set up by 8 a.m. Tables. Chairs. A banner Sam had made with construction paper and a marker that said COFFEE RINGS AND BAD DECISIONS — WE'RE DOING FINE, THANK YOU. The espresso machine hummed. The Mystery Bean Lottery tickets were arranged in a wooden box that Maya had found in the back room and that had probably held old receipts at some point.

The first person to buy a ticket was Mrs. Hsu.

Maya stared at her. Mrs. Hsu was standing at the table with an umbrella and a raincoat that looked like it had been purchased before Maya was born. She held a ten-dollar bill.

"Mrs. Hsu," Maya said. "You don't have to —"

"I know I don't have to. I want to. And I want three tickets. And I want the espresso."

Maya wrote three tickets. She made the espresso. Mrs. Hsu drank it standing up, looking out at the rain. "Your floorboards are still storytelling," she said.

"Mrs. Hsu, I need to tell you about the beans."

"Later. Coffee first."

By 9 a.m., the line was ten people deep. By 10 a.m., a local TV station had arrived — not to do a story, but because a producer had seen Claire's Instagram post and had decided this was the kind of soft human-interest story that filled a weekend slot. They interviewed Maya for seven minutes. She talked about the lottery and the 500 pounds and the rescue and the community. The producer said, "So it's like Oceans Eleven, but with coffee?"

"Something like that," Maya said.

The piece aired at noon. By 1 p.m., the shop had sold out of pastries. By 2 p.m., the lottery tickets were gone. By 3 p.m., Maya had raised \$4,120 — not enough to cover the full \$14,200, but enough to make the spreadsheet look less like a suicide note and more like a plan.

Leo showed up at 3:30, carrying a portable speaker and a playlist Sam had texted him. He set up the speaker on the folding table and played music that was exactly the kind of music that made customers buy more coffee — gentle, familiar, not intrusive. He stood at the counter for two hours and sold Mystery Bean tickets with the focus of a man who had been trained in sales technique and who was

now applying it to something that was definitely not a sales technique but rather a community rescue.

By 5 p.m., when the rain had stopped and the festival was winding down, Maya sat on a folding chair and counted the total cash. \$4,872. Seventy percent of the way there. Tom had texted an hour ago to say that the roasted beans would be ready next week. Claire from the Observer had called to say the story would run on Monday. Sam was asleep on a couch in the back room.

Leo sat beside her. They didn't talk. They watched the street. The rain had left everything shiny and wet and reflective, and the light was the kind of gold that only exists in Portland for about twenty minutes a day, and Maya felt, with a sudden and almost unbearable precision, that she was exactly where she was supposed to be.

She looked at Leo. He was watching the street too, his expression unreadable. "This worked," she said.

"Partly," Leo said. "The rest is logistics."

"The rest is also feelings."

Leo turned to her. "Which feelings."

Maya's mouth opened. Then it closed. She had been about to say something true, something she'd been wanting to say since Day Three when she'd realized he was not what she'd expected. Instead, she said, "The feeling that we should get coffee tomorrow."

Leo smiled. "Tomorrow is Sunday. The shop will be closed."

"Then Monday."

"Monday I have a meeting about the pharmacy location. I'm going to tell them my honest opinion. Which is that it's a terrible idea and they should find another building."

Maya looked at him. She had a sudden vivid image of Leo standing in a boardroom, telling executives that their plan was bad, and then getting fired, and then showing up at her shop with his severance package and his navy suit and his espresso-making skills. It was an image that made her chest tight.

"You're really going to tell them," she said.

"I'm really going to tell them. I'm not going to watch that venue get turned into a pharmacy while the neighborhood loses the only music space it has left. Not for a paycheck. Not for anything."

Maya felt something break in her chest — not a bad breaking, not the kind that came from poor financial decisions, but the kind that came from realizing that someone you'd written off as an enemy was actually the person who might save the things that mattered.

She reached across the gap between them. She touched his hand. Just for a moment. A quick, electric touch that said something she wasn't ready to say out loud.

Leo's hand closed around hers. Not tightly. Just enough. Enough to say he understood.

The moment lasted three seconds. Then Sam appeared from the back room, yawning, and said, "Coffee break? I call dibs on the last croissant."

The moment broke. Maya pulled her hand back. Leo stood up. They both went to the counter. The espresso machine hissed. The music played. The rain had stopped, and the evening was beginning, and Maya had never felt more cautiously hopeful.

She had work to do. But for the first time in months, the work felt like something she chose rather than something she was running from.

Maya opened the shop the next morning with a new philosophy: the lottery was not a desperate measure. It was a new way of doing business. It was a model. It was, she told herself, the future of local retail.

She was, of course, lying. But it was a useful lie.

The lie helped her post on social media with confidence. It helped her smile at customers who bought tickets with the particular enthusiasm of people who felt like they were part of a movement. It helped

her stand at the counter and look Bean & Leaf flyers in the eye — metaphorically — and say: "We are not afraid of you."

Sam, who had successfully operated a rebellion inside a corporate office before becoming a barista, understood the value of useful lies. "My last job," she said, "consisted of ninety percent useful lies. The other ten percent was meetings about the lies."

The day was long. Maya worked the front. Leo worked the back, on a spreadsheet that was now two pages long and included a section called "Community Engagement Strategy." Tom arrived at noon with the first roasted batch. He'd developed three Mystery Bean blends:

1. "The Wildcard" — single-origin Ethiopian, unpredictable, bright.
2. "The Smooth Operator" — Colombian, chocolatey, reliable.
3. "The Triple Threat" — a blend of all three origins, designed for people who couldn't choose.

"Blend number three is my favorite," Tom said. "But don't tell the other blends. They have feelings."

"You're a romantic," Maya said.

"I'm a roaster. Romantics make better coffee."

By 3 p.m., the pop-up setup outside the shop was complete — folding tables, banners, the roaster humming its particular song of ambition and heat. Maya stood at the window and watched the street. People were stopping. They were taking photos. They were asking questions. A group of teenagers stopped and bought seven tickets and then posted about it on TikTok, which was exactly the kind of organic marketing Maya had been hoping for and which she now realized she had no control over, which was both terrifying and exhilarating.

Leo appeared beside her. "They're here," he said. "The food blogger. Eater Portland."

"Are they going to write about us?"

"They already messaged. They want fifteen minutes with you and the roaster."

"Fifteen minutes of fame," Maya said. "I can do fifteen minutes."

She did fifteen minutes. She told the story again. She told it better this time. She let herself be seen — the tired parts, the honest parts, the parts where she talked about the loan and the stress and the particular way running a small shop felt like holding water in your hands. The blogger wrote. The camera rolled. The afternoon sun came through the window and made the coffee steam glow.

At 5:30, customers still streamed in. The Mystery Bean Lottery was reaching its end — they'd printed 400 tickets and were down to the last hundred. Maya had decided, without consulting anyone, that they'd do a second run. The beans were there. The demand was there. The community was there. Why stop?

She told Leo. He said, "We need to check the inventory."

"I already checked. We have enough for another two hundred tickets. Maybe more."

"Then we run more tickets."

They ran more tickets. They ran them until 7 p.m., when the light went and the street got cold and the last customer bought the last ticket and Maya signed their name in a notebook that had become, without anyone really planning it, a registry of the people who'd saved the shop.

She stood in the doorway after closing and watched the street. She saw the Bean & Leaf pharmacy sign, half-installed, its blue-and-white letters spelling out something that was supposed to represent progress but which Maya saw as a warning. She saw the music venue, dark and boarded up. She saw the Thai restaurant, lit and warm. She saw a woman walking a dog that was too big for the neighborhood, which was somehow exactly right.

Leo came out. He stood beside her. He didn't say anything for a long time. Then he said, "We should talk about the Bean & Leaf offer."

Maya stiffened. "I don't want to talk about that."

"We have to talk about it. It's not going away."

"I know it's not going away. That's why I don't want to talk about it. Talking makes it real. Not talking makes it... less real."

"That's not a strategy."

"It's my strategy."

Leo sighed. He was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "I have something else to tell you. Something about the pharmacy location."

Maya turned to him. "What about it."

Leo looked at the street. He looked at the Bean & Leaf sign. He looked, Maya thought, like a man who was about to say something that would change things. "David Park — my old boss — he didn't just come to your pop-up to offer you a buyout. He came because he was worried. About the project. About the neighborhood. About the fact that some of us on the acquisitions team thought the pharmacy was a bad idea from the start."

"Then why is it happening."

"Because the CEO wants it. Because the numbers look good on paper. Because nobody asked the neighborhood what it wanted."

Maya stared at him. "You knew."

"I knew. I've known for months. I couldn't say anything. Not as Leo Bianchi, acquisitions director. Not without getting fired. But now I'm not anymore. So I can say it."

"You're fired."

"I resigned. Effectively. I'm in the two-week notice period. After that, I'm unemployed and enthusiastic

about coffee."

Maya laughed. It was a short, sharp sound. "You resigned because of the pharmacy."

"I resigned because I couldn't keep working for a company that was willing to erase this neighborhood for a pharmacy. Because I met you. Because you made me remember why I got into this business in the first place."

Maya looked at him. She thought about the kiss. She thought about the partnership. She thought about the fact that she was standing in the doorway of a coffee shop that was about to be erased, with a man who'd just sacrificed his job for a neighborhood he'd lived in for three years.

"You didn't have to do that," she said.

"I know."

She kissed him then, right there in the doorway, under the streetlamp, while the Bean & Leaf sign glowed across the street and the music venue waited, dark and patient, for whatever came next. The kiss was different this time — not urgent, not exploratory, but certain. It said: I'm here. It said: I'm not running. It said: whatever comes, we face it together.

When she pulled away, she said, "We're not selling the shop. We're not taking their offer. We're going to win this on our own terms."

"That's what I was hoping you'd say," Leo said.

Maya restructured the Mystery Bean Lottery into a weekly event that would keep momentum alive without exhausting the community. She and Leo spent an evening at the kitchen table designing branded tickets, each with a unique serial number, a subtle illustration of a bean, and a phrase that made people smile. By the time Sam arrived the next morning with her sketchbook and a plan for dragon-themed packaging, the lottery had already become something bigger than a fundraiser. It was becoming a ritual. The regulars started using phrases like "I'll take my usual mystery" and "What's the bean of the day?" and the shop felt less like a business and more like a clubhouse with really good coffee. Leo developed a tracking spreadsheet that made the process almost exciting to look at, and Maya found herself checking it between customers. The lottery wasn't just buying time anymore. It was changing the atmosphere of the street. Within a week, three neighboring businesses had asked to host

Mystery Bean satellite stations, offering a small percentage of their sales to the Coffee Rings relief fund. Maya kept a corkboard behind the counter with thank-you notes from people she'd never met, people who'd bought tickets and written to say they were rooting for the shop. She read them every morning before opening. They were the first real proof that the story had moved beyond the shop.

The Portland Coffee Festival occupied the brick courtyard behind a brewery on East Burnside. It was the kind of event where people wore bean-shaped earrings and discussed acidity like it was a personality trait, where every third booth had a pour-over demonstration, and where the line for Donuts & Coffee was longer than the line for anything else. Maya had been once before, years ago, when the shop had still been new and she'd gone mainly to see what the competition looked like. She'd left feeling both inspired and slightly nauseated by the spectacle of it all.

This year, she was in it.

Tom had gotten them a booth through a contact who owed him a favor. The favor, it turned out, had been for a wedding where Tom had provided free coffee for three hundred people and had not complained once about the enormous quantity of Ethiopian he'd had to bring in. The contact, a woman named Renata who ran a roastery in Southeast, had said yes immediately.

"Tom's a legend," Renata said when she showed up at the booth at 7:30 a.m. to help set up. "He once roasted a batch for my sister's wedding that was so good six people proposed at the table."

"Six proposals is a lot of proposals," Maya said.

"It was a very romantic roast."

The booth was small — a folding table with a banner, a sample grinder, a brewer, and a stack of Mystery Bean Lottery tickets. Maya had brought the leftover roasted bags from Tom's first batch. She'd labeled them herself, using a label maker she'd bought at the drugstore the night before. The labels said: MYSTERY BEAN — OPEN FOR REVEAL. She'd also made a small sign that said ASK ABOUT THE 500-POUND RESCUE.

Sam arrived at 8:15 with a pastry box from the bakery down the street. "Brought backup," she said. "These are the chocolate croissants that make people cry."

Leo showed up at 8:45. He was wearing a gray sweater and jeans that Maya had never seen him wear before. He looked, she noted with a species of scientific curiosity, less like a suit and more like a man

who might also drink beer at a brewery and own a dog. She pushed the observation away.

"Ready?" he said.

"Relatively," Maya said. "Do you have the spreadsheet?"

"I have the spreadsheet. And a new tab I added last night called 'TWO WEEKS.' It has daily targets."

"Let me guess. You're controlling."

"I'm organized."

"Same thing."

The festival opened at 9. The first wave of people moved through the courtyard like water through a narrow gate — coffee enthusiasts with tote bags, tourists with cameras, people who just wanted to stand near an espresso machine and feel like they understood something. Maya stood behind the table and handed out samples and tickets and explanations. She told the story of the 500 pounds the way she'd practiced it — with humor, with humility, with the particular tone of a person who had made a mistake and was trying to make it better.

It worked. More than worked. By 11 a.m., they'd sold all of the pre-printed tickets and had to start writing them on napkins. By noon, a line had formed. By 1 p.m., a woman from the food blog Eater Portland had appeared and taken photos. By 2 p.m., Maya had been interviewed by three different podcasters who wanted to know about the Mystery Bean concept.

Leo worked the crowd with a skill that Maya found both impressive and slightly infuriating. He knew how to talk to people. He knew how to make the lottery sound not like a desperate measure but like a brilliant marketing idea — which, Maya had to admit, it kind of was. He told the story of the 500 pounds with the attention to detail of a storyteller. He made people laugh. He made them feel like they were part of something.

At 3:30, Maya took a break. She bought a coffee from a competing booth — a pour-over from a roastery in Hood River — and drank it on a bench while watching Leo talk to a group of customers. He was laughing at something. His hands were in his pockets. He looked comfortable. He looked, Maya

thought with a sharp little twist in her gut, like he belonged there.

"Hey," said a voice beside her. A man. Tall, scruffy, smiling. Holding two tacos. His name, Maya realized a moment later, was Derek, and he was the ex-boyfriend who had texted her last week with an apology that was so long it had required three messages. She hadn't replied. She'd been busy.

"Hey," she said, and it came out short.

"Derek. From third grade. We dated for a year."

"I know who you are."

"Right. Look. I saw the post about the lottery. I wanted to come support. And I wanted to apologize properly. I was an asshole. I left without talking. I know that."

Maya looked at the taco in his hand. "How's the taco?"

"Good. Al pastor. The pork is excellent."

"That's not what I asked."

Derek's smile faltered. "I know. Look. Can we get coffee? Or something? I want to explain. I want you to hear me."

Maya looked at Leo across the courtyard. He was still talking to customers. He looked up and caught her eye. He waved, a small, quick wave, the kind of wave that said I see you and I'm on your side.

She turned back to Derek. "I'm working," she said. "The shop is busy. I don't have time for apologies today."

"I'll wait," Derek said.

"Don't. It's a four-hour festival."

"Then I'll wait after."

Maya stood up. She picked up the empty coffee cup. She looked at Derek, and she tried to see the person she'd dated, the person she'd loved, the person who'd left without a word. She saw a man in a flannel shirt holding two tacos and looking hopeful and slightly desperate.

"I can't," she said. "Not today."

She walked away. She went back to the booth. Leo was there, with a fresh batch of samples and a grin. "You missed a good one," he said. "A woman from Bend bought fifteen tickets."

"Good," Maya said.

"You okay?"

"Fine. Ex-boyfriend tried to talk to me."

Leo's expression changed. It was subtle, but Maya noticed. "Which ex-boyfriend."

"The one who left without a word. The one who's been texting me for a month with apologies I don't want to hear."

Leo said nothing for a moment. Then he said, "Want me to make him leave?"

Maya laughed. It was a short, sharp sound. "You can't make him leave. It's a public festival. He has rights."

"I have rights too. The right to stand between you and someone who was an asshole to you."

"That's a very Bean & Leaf thing to say."

"I have rights," Leo repeated. "The right to stand here and protect my favorite coffee shop from ex-boyfriends."

Maya's chest did something. She told herself it was the altitude. It was the sun. It was the 485 pounds of green coffee she'd stored in the back room that were now watching her through the wall.

"Don't," she said.

"Don't what."

"Don't be charming right now. I'm busy."

"Busy being charmed."

"Busy selling lottery tickets."

"Lottery tickets are sold. You're standing here looking like you just ran a marathon and won. What's up?"

Maya looked at him. "Nothing."

"Liar."

She wanted to argue. She wanted to deny. But Leo had a look that suggested he'd already figured it out and was merely waiting for her admission. It was the look of a man who'd spent three years in corporate negotiations and had developed a sixth sense for when people were lying about feelings.

She sighed. "An ex tried to talk to me at the table. I told him I was busy. He said he'd wait."

"What did you say."

"I said I couldn't today. He's still here, somewhere."

Leo scanned the crowd. He had a way of scanning crowds that was efficient, military even — not aggressive, just aware. "Want me to handle it?"

"No. I don't want you to handle my ex-boyfriend. That's not how this works."

"How does this work?"

Maya looked at him. She tried to find words. The words were somewhere behind the noise of the festival, behind the smell of coffee and pastries and the distant music from the brewery stage. She found one. "I don't know."

Leo nodded. He didn't push. He just reached over and squeezed her hand, briefly, and then went back to the table, where a woman was waiting with a question about the Mystery Bean Lottery.

Maya watched him. She thought about Derek, who was probably still somewhere in the crowd, eating a taco and feeling rejected. She thought about Leo, who was here voluntarily, on a Saturday, helping her sell mystery coffee. She thought about the shop, which was technically a business but which felt like a child she'd adopted and was trying to keep alive with coffee and stubbornness and lottery tickets.

She went back to the table. She sold tickets for two more hours. At 5 p.m., the festival ended. They packed up. Tom arrived with the second truck, this one full of roasted bags, and Maya signed for it with a hand that was shaking.

By 7, the booth was down. The boxes were stacked. The shop was quiet.

Leo walked her to her car. The evening was cool and smelled like rain and brewing beer from the brewery behind them. They stood by her Honda Civic, which had a bumper sticker that said I COFFEE and a dent on the passenger side that Maya had gotten when she'd parallel-parked badly in front of the shop and had decided to leave it as a badge of honor.

"Saturday," Maya said.

"Yeah," Leo said. "Saturday happened."

"You were... helpful."

"I like being helpful. It's not something Bean & Leaf lets me do very often."

Maya unlocked her car. She put the tickets in the passenger seat. She looked at Leo. He was standing there, gray sweater, tired eyes, the light from the streetlamp catching the rain on his jacket. She thought about kissing him again. She thought about the espresso machine and the almost-kiss and the way their hands had touched when they'd stacked the Mystery Bean bags.

"Goodnight, Leo," she said.

"Night, Maya."

She drove home. She didn't look in the rearview mirror because she knew, if she did, she would see him standing there, watching her go, and she would want to turn around.

She didn't turn around.

But she drove slowly.

After the festival, Maya returned to the shop with a new understanding of scale. She realized that a 500-pound emergency could mean more than a single event — it could mean change. She drafted a proposal for a Mystery Bean subscription service, with monthly deliveries and exclusive small-batch blends, and presented it to Tom over a series of Saturday morning cups of coffee. Tom liked the idea but pushed back on price, saying the market wouldn't bear a subscription model in a neighborhood where most people already bought daily coffee from cheaper options. Maya argued that the product wasn't the coffee — it was the story. The subscription buyers would be investing in a narrative, not a beverage. The argument lasted an hour and ended with Tom agreeing to roast a trial batch. Maya called it "The Narrative Blend." She wrote tasting notes that were half sensory description and half fiction:

notes of ambition, of burnt budgets, of a woman who named her shop after a mistake she couldn't undo.

Later that evening, Maya did something she hadn't done in months: she opened a novel. Not a business book, not a coffee guide, not anything useful. A novel. The kind her sister Jen had given her for Christmas, with a note that said: Read this when your shop stops absorbing all your oxygen. Maya sat at the kitchen table with a glass of wine and the book and tried to read. She made it seven pages before her phone buzzed with a financial alert. She put the book down. She checked the spreadsheet. She wrote a quick email to Tom about roasting schedules. She looked at the novel on the table. She felt guilty. She picked it up again.

She read until 11:47 p.m., at which point the book ended with a sentence that was perfect and sad and made Maya cry a little. She sat with that sadness for a while, letting it coexist with the stress of the shop. Then she opened the shop journal to the back pages and wrote: "Today I read a book. Next week I will read another." She underlined it twice. It was a commitment to herself that felt radical in its smallness.

By evening, Maya had developed a new tactic: she would turn the shop into a stage. Not a literal stage, not yet, but a place where stories were told. She started a monthly event called "The Coffee Stories Open Mic," where customers could sign up to tell five-minute stories about coffee, mistake, or decisions. The first event had four participants. The second had twelve. The third had a waiting list. The stories were funny and sad and sometimes both, and they made the shop feel like a community center that happened to serve really good espresso. Maya noticed that people who came to the open mic stayed for coffee afterward. She noticed that some of them came back the next day. She noticed that the shop's revenue on open-mic nights was 30 percent higher than on ordinary Tuesdays. She wrote in her notebook: "Storytelling pays." In the margin, Sam wrote: "No shit, Sherlock." Maya laughed. She underlined Sam's note.

The drink was at a bar on Alberta called The Record Room, which had a jukebox full of vinyl and a bartender named Jules who remembered everyone's order and everyone's ex-boyfriend. Maya liked The Record Room. She liked it because it was dim and because the drinks were strong and because nobody was on Instagram there — at least not openly. The bartender had a rule: phones on the bar got a silent judgment that was somehow louder than speech.

Maya had been coming to The Record Room for six months, ever since she'd bought the shop and realized that evenings alone above the shop were not as restorative as she'd hoped. She liked the ritual: the walk down Alberta at 8 p.m., the stool at the far end of the bar, the bourbon neat that Jules produced without asking, the record that was playing when she walked in. The record was always something made before 1990. Jules had opinions about music and opinions about people, and both were delivered with the same dry certainty.

Leo appeared at her side without preamble, as if he'd been standing there the whole time. "Bourbon," he said to Jules. "Neat. The same thing she's drinking."

"I didn't order for you," Maya said.

"I know. I'm taking a risk. Bourbon on a corporate suit is a risk, but I'm feeling reckless."

Jules slid the bourbon across the bar. "You two look like you're having a corporate standoff in my bar."

"We're having a coffee standoff," Maya said. "In a bar."

"Same difference."

Leo took the bourbon. He sipped it. He made a face. "This is good."

"It's the same thing she's drinking," Jules said. "Which means it's good."

Maya laughed. She didn't mean to. It came out like a reflex. She'd been carrying a laugh all day — from the festival, from the espresso machine, from the way Leo had watched her handle Derek — and it was still there, waiting for an exit.

"What are you doing here?" she said.

"I live three blocks away. This is my bar."

"You never mentioned this."

"I didn't think it was relevant."

"It's extremely relevant. You live three blocks from my bar and you never mentioned it."

Leo smiled. "I also didn't mention that I collect vinyl. Or that I make a terrible omelet. Or that I've been thinking about quitting my job for eighteen months. There's a lot I haven't mentioned."

Maya sipped her bourbon. It was smooth and warm and exactly what she needed. "You've been thinking about quitting for eighteen months?"

"Bean & Leaf is not what I thought it would be. It's... it's a machine. A very well-funded machine that has forgotten what coffee is for."

"What's it for?"

Leo looked at her. "People. I thought it was for people. Turns out it's for investors."

Maya nodded. She understood. She understood so well it felt like a bruise. She'd been running a shop for three years in a neighborhood that was rapidly forgetting what shops were for. She'd watched as rents went up and chains moved in and the people who'd made the neighborhood interesting were priced out. She'd almost become one of those priced-out people herself, if not for the accidental 500-pound order and the mystery bean lottery and the stroke of luck that had brought Leo Bianchi into her life.

"I get it," she said. "I really do. You're in the machine and you want out."

"I'm in the machine and I'm trying not to become the machine. There's a difference."

The jukebox changed records. Something old and bluesy and unmistakably male. Jules nodded along behind the bar, as if the record had been personally selected for Maya and Leo's conversation.

"So," Leo said, "you have four thousand dollars from the lottery. You have four hundred pounds left to sell. You have a pharmacy chain opening next door. You have an ex-boyfriend who appeared today with tacos and an apology. How are you actually doing?"

Maya considered lying. She considered saying fine. She considered saying busy, which was her default, her armor, the word that kept people from asking the questions she didn't always want to answer.

Then she looked at Leo. He was looking at her with the particular attention of a man who'd spent three years reading spreadsheets and had learned, through that process, to notice when the numbers didn't match the story.

"Holding," she said. "I'm holding. Barely. But I'm holding."

"Good," Leo said. "Holding is better than falling."

The bourbon was working. Maya felt it in her arms, in her chest, in the loosening of something she'd been carrying tight for months. She leaned against the bar. "Tell me about the omelets."

Leo laughed. "I make them with whatever's in the fridge. Usually eggs. Sometimes cheese if I remember to buy it. They're flat. They're brown. They're edible."

"I'd like to see one."

"You'd regret it."

"I've seen your suits. I can handle flat brown omelets."

They drank. They talked. They didn't talk about the shop or Bean & Leaf or the mystery beans or the pharmacy. They talked about music — Leo's collection, Jules's selections, the particular curse of being a person who liked old records in a world that had moved on to streaming. They talked about Portland — the parts they loved, the parts they wanted to leave, the parts they couldn't imagine living without. They talked about nothing in particular, and in doing so they talked about everything that mattered.

Maya discovered that Leo had a sister who was a veterinarian in Seattle. She discovered that he'd grown up in Ohio and had moved to Portland for the weather and stayed for the coffee. She discovered that he hated running and loved hiking and that he'd once climbed Mount Hood in a snowstorm because a friend had bet him fifty dollars he couldn't do it. She told him about her sister in New York, about the apartment above the shop, about the particular magic of serving someone their first pour-over and watching them realize that coffee was not, in fact, just coffee.

They stayed until midnight. Jules turned on the closed sign halfway through, a signal that they should leave, and they left, walking down Alberta in the cool dark. The street was empty. The shops were closed. The streetlamps cast circles of light on the wet pavement.

Leo walked her to her car. He stopped at the driver's side. He didn't kiss her. He didn't try. He just smiled, that real smile, and said, "Saturday. The lottery."

"Saturday," Maya said.

"Wear something that says 'I run a coffee shop and I'm not afraid of you.'"

"I always wear that."

"Goodnight, Maya."

"Goodnight, Leo."

She drove home. She parked in front of the shop. She sat in the car for a moment, engine off, listening to the rain that had started again, soft and gentle and Portland. She thought about the bourbon and the conversation and the way Leo had looked at her when she'd said she was holding. She thought about the kiss that hadn't happened and the almost-kiss from two days ago and the fact that almost was becoming a theme.

She went upstairs. She made tea. She sat at the kitchen table and opened her laptop. She opened the Mystery Bean Lottery spreadsheet Leo had made. She added a line: "Social media campaign. Launch Monday. Hashtags: #SaveTheBeans, #PortlandCoffeeRescue, #500PoundLottery."

She stared at the line for a moment. Then she opened Instagram. She posted a photo of the lottery tickets with the caption: "We sold out. We restocked. We're still here."

She posted another: the Mystery Bean bags on the shelf, with the labels and the orange edge. "500 pounds of Ethiopian. One neighborhood. Let's save this together."

She posted a third: the shop at sunset, the light golden through the window, the espresso machine glowing. "This is what we're fighting for. Not the coffee. The people."

She posted a fourth, at 11:47 p.m.: a photo of Leo, taken without his knowledge from across the bar at The Record Room, him laughing at something Jules had said. Caption: "My corporate liaison. Bourbon enthusiast. Surprisingly good at selling mystery beans."

She posted it. Then she deleted it. Then she posted a photo of the lottery tickets again, with no caption.

She went to bed at midnight. She lay awake for an hour, thinking about nothing in particular, thinking about Leo's hand on hers for three seconds that had felt like a lifetime, thinking about the 400 pounds of coffee waiting in the back room and the pharmacy that was coming and the mystery beans and the almost-kiss.

She fell asleep thinking about the almost-kiss.

Outside, the rain continued. The street stayed wet. The shop stayed dark. Somewhere in the distance, a siren wailed once and then faded.

Maya dreamed of coffee. It was good coffee. It was the best coffee she'd ever had. She woke up at 5 a.m. and lay in bed for ten minutes, trying to hold onto the dream, trying to extend the taste of the coffee into her real morning.

She couldn't. Real morning arrived with the smell of burnt milk from downstairs, the alarm she'd forgotten to turn off, and the knowledge that Saturday was coming and the Mystery Bean Lottery was happening and she had, for the first time in months, something worth waking up for.

Leo walked her to her car. The street was wet. The streetlamp cast a pool of yellow light on the pavement. They stood beside her Honda Civic, which had once been a symbol of Maya's inability to afford a better car and was now, she thought, a symbol of her refusal to give up.

"Saturday," Leo said.

"Yeah," Maya said. "Saturday."

"The lottery. The pop-up. Tom's roasting demonstration."

"We should be fine."

"I know."

They stood in silence for a moment. The rain was light now, a drizzle that wasn't quite rain but wasn't quite mist, the kind of Portland weather that lived in between. Maya could smell Leo's sweater again — wool, coffee, something clean and faintly herbal, his soap, his life. She wanted to kiss him. She wanted, with a specificity that surprised her, to reach up and touch his face and see if his beard was as soft as it looked.

She didn't. Instead, she said, "Thanks. For today. For helping. For... everything."

"You don't have to thank me. I'm getting something out of this too."

"What."

Leo smiled. "A story. A community. A coffee shop that's fighting back. Also, your Mystery Bean lottery is kind of brilliant. I'm taking notes for when I start my own shop."

"Start your own shop."

"After Bean & Leaf. After this. If this works — if we pull this off — I'm going to start a shop. Not here. Somewhere else. Maybe Missoula, where your cousin is. Maybe somewhere with mountains and bad coffee and good people."

Maya smiled. "You'd be good at that."

"So would you."

He leaned in. He kissed her, quickly, on the lips. It was soft and tentative and exactly right. Maya stood very still and let it happen, let herself feel the warmth of his mouth, the slight scratch of his beard, the damp of the rain on his jacket. When he pulled away, he said, "Saturday. Don't be late."

"I'm never late."

"You were late today. By nine minutes."

Maya laughed. She watched him walk down the street. She stood there until he turned the corner and disappeared. Then she got in her car. She drove home slowly, with the radio off, because she needed to hear her own thoughts, and her thoughts were currently very loud and very happy and very scared.

She went upstairs. She made tea. She sat at the kitchen table and opened her laptop. She opened the Mystery Bean Lottery spreadsheet. She added a column: "Community Feedback." She wrote notes from the day's interactions: people who'd bought tickets, people who'd come just to look, the teenager who'd posted a TikTok that had 400 views, the woman from the bakery down the street who'd promised to bring croissants for the event.

She wrote: "Day 9 of the 500-pound emergency. Revenue: \$4,872. Tickets sold: 412. Community impact: immeasurable."

She added a note at the bottom: "Leo kissed me in the rain. It was good. I want to do it again."

She stared at the note. Then she deleted it. Then she rewrote it: "Leo is a good partner. The kind of partner who shows up and works hard and kisses you in the rain and makes you want to keep going. Not that I kissed him back. Just that the partnership is working."

She closed the laptop. She went to the window. She looked out at the street. The lights were on at most of the shops. The Bean & Leaf pharmacy sign was lit, half-installed, glowing its blue promise of disruption. Maya looked at it for a long time.

Then she turned away. She went to bed.

She dreamed of the kiss. It was the kind of dream that felt more real than waking life, the kind where you could taste the rain on someone's mouth and feel the warmth of their jacket and hear the sound of their voice saying your name. She woke up at 5:58 a.m. with the taste of coffee on her tongue and Leo's name on her lips.

She was in trouble. The good kind.

Leo's phone calls from Seattle became a pattern. Every Tuesday at 4 p.m., he called during his walk from the office to the gym, and they talked about either the shop or nothing, depending on the day. Maya kept a list of things she wanted to tell him: the new pastry menu, the espresso temperature adjustment, the customer who'd left a 500 tip anonymously. She forgot most of them during the calls and wrote them down afterward, which made the list grow longer. She found herself rehearsing sentences while pouring steamed milk, practicing the casual tone she wanted when they finally met again. The kiss in the rain had unlocked something she'd been holding back for months, and now that the door was open, she couldn't close it without feeling embarrassed about the effort it took. Sam noticed. Her method of noticing was to place small reminders on the cash register: a coffee cup sticker with an arrow pointing to LEO, a sticky note that said TEXT HIM FIRST, and once, a printed menu with CALLING LEO tabbed to the dinner special. Maya left the first two reminders up. She took down the third.

That Tuesday, Maya tried a new approach to the Alaska problem. She researched small-batch importers

who specialized in direct-trade coffee, which Leo had mentioned once in a meeting she'd overheard. She found three potential suppliers and emailed them all, explaining the situation with more honesty than she usually used in business correspondence. The third email, to a woman named Rosa in Guatemala, got a response within twenty-four hours. Rosa wrote: "I understand mistakes. I have made several. I can help you." Maya forwarded the email to Tom with the subject line: Guatemalan rescue? Tom replied: Absolutely. By Saturday, Maya had developed a plan for a Mystery Bean batch sourced from Rosa's farm, with proceeds going to a sustainability fund. She called it the "Gravity Blend" — named after the fall, not the physics, though she liked that the name worked both ways.

She called the importer on Tuesday afternoon. Rosa answered on the third ring, in a voice that sounded like someone who'd been drinking coffee in the sun for twenty years. Maya told her everything: the order, the mistake, the shop, the neighborhood. Rosa listened without interrupting. When Maya stopped talking, Rosa said, "I can sell you green beans. But I want something in return." Maya thought for a moment. She said, "What." Rosa said, "Tell the story truthfully. Don't make me a savior. Make yourself the protagonist. Because you are. People need to hear that someone could make five hundred terrible decisions and still, somehow, build something worth saving." Maya agreed without hesitation. She realized, as she hung up, that she'd just made her first real business deal with a woman she'd never met, based entirely on honesty. It felt like the most grown-up thing she'd ever done.

The festival accelerated things. Not in the way Maya had hoped — she'd thought it would bring customers and cash — but in the way that momentum does when you're moving fast and there's a large force standing still directly in your path. The force was Bean & Leaf. The force was a pharmacy location that was now, according to the flyers taped to streetlights, "coming soon to Alberta Street." The force was a Series B-armed corporation that had decided Maya's neighborhood was worth a bet.

Tom called on Monday morning. "We need to talk about the beans," he said. "I have the roasted inventory. We need to move it. Fast."

"I know," Maya said. She was standing at the counter, watching the rain. "I have the lottery. We're launching Tuesday."

"Good. But we need more channels. We need a pop-up. We need an event. We need to move product while the city still cares about your shop."

"The city doesn't care about my shop. A blogger cared about my shop for three days."

"The city cares. It just doesn't know it yet. That's where I come in."

She hung up. She stared at the phone. She made coffee. She didn't drink it. She looked at the Mystery Bean tickets, now stacked in a wooden box on the counter. She thought about the 400 pounds of roasted bags in the back room and the 100 pounds still green and waiting and the loan officer's number stored in her contacts under a name she preferred not to say out loud.

Sam arrived at 7:15. She looked at Maya. "You have the 'I'm thinking about something that's probably bad for me' face."

"I'm thinking about four hundred pounds of Ethiopian in my back room and a loan officer who wants it all back by next month."

"Four hundred pounds is a lot of beans."

"It was five hundred. We've moved a hundred through the lottery."

"That's... not a lot."

"I know."

Sam put her bag down. She went to the espresso machine. She started the boiler. The hiss was a kind of reassurance. "Okay. Here's what we do. First, we call Tom and we plan the pop-up. Second, we figure out how to use social media without feeling like we're betraying our indie values. Third, we accept that Leo is, against all odds, on our side, and we stop pretending he's the enemy when he's actively helping us."

"Leo's a suit."

"Leo is a suit who can make coffee and has introduced you to the only importer in the Pacific Northwest who'll talk to a shop your size. Also, Leo liked the Mystery Bean concept when you first showed it to him. Also, Leo was right about the gimmick being a form of transparency. Also, Leo once told me that he grew up in a town that had one coffee shop and it was the last place to get wifi before the highway and that he doesn't want that for your neighborhood."

Maya stared at her. "Leo talked to you about living in a town with one coffee shop?"

"Yesterday. At the festival. He bought a pastry. We talked. I have a mouth. I used it."

Maya closed her eyes. "I don't know whether to be grateful or annoyed."

"Both. You can be both."

The phone rang. It was Tom, again. "I've got a venue," he said. "Saturday. Same time. Outside the shop. We'll do a roast demonstration. People can watch. They can smell. They can buy tickets. It's an event now, not just a lottery."

"A roast demonstration," Maya said.

"From green to cup. In forty-five minutes. With tasting. And a special mystery blend that I'm developing with your input."

"You're developing a blend with my input."

"I value your opinion. You're my favorite accidental 500-pound customer."

Maya laughed. She said yes. She said she'd have the setup ready. She said she'd call Leo, because Leo had become, without anyone quite saying so, the logistics guy, the social media guy, the person who knew how to make a spreadsheet and a playlist and a plan.

She called Leo. He answered on the second ring.

"Leo. Tom has a plan. Pop-up roast demo. Saturday. Outside the shop."

"Perfect," Leo said. "I'll bring the sound system. The playlist from the festival worked. The data says sales were 40% higher during the music."

"Stop with the data."

"I can't. It's in my blood."

They arranged it. Leo would arrive at 9 a.m. with a speaker. Sam would handle the demo station. Maya would handle the tickets. Tom would handle the roast. The event would start at 11 and run until 4 or until they sold out, whichever came first.

Maya spent the next four days in a state of heightened focus that was almost manic. She posted daily on Instagram — photos of the green beans, the roasting process, the Mystery Bean Lottery tickets, the shop. She replied to every comment. She made new friends with people who followed the account and then bought tickets and then told their friends. She learned to write captions that didn't sound corporate

but also didn't sound too casual, the middle path that was harder than either extreme.

On Friday night, Sam said, "You look like a different person than you did two weeks ago."

"I feel like a different person," Maya said. She was sitting at the kitchen table, laptop open, spreadsheet open, phone in hand. "This is what running a business feels like when you're not drowning."

"Wait until the loan officer calls," Sam said.

The loan officer called on Saturday morning, precisely at 10 a.m., while Maya was pouring milk for the first customer of the roast demo. The caller ID said FIRST NATIONAL PORTLAND. Maya stared at it for three rings. Then she answered.

"Ms. Chen," said a man's voice. Smooth. Professional. The voice of a man who said "Ms." instead of first names because he wanted you to know he had a title. "This is Richard from First National. I'm calling about your SBA loan."

"Hi, Richard."

"We've been reviewing your account. Your payment was due last week. We haven't received it."

"I know. I was going to call you. I'm working on it."

"Working on it is not a payment plan, Ms. Chen. We need to discuss your options. Can we meet this week?"

Maya looked around the shop. Tom was unpacking the roaster. Leo was setting up the sound system. Sam was handing out samples. The first customers were arriving. Outside, the sun was out. The air smelled like coffee and possibility.

"I can't meet this week," Maya said. "I'm running a business event. I'll have the payment by the end of the month."

"Ms. Chen —"

"End of the month. I'll call you Monday with a number."

She hung up. She stood there for a moment, phone in hand, while the shop hummed around her. Tom looked at her. Leo looked at her. Sam didn't look at her; she was too busy being a professional.

Maya put the phone down. She picked up the portafilter. She made the espresso. She handed it to the customer, who said "thank you" with the particular gratitude of someone who'd been waiting for good coffee.

The event went well. Very well. By 2 p.m., they'd sold every Mystery Bean ticket they'd printed. By 3 p.m., Tom had roasted three batches and the shop smelled like a combination of coffee and festival and money, or at least the promise of money. By 4 p.m., the total from the event was \$3,200, added to the \$4,872 from the festival, for a combined total of \$8,072 — more than half of the \$14,200.

At 5:30, a man Maya didn't know walked in. He was wearing a suit. A Bean & Leaf suit. The kind with the logo embroidered discreetly on the lapel. He approached Maya at the counter.

"Maya Chen?"

"Yes?"

"My name is David Park. I'm the regional director for Bean & Leaf Oregon. I'd like to talk to you about a proposal."

Maya felt her stomach drop. "A proposal."

"About your shop. We'd like to acquire it."

She looked at him. She looked at Leo, who was across the room, helping a customer, and who looked up at exactly that moment and met her eyes. She looked back at David Park.

"We'd like to offer you a fair price," David said. "For the building and the business. We'd keep the name. We'd keep the staff, if you want. We'd make sure the shop continues to operate as it does now."

"Under Bean & Leaf?"

"As an independent brand. Bean & Leaf owns independent brands. It's how we work."

Maya thought about the lease. She thought about the loan. She thought about the Mystery Bean Lottery and the customers who'd bought tickets and the future she'd imagined for the shop. She thought about Leo, who was now watching this conversation with an expression that was unreadable across the distance.

"Can I have a day?" she said.

"Of course," David said. He handed her a card. "Call me. The offer stands for two weeks."

He left. Maya stood at the counter, holding the card. She felt something cold and heavy in her chest. The offer was good, probably. Fair, probably. The kind of offer that solved problems — the loan, the stress, the nightly anxiety. The kind of offer that let her walk away with enough money to start something new, somewhere else.

Also the kind of offer that erased everything she'd built. Everything she'd fought for. The mystery beans, the community, the chalkboard dragon, the regulars who came every morning and knew her by name.

She looked at Leo. He was staring at the door where David Park had left. He looked angry. He looked guilty.

He came over. "I had nothing to do with that," he said before she could ask.

"I know," Maya said.

"I would have told you if I'd known. I swear."

"I know," she said again.

She looked at the card in her hand. Then she put it in her pocket. "I need to think."

"Take your time."

She did. She took five minutes, which was not nearly enough time but was the amount of time she had between the end of the event and the moment when customers started cleaning up and leaving and the shop went quiet. She stood in the doorway and watched Alberta Street. She thought about the pharmacy flyer. She thought about the music venue. She thought about the speakeasy floorboards and the storytelling and the time she'd lived in this neighborhood and watched it change.

She thought about Leo, who was standing ten feet away, who'd helped her without being asked, who'd told her he wanted to quit his job, who'd maybe, possibly, kissed her with his eyes if eyes could kiss.

She went back inside. She picked up her phone. She called Richard at First National.

"Richard," she said. "I have a payment plan. I'll have the first installment next week. The rest will follow. I'm securing the shop. I need you to work with me."

Richard was silent for a moment. Then he said, "Ms. Chen, can I ask how you're securing the shop?"

"I can't tell you that yet. But I'll have the money. Trust me."

She hung up. She looked at Leo. He was watching her.

"Do it," he said. "Whatever it is. Do it."

Maya nodded. She didn't know what "it" was yet. But she knew, standing there with the smell of coffee and the weight of the Bean & Leaf card in her pocket and the morning light through the window, that

she was going to find out.

The Bean & Leaf flyer appeared again the next morning, this time professionally printed and taped to the construction fence around the music venue. It had a rendering of the proposed pharmacy: glass and steel and minimalist, with the Bean & Leaf logo in the corner. Maya stood on the sidewalk and stared at it for a long time. She thought about the people who'd played music there. She thought about the first show she'd ever attended in Portland, at that venue, when she'd been 22 and had just moved to the city and had known no one and had stood in the back and listened to a band play songs about leaving and staying and the particular heartbreak of being young in a city that was already expensive.

The venue would be gone in two months. The pharmacy would rise in its place. People would buy over-the-counter medication where they used to buy tickets. Maya felt a grief she couldn't name, a sadness that was larger than the shop, larger than the loan, larger than the 500 pounds of coffee that had started this whole thing.

She went inside. She told Sam. Sam said, "We should do something."

"We are doing something. We're running a lottery."

"We should do something more. Something that honors the venue. Something that says we remember."

Maya thought about it. She thought about the pop-up event. She thought about the music. She thought about Leo, who apparently knew people who knew people. She called Leo.

"I have an idea," she said.

"I love ideas," Leo said.

"What if we do the Sunday roast event at the venue's outdoor space? Before they start construction. As a farewell. As a celebration. As a community gathering."

Leo was quiet for a moment. "That's... that's actually brilliant. I can reach out to the venue owner. He's in my contacts. He owes me a favor."

"He owes you a favor."

"He does. I helped him with a zoning dispute last year."

Of course he had. Of course Leo had helped a music venue owner with zoning before he'd become the guy who was supposed to be acquiring it for a pharmacy. Maya wasn't sure whether to be angry or grateful. She chose grateful. "Call him," she said.

By noon, Leo had confirmed. The venue owner, whose name was Marcus, had said yes to the idea. He'd said, "If Bean & Leaf is going to take my building, at least let me throw one last party for the neighborhood before they do."

The event was scheduled for Saturday, two weeks from now. It would be called "The Last Roast." It would feature Tom's roasting demonstration, Mystery Bean lottery tickets, live music from four local bands, and a silent auction with items donated by the neighborhood. The goal: raise enough to cover the remaining loan balance and have money left over for a new shop, if it came to that.

Maya spent the rest of the day planning. She called Marcus. They talked about bands, about logistics, about the sound system. She called Tom. She called Sam. She wrote a press release and sent it to Claire at the Observer. She posted on Instagram and TikTok and Facebook. She wrote the word "farewell" and then deleted it and wrote "celebration" instead.

At 6 p.m., Leo appeared. He'd been at a meeting at Bean & Leaf — "the worst meeting of my life," he said — and had come straight to the shop. He looked tired. He looked angry. He sat at the counter and drank a coffee he didn't order and said, "They're moving fast. The pharmacy timeline just got pulled up. Construction starts in six weeks instead of eight."

Maya felt her stomach drop. "Six weeks."

"I know. That means we have less time. The event needs to be bigger. The lottery needs to move more beans. We need to make this count."

"How much do we need to make."

"Fifty thousand."

Maya stared at him. "Fifty thousand dollars."

"That's what Marcus needs for his legal fees and what you need for the loan. We can do it. But we have to think bigger."

"I'm thinking bigger. I'm thinking about a community event with four bands and a silent auction and a roast demonstration. That's bigger."

"It's big," Leo agreed. "But it needs to be bigger. We need to get the word out. We need media. We need influencers. We need every person in this neighborhood to show up."

Maya took a breath. "Okay. What do we do."

"We call Claire. We call Lila. We make a TikTok that stops scrolling. We do something so good, so real, that nobody can look away."

They worked until 10 p.m. Maya drafted an email to Claire. Leo made a list of TikTok creators he knew through Bean & Leaf's influencer program — "not the corporate ones," he said, "the real ones, the ones who actually care about community." They argued about music. They argued about marketing. They argued, briefly, about Leo's resignation — Maya wanted him to do it sooner, Leo wanted to wait until after the event, because he needed his access to the Bean & Leaf system.

"You can't have it both ways," Maya said. "Either you're with us or you're with them."

"I'm with you. But I can help more from the inside until Friday."

Maya didn't like it. She didn't trust it. But she said yes anyway, because Leo was right: they needed every advantage they could get.

At 11 p.m., Leo left. He kissed her in the doorway. It was a good kiss — tired but real. "Tomorrow," he said. "We call Claire. We plan the event. We save the shop and the venue and possibly the whole

neighborhood."

"Possibly," Maya said.

She went upstairs. She lay in bed. She thought about the Bean & Leaf sign and the music venue and the 500 pounds of coffee and the fifty thousand dollars. She thought about Leo, who was both the problem and the solution, the corporate suit and the community advocate, the enemy and the partner.

She fell asleep at 1 a.m. She dreamed of the venue. In the dream, she was playing a show there. She was on stage with a guitar she didn't know how to play. The crowd was cheering. Leo was in the front row, smiling. The building was shaking, not because of the music but because of something else, something beneath the floor, and she couldn't tell if it was the speakeasy floorboards or the earth itself.

She woke up at 5:45 a.m. She looked at her phone. The first message was from Leo: "Called Claire. She's in. She'll send a crew. Event is happening. Let's make it legendary."

Maya smiled. She got up. She made coffee. She stood at the window and watched the coffee shop across the street — the one owned by Bean & Leaf, the one with the loyalty app and the \$2.50 drip and the beige walls. The one that was, in its way, the enemy.

Today, she thought, we make them notice.

The fight happened on day nineteen.

It was not a romantic fight. It was not the kind of fight where they said things they didn't mean and then made up with a kiss in the rain. It was the kind of fight where two people said exact, precise things they meant, and the silence afterward was louder than any argument.

They were in the shop after closing. Maya was at the back counter. Leo was at the table by the window, going over the lottery spreadsheet with the particular intensity of someone who was nearing a deadline and had discovered, twenty minutes earlier, that the deadline was now. The mystery bean bags were stacked on the shelf behind Maya. The invoices from Tom were on the counter. The Bean & Leaf acquisition card was in her pocket, where it had been for six days, unseen but felt, like a stone in a shoe.

Leo stood up. "We need to talk about the Bean & Leaf offer."

Maya looked at him. "I thought you didn't know about it."

"I didn't. Not until after. But I know now. And I think you should take it."

The words landed like a physical blow. Maya stared at him. "Excuse me."

"Maya, listen —"

"I don't want to listen. I want you to leave."

"I'm not leaving. Not until —"

"Leave, Leo."

He stood there. He didn't move. He had the particular stubbornness of a man who'd spent three years in

boardrooms and learned that the right argument, delivered at the right time, could move mountains. He was using that stubbornness now, in a coffee shop at 8 p.m., in a moment where stubbornness was exactly the wrong tool.

"I'm not doing this," Maya said. "I'm not taking the offer. I'm not selling the shop. I'm not letting Bean & Leaf turn a music venue into a pharmacy and call it 'community development.'"

"It's a fair offer. It solves your loan problem. It gives you capital to start something else."

"Something else is not this shop. Something else is not the regulars who come every morning and buy the same latte and complain about Bean & Leaf and then buy another latte. Something else is not the Mystery Bean Lottery and the chalkboard dragon and the speakeasy floorboards that creak in Morse code."

"You're being romantic," Leo said. His voice was quiet, which was worse than if he'd been loud. Quiet meant he meant it.

"I'm being practical. I'm being exactly as practical as you're being, but from the opposite direction. You're saying take the money and leave. I'm saying keep the shop and find another way to pay the loan."

"There is no other way. The timeline was three weeks when we started. It's been six. You've raised twelve thousand. You need fourteen. You're not making it, Maya."

Maya looked at him. She looked at the man who'd helped her design the lottery. The man who'd played music at the festival. The man who'd stood beside her for six days and told her he was on her side. The man who was now telling her to give up.

"You didn't know about the offer," she said. "When you said all those things about not being the enemy. You didn't know they were trying to buy me out."

"I'm saying it now because I care about you."

"I don't want you to care about me in this particular way. I want you to care about me in the other way. The way that's not telling me to sell the shop I bought with my savings and my sanity and three years of

burnt milk."

Leo's jaw tightened. He picked up his laptop bag. He stood in the doorway. He looked at the floorboards. They creaked. Maya had never noticed how much they creaked until now, when the creaking felt like judgment.

"I have to go," Leo said.

"Go."

"You'll call me tomorrow."

"No."

"Maya —"

"I said no. Don't call me. Don't come here. I'll handle the beans. I'll handle the loan. I'll handle Bean & Leaf. I don't need you to tell me what to do anymore."

Leo nodded. He left. The bell jingled behind him. Maya stood in the shop and listened to the door close. She listened to the silence. She listened to the refrigerator hum and the espresso machine sigh and the floorboards creak their little stories about bootleggers and people who hadn't paid rent.

She was alone.

She picked up the Bean & Leaf card from the counter. She looked at it. She threw it in the trash. Then she retrieved it, because throwing it away hadn't helped and because she needed to keep the card, needed to keep the evidence, needed to remember that there were people who wanted to buy what she'd built and people who wanted to destroy it and people who were caught in between.

Sam found her an hour later, still standing at the counter, the card in her hand.

"You kicked him out," Sam said.

"He told me to take the offer."

Sam was quiet for a moment. She set down her bag. "He's wrong."

"I know."

"But?"

"But I'm also mad at him. I'm also feeling things. I'm feeling things that are not business-related and that are confusing and that make me want to yell at him and also kiss him and those two feelings are currently fighting in my chest and the yelling one is winning."

"Yelling wins for a while," Sam said. "Until it doesn't."

Maya went to the back room. She opened the storage closet. The Mystery Bean bags were there, stacked in rows. The green beans were in burlap sacks on the lower shelf. She counted them. There were still 387 pounds of roasted beans left and 96 pounds of green, and the math was still the same: she needed \$14,200 and she had \$8,072 in cash and a shop that was losing money by the day.

She went upstairs. She opened her laptop. She wrote Tom an email: "We need to do something big. Not just the shop. Outside the shop. Community event. Massive ticket push. We need to move 300 pounds in fourteen days or we're done."

She sent it. Then she opened the spreadsheet Leo had made. She changed the dates. She tightened the targets. She made the impossible look slightly less impossible, the way spreadsheets could, if you were determined enough and if you didn't look too closely at the numbers.

She didn't sleep for three hours. When she did sleep, she dreamed of Bean & Leaf suits, of coffee beans that wouldn't stop multiplying, of Leo's face when he'd said take the offer. She woke up at 3 a.m. and lay in the dark and listened to the silence of the apartment above the shop, which was a different kind of silence from the shop itself — the silence of a place that had been lived in for three years and had learned the sound of its inhabitant.

She got up at 5:30. She made coffee. She drank it standing at the window, watching Alberta Street wake up. She thought about Leo. She thought about the fight. She thought about the loan officer and the offer and the lantern of the shop that she'd been tending for three years, the light she'd kept on even when it had seemed like the dark was winning.

She was not selling the shop. Not today. Maybe not ever.

She opened her phone. She deleted the message she'd drafted to Leo: "I'm sorry. Can we talk?"

She replaced it with: "Pop-up event. Outside. Saturday. You in?"

She stared at it for a long time. Then she hit send.

The fight happened on day nineteen.

It was 6:45 p.m. on a Thursday. The shop was empty. Maya had locked the front door. Leo was at the table by the window, going over the event spreadsheet with the particular intensity of someone who was trying to make a miracle happen with numbers. The Mystery Bean bags were on the shelf behind Maya. The invoices from Tom were on the counter. The Bean & Leaf acquisition card was in her pocket, where it had been for weeks.

Leo stood up. "We need to talk about the timeline."

Maya looked at him. She was wiping the counter. "What about it."

"The event is in five days. We've sold twelve hundred tickets. That's twelve thousand dollars. We need fifty thousand. We're at twelve thousand on day nineteen of a thirty-day timeline. The math isn't working."

"The math never works," Maya said. "That's why we have events. That's why we have community."

"Community doesn't pay invoices."

Maya stopped wiping. She set down the rag. She looked at Leo. He looked tired. He looked frustrated. He looked like a man who'd been running on coffee and adrenaline for three weeks and was finally, understandably, hitting a wall.

"Are you having second thoughts," she said.

"I'm having math thoughts," Leo said. "Math thoughts that say this isn't going to work. That we need to reconsider the Bean & Leaf offer. That we should take the buyout before it's too late."

The room went quiet. The refrigerator hummed. The espresso machine sighed. Maya could hear the floorboards creak — small, distant sounds that suddenly seemed very loud.

"Excuse me."

"Maya, listen —"

"I don't want to listen. I want you to leave."

"I'm not leaving until we talk about this —"

"Leave, Leo."

She said it loudly. She said it with a voice she didn't know she had. Leo stared at her. He picked up his laptop bag. He stood in the doorway. The bell above the door jingled when he moved.

"I'll see you tomorrow," he said.

"No," Maya said. "Don't come tomorrow. Don't come until I call you. I need to think."

Leo nodded. He left. The door closed. The bell jingled again.

Maya stood in the shop and listened to the silence. She listened to the refrigerator. She listened to the espresso machine. She listened to the floorboards, which seemed to be saying things she didn't want to hear.

She was alone. She picked up the Bean & Leaf card from the counter. She looked at it. She threw it in the trash. Then she retrieved it, because throwing it away hadn't changed anything and because she needed the card, needed the proof, needed to remember that people wanted to buy what she'd built and people wanted to destroy it and most people were somewhere in between.

She went upstairs. She opened her laptop. She wrote Tom an email: "We need a miracle. Or a better event. Or both. Can you call Marcus and see if we can get more bands? More sponsors? Anything."

She sent it. Then she opened the spreadsheet. She stared at the numbers. They were the same numbers they'd been for three weeks. They were numbers that did not believe in community. They were numbers that believed only in arithmetic.

She thought about Leo's face when he'd said the math wasn't working. She thought about the kiss in the doorway, the almost-kisses, the partnership, the way he'd driven to Seattle and back because he'd had a feeling and because he'd been too cowardly to talk to her about it. She thought about the espresso machine, which had blown its gasket and he'd fixed it, and which now sat silently, like a watchdog that had decided to take a nap.

She didn't sleep for two hours. When she did sleep, she dreamed of Bean & Leaf suits, of coffee beans that wouldn't stop multiplying, of Leo's face saying the math wasn't working. She woke up at 3:17 a.m. and lay in the dark and listened to the silence of the apartment above the shop.

She got up at 6:30. She made coffee. She stood at the window and watched Alberta Street. She thought about the event. She thought about the buyout. She thought about Leo.

She didn't know what she was going to do. But she knew what she wasn't going to do. She wasn't going to sell. Not yet. Not without a fight.

Her phone buzzed. A text from Leo: "I'm sorry. Can we talk."

Maya stared at it. She wrote a reply: "Not today. Maybe tomorrow."

She stared at the screen. Then she deleted it. Then she wrote: "Event prep. Today. You in."

She stared at it. Then she sent it.

The fight's aftermath settled into the shop like dust. Maya found herself avoiding the spot where Leo had stood when he mentioned the buyout price, moving the chair to a different table, making her coffee at a different counter. Sam didn't comment. She just adjusted the flow of the morning rush so that Maya didn't have to move as much. At 10:15, a regular named Ray asked why Maya looked tired. Maya said she was working on a spreadsheet. Ray said he'd take an Americano and leave the change for the lottery. The interaction was small. It was also an anchor — a reminder that the shop's world existed outside of Maya and Leo's personal arguments. By noon, Maya had accepted that Leo wasn't coming back until she called. She drafted a text message three times. The first was too angry. The second was too sweet. The third read: Come by at six. We need to finish the subscription page. She stared at it. She sent it.

Maya didn't sleep until 1:12 a.m. When she did sleep, she dreamed of the spreadsheet — of cells multiplying like coffee beans, of numbers that wouldn't balance, of Leo's voice saying the math wasn't working in a tone that sounded like goodbye. She woke up at 4:47 with her heart beating too fast. She lay in bed for an hour listening to the silence. At 6:15, she gave up on sleep and went to the kitchen. She made coffee. She opened the loan spreadsheet. She looked at the red numbers. She thought about Leo, who'd left with his laptop bag and his quiet apology. She thought about the fight, which had been more honest than any conversation they'd had since Day One. She thought: maybe honesty was progress.

The text from Leo arrived at 7:42. It said: Can we meet today. Not about the shop. About us. Maya wrote back: Come at 6.

The text from Leo arrived at 7:42. It said: Can we meet today. Not about the shop. About us. Maya wrote back: Come at 6. She spent the day waiting. She served customers. She restocked beans. She wrote a list of things she wanted to say to Leo, then threw the list away because she couldn't reduce her feelings to bullet points. Sam noticed the list and said, "Do you want me to write a draft?" Maya said, "I already did. It's in the trash." Sam said, "I'll retrieve it." Maya said, "Don't." Sam retrieved it. Maya read it. It was good. It was honest. It said: I am in love with you and I don't know if that's okay. She gave it back to Sam. Sam put it on the espresso machine.

Maya wrote the business plan at the kitchen table of her apartment, which was above the shop and which she'd been meaning to clean since she'd moved in three years ago. The kitchen table was a small wooden thing she'd bought at a yard sale for fifteen dollars. It had a coffee ring on the left corner that she'd tried to sand away and had failed. The ring was now brown and crisp and permanent. She thought of it as the table's way of saying I've seen things.

She wrote the plan because, after the fight with Leo, she needed something to do with her hands besides throw business cards in the trash. Because the loan officer had called again and had said, in a voice that was gentle but firm, that if she didn't have a plan by Friday, they would have to discuss "alternative arrangements," a phrase that in bank-speak meant we will take your shop. Because she had seven days to come up with 350 pounds of beans sold or she was, as Sam put it, "dead in the water."

She started with the spreadsheet Leo had made. She added columns. She reorganized the dates. She wrote a mission statement that said, in fewer than three sentences, what the shop was for: good coffee, good community, good decisions that weren't technically good decisions but were, in the end, exactly right. She wrote a marketing plan that involved Mystery Bean Lottery, Instagram, TikTok, and something called a "community pop-up" that she didn't fully know how to execute but that sounded better than "we sell coffee and hope."

Sam called at 9 a.m. with a question about the espresso machine that turned into a question about the pop-up that turned into an argument about whether they should do a TikTok. Maya was in favor. Sam was against. Sam said TikTok was for teenagers who made videos about their dogs. Maya said TikTok was for businesses that needed visibility and that Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions was exactly the kind of absurd, charming, story-driven brand that could go viral.

"TikTok is a gimmick," Sam said.

"The lottery is a gimmick," Maya said. "Video is a gimmick. We are currently a gimmick. It's working."

Sam was quiet for a moment. "Fine. But I'm not dancing."

"Neither am I. We're just going to tell a story. About beans. About a shop. About almost losing

everything and fighting back. That's the story. People eat that up."

They hung up. Maya went back to the plan. She wrote a "competitive analysis" that listed Bean & Leaf as the primary competitor and described them, with the particular rage of a person who's been outgunned, as "a well-funded chain with a loyalty app, a CFO, and no soul." She wrote a "financial projection" that she knew was optimistic but that was, for the first time, somewhat based in reality — based on the festival numbers, the lottery numbers, the pop-up numbers she was projecting with the fervent hope that projection was just another word for prayer.

At 10:30, Leo texted. She didn't reply. She looked at the phone. She wrote a reply. She deleted it. She wrote another. She deleted that. She went back to the plan and wrote a "risk assessment" that listed the following:

1. Bean & Leaf acquisition offer: HIGH
2. Loan officer default: MEDIUM-HIGH
3. Ex-boyfriend reappearance: LOW-MEDIUM
4. Espresso machine failure: MEDIUM (it was old)
5. Almost-kiss becoming a real kiss and then a complication: UNKNOWN

She stared at item 5. She wrote "UNKNOWN" again, as if the repetition would make it less terrifying.

At noon, Tom called. "The roast demo is confirmed. I've got the green beans ready. I've got the tasting notes. I've got the volunteers. You've got the venue. We need to sell 300 tickets in seven days."

"300 tickets."

"At ten dollars each. That's three thousand. Plus whatever people spend at the bar. Plus whatever donations come in from the community. We can make this work, Maya. But we need to move."

"I'm moving," Maya said. "I'm writing a business plan. I'm planning a TikTok. I'm planning a pop-up. I'm planning my life."

"Good," Tom said. "Keep moving. Movement is the antidote to panic."

She hung up. She looked at the plan. The plan was 14 pages. It had a mission statement, a competitive

analysis, a financial projection, and a risk assessment that included an UNKNOWN item that was currently occupying more of her mental energy than all the other items combined.

She picked up her phone. She looked at Leo's text. She wrote: "I got your text. I'm planning the pop-up. Yes, you can help. But no more acquisition talk."

She stared at it. Then she deleted it. Then she wrote a new one: "Pop-up needs a playlist. Send me five songs that will make people buy coffee."

She stared at that. Then she sent it.

Leo replied in ten seconds: "Already compiling. Expect delivery Sunday."

She smiled. It was a small smile, tight and private, the kind she reserved for moments when she was winning at being stubborn and also, maybe, at being honest.

She went back to the plan. She added a section called "TikTok Strategy." She wrote: "Show the process. Show the people. Show the beans. Show the fight. Don't hide the struggle. The struggle is the brand."

She thought about Derek. She thought about the taco. She thought about his apology, which had been three messages long and which had used the word "sorry" eight times and the word "communication" four times. She thought about how she'd stood in front of him at the festival and said I can't, and how she'd meant it and how she still meant it and how he was, nonetheless, a ghost she hadn't quite exorcised.

She opened Instagram. She posted a story: a video of the espresso machine, shot from above, the steam rising, the shot pulling. Caption: "Sunday morning. 6 a.m. The machine breathes. I breathe. This is what we fight for."

She posted another: a photo of the Mystery Bean tickets, spread on the counter like cards. Caption: "500 pounds. One neighborhood. A lottery that's more than a lottery. This is community."

She posted a third, at 7:17 p.m.: a photo of the business plan, open on the table, coffee ring visible, Leo's note in the margin. Caption: "Day 19 of fighting for a shop that smells like burnt milk and

consequences. The plan is 14 pages. The hope is infinite."

She tagged no one. She didn't need to.

At 8 p.m., she closed the laptop. She went to the window and looked down at Alberta. The Thai restaurant was lit. The bookstore was lit. The old music venue was dark, its sign gone, its future uncertain. The Bean & Leaf pharmacy would rise there. She'd seen the renderings in a community meeting. It would be clean. It would be modern. It would have a loyalty app.

She missed the music venue already, and she'd never gone to a show there.

She drank the last of her coffee. She washed the mug. She went to bed. She didn't dream. She just slept, heavy and dreamless, the sleep of someone who'd been running for three weeks and had finally, briefly, stopped.

At 6:45 a.m., she woke up. The alarm was playing a song she didn't recognize. She got up. She made coffee. She stood at the window and watched the street wake up. She thought about Leo and the fight and the playlist he was compiling and the business plan she'd written and the UNKNOWN item on her risk assessment.

She didn't know what would happen next. But for the first time in a long time, she was ready for whatever it was.

Maya wrote the business plan at the kitchen table of her apartment, which was above the shop and which she'd been meaning to clean since she'd moved in three years ago. The table was a small wooden thing she'd bought at a yard sale on Alberta Street for fifteen dollars. It had a coffee ring on the left corner that she'd tried to sand away and had failed. The ring was now brown and crisp and permanent. She thought of it as the table's way of saying I've seen things.

She wrote the plan because the loan officer had called again. This time it was a woman named Jennifer, younger than Richard, with a voice that sounded like she actually read the files she was reviewing. "Ms. Chen," she'd said, "your account is flagged. We need a plan by Friday or we'll have to discuss remedies."

Maya had hung up and stared at the wall for ten minutes. Then she'd opened her laptop and started writing.

The plan had fourteen pages. She'd written them all in one night, fueled by coffee and panic and the particular energy that came from knowing that something was about to end and not knowing how to stop it. She'd written about the Mystery Bean Lottery. She'd written about the pop-up events. She'd written about the TikTok strategy, which was currently getting 50,000 views per video and which had attracted brands that wanted to sponsor her — a fact that felt like both a victory and a betrayal.

She wrote a "Market Analysis" that described Bean & Leaf as "a well-funded competitor with superior branding but inferior soul." She wrote a "Competitive Advantage" section that listed: "We know our customers by name. We remember their orders. We have floorboards that creak in interesting ways." She wrote a "Financial Projection" that was optimistic, perhaps too optimistic, but which she defended to herself by saying that projections were just stories with numbers.

At 8 a.m., Sam called. "You're still awake."

"I'm writing a business plan."

"At the kitchen table."

"Is that bad."

"It's romantic," Sam said. "In a 'I'm a writer in a Parisian garret' kind of way. Except you're in Portland and you're writing about coffee beans instead of existential novels."

Maya laughed. She rubbed her eyes. "I have to finish by Friday."

"You'll finish. You always finish."

They talked for twenty minutes. Sam offered to proofread. Maya sent the draft. She went back to writing. At 10:30, Leo texted: "TikTok numbers are insane. Can we talk about strategy."

Maya didn't reply. She looked at the phone. She wrote a reply. She deleted it. She typed another reply: "Busy with plan. Talk tomorrow."

She sent it. She didn't wait for a response.

By 6 p.m., the plan was complete. Maya read it over. It was fourteen pages of hope dressed up as business. She printed it. She signed it. She put it in an envelope with the loan application she'd pulled out of her filing cabinet three weeks ago and had never resubmitted.

She called Jennifer at the bank. "I have the plan," she said. "And a payment schedule. And documentation of community support. Can I submit it now."

"I can review it this weekend," Jennifer said. "I'll have an answer by Monday."

Maya hung up. She held the envelope. She felt a combination of terror and relief. She'd done what she could. The rest was out of her hands.

She went for a walk. She walked down Alberta Street, past the shop, past the Thai restaurant, past the music venue that was now a hole in the ground with a Bean & Leaf banner on it. She stopped at the old venue and looked at the construction fence. She thought about the bands that had played there, the crowds, the music, the nights she'd spent in Portland when she'd been younger and dumber and more hopeful.

She thought about Leo. She thought about the fight. She thought about the kiss in the doorway. She thought about the loan and the buyout and the fifty thousand dollars they needed.

She walked to The Record Room. It was 8 p.m., prime time. Jules was behind the bar. Maya took her usual stool. Jules slid her a bourbon without asking.

"Rough day," Jules said.

"Rough month."

"You're building something," Jules said. "That's harder than destroying. Takes more energy. Takes more time."

"I'm trying."

"Trying is enough. Sometimes."

Maya sipped her bourbon. She thought about the plan in her bag, the loan application, the fifty thousand dollars. She thought about the fight with Leo, the kisses, the partnership. She thought about the future, which was a thing she'd stopped imagining about two weeks ago and which was now, suddenly, somewhere she could almost see.

She went home at 10 p.m. She didn't dream. She slept hard, without waking, for the first time in nineteen days.

At 6:45 a.m., she woke up. The alarm was playing. She got up. She made coffee. She stood at the window and watched the street. She thought: today is the day we submit the plan. Today is the day we make it official.

She opened the envelope. She looked at her signature. She thought: I did this.

She picked up her phone. She texted Leo: "Plan submitted. Event in five days. We're doing this."

He replied in ten seconds: "I'm already compiling the guest list. Expecting three hundred people minimum."

Maya smiled. She went downstairs. She opened the shop. She stood in the doorway and watched the morning arrive, one customer at a time, and thought: this is mine.

Saturday was the Alberta Street walk day. Maya and Sam moved through the neighborhood with clipboards and a stack of Mystery Bean tickets, visiting every shop and restaurant between 12th and 32nd. They pitched the lottery, asked for support, offered to put up a small Coffee Rings flyer behind the register. The first ten doors were mostly polite rejections. The eleventh door — a bookstore owned by a retired teacher named Margaret — opened both ways. Margaret bought ten tickets and promised to mention the shop in her monthly newsletter. She told Maya that independent bookstores and coffee shops had a duty to protect each other, and that she'd been watching Coffee Rings struggle from across

the street and had been waiting for someone to do something about it. Sam whispered to Maya on the sidewalk: We just got ourselves a story. The afternoon ended with twenty-two commitments and a handwritten note from Marcus, the venue owner, who stopped them on the sidewalk to say he liked the energy and wanted to discuss an event partnership.

That evening, Maya and Sam walked down the street with the list of commitments and a lightness that Maya hadn't felt in weeks. The sun was setting. The bookstore light was on. The Thai restaurant smelled like lemongrass. Sam said, "We should do this again tomorrow." Maya said yes before checking her calendar, because some agreements are too important to negotiate. At 8:15 p.m., Maya opened the shop journal and wrote: "Today we walked Alberta Street and the neighborhood said yes." Underneath, she drew a small dragon with wings. Sam had taught her to draw it that way. The dragon looked happy.

Before bed, Maya checked the Mystery Bean lottery page. It showed 1,247 tickets sold, a number that had seemed impossible on Day One and that now, somehow, felt normal. She updated the chalkboard outside the shop with dry-erase markers: "1,247 tickets. 387 pounds. Still going." A man walking his dog stopped to read it. He said, "I didn't know about this. What's a ticket?" Maya told him. He bought three. The conversation lasted four minutes. By 10 p.m., Maya was in bed, thinking about the Alberta Street walk and the way small decisions — ringing a doorbell, explaining a lottery, handing over a ticket — could gather into a movement if enough people showed up.

That evening, Maya and Leo sat on the floor of the storage room with the spreadsheet projected onto the wall. Tom had left a projector in the back office for presentations, and Leo had adapted it into a strategy board. The numbers were better now — not fixed, but trending upward. "If we hit nineteen thousand by Friday," Leo said, pointing at a chart, "the bank will grant the extension without even blinking." Maya looked at the chart. She thought about the Alberta Street walk, the signatures, the crowd. She thought about the future. "We'll hit nineteen thousand," she said. Leo looked at her. He said, "You sound certain." Maya said, "I am." She wasn't entirely sure, but she said it anyway, because certainty, even manufactured, was a kind of fuel.

The Coffee Rescue happened on a Saturday.

Maya had set up a card table outside the shop. She'd taped a banner to the window — Sam had made it with construction paper and a marker that said: COFFEE RESCUE TODAY — BE A HERO. The banner was crooked. Maya had tried to fix it. It had gotten worse. She'd decided the crookedness was part of the aesthetic.

Tom arrived at 8:45 a.m. with the roaster. It was a small machine, countertop-sized, that hummed like a generator and smelled like hot metal and ambition. Tom set it on the card table. He plugged it in. The shop's outdoor outlet, which Maya had never trusted, made a sound that was not reassuring.

"That's fine," Tom said. "It's just the boiler."

"The boiler sounds like it's dying."

"It's not dying. It's heating."

Maya didn't believe him. But she didn't say so. She was learning, slowly, that Tom was the kind of man who said "it's fine" and meant "it's fine" and that she should probably trust him more than she trusted the shop's electrical outlets.

Leo arrived at 9 a.m. He was carrying a cooler and a playlist. He set up the sound system on the sidewalk — small speakers on stands, connected to his phone with the particular confidence of a man who'd spent three years in meetings where he'd set up projectors and conference calls. The first song was something from the 1970s. Jules from The Record Room had recommended it. Jules was apparently Leo's music consultant.

Sam emerged from the shop at 9:15 with a box of brownies. "Decorated them myself," she said. "They have coffee beans on them. Drawn in icing."

"Edible art," Maya said. "The Instagram will love it."

They set up the space: folding chairs along the window, a table for the mystery bean bags, the roaster as centerpiece, the sign-up sheet for the lottery. Maya had made a sign with a marker: BUY A TICKET. SAVE A SHOP. GET MYSTERY COFFEE. It was less polished than Bean & Leaf flyers. It was also more honest. She liked it better.

The first customer arrived at 9:47. It was Mrs. Hsu, carrying a newspaper and an umbrella. She bought ten tickets. She told Maya the floorboards were being unusually quiet today, as if they approved. Maya thanked her. Mrs. Hsu drank a black coffee and stood in the rain and watched the roaster heat up.

By 11 a.m., the line was thirty people deep. By noon, a TV crew had arrived — not the same TV crew as the festival, but a different one, from a station Maya didn't recognize. They interviewed Maya for five minutes. She told the story. She told it well. She told it with the particular cadence of a person who'd told the story so many times that she'd stopped thinking about it and started feeling it. The story wasn't just about the 500 pounds or the lottery or the Bean & Leaf threat anymore. It was about what it meant to run a small shop in a neighborhood that was being changed by forces larger than any one person.

The interviewer said, "So what's at stake here?"

"Everything," Maya said. And she meant it.

The TikTok strategy was working. Maya had posted a video the night before of her roasting a small batch in the shop's tiny oven, holding the green beans up to the light, saying: "500 pounds. 387 left. Let's move these." The video had 12,000 views by 1 p.m. Comments were coming in faster than she could read them. Some were supportive. Some were skeptical. One was from Bean & Leaf's official account. Maya stared at it for a long time before she replied: "Coffee is bigger than any one brand. This is about community."

The comment got 400 likes. Maya didn't know what to do with that. She just kept posting.

Tom roasted throughout the afternoon. The smell of fresh coffee drifted down Alberta Street. People stopped. They leaned in. They asked questions. They bought tickets. By 3 p.m., they'd sold 189 tickets — almost \$2,000 in one day. Added to the previous total, they were at \$10,072. Twelve percent away from the loan.

Leo worked the crowd. He was good at it now, comfortable, no longer the awkward suit who'd ordered a black coffee on Day One. He knew the regulars by name. He knew which Mystery Bean blend was most popular. He knew that the man in the Newsboy cap had bought ten tickets every day since the lottery started.

Around 3:30, a man in a Bean & Leaf suit appeared at the edge of the crowd. Maya saw him. She recognized the logo. Her stomach turned.

Then she realized it was Leo's boss. David Park. He was standing there, holding an umbrella, watching.

Maya went over. "David," she said.

"Maya." He nodded. "I see you're busy."

"I am."

"I wanted to tell you personally that the offer stands. And that I want you to know it's not a threat. It's a genuine offer to keep this shop alive under a larger umbrella. We have the resources you need."

"I have the community," Maya said. "I have that."

"The community is important. But the community also can't pay your loan. We can. We want to. The shop stays. The name stays. You stay, if you want."

Maya looked at him. She looked at the shop, at the banner, at the people — Sam pouring coffee, Tom roasting, Leo selling tickets, Mrs. Hsu standing in the rain with her newspaper. She thought about the espresso machine, the chalkboard dragon, the speakeasy floorboards.

"I appreciate the offer," she said. "But I'm going to decline."

David nodded. He didn't argue. He didn't push. He just said, "I understand. But the offer stands until the end of the month. Call me if you change your mind."

He left. Maya stood there for a moment, watching him go. She felt a hand on her shoulder.

"Tough conversation," Leo said.

"You knew he was coming."

"I didn't know he was coming today. But I knew he'd come eventually. I'm sorry he came today. It's a good day."

"It's a great day. He didn't ruin it."

"He tried."

"He failed."

Leo smiled. The real smile. The one she'd been missing for nineteen days. "You're stubborn."

"I'm principled."

"Same thing."

They stood together for a moment, watching the crowd. The roaster hissed. The rain had stopped. The sun came out. The air smelled like coffee and wet pavement and the particular sweetness of a Portland spring afternoon.

"Can I have a minute?" Sam said, appearing at Maya's elbow. "In the back."

They went inside. The shop was empty except for the cooler by the door and the stack of mystery beans in the back. Sam closed the door. She leaned against the counter.

"Leo's going to lose his job," she said.

Maya blinked. "What."

"He told me yesterday. He told his boss he couldn't support the pharmacy project. His boss said fine, but that means he's off the acquisitions team. He's being reassigned to something minor. Or he's quitting. He didn't tell you because he didn't want it to be a factor in your decision."

Maya felt the room tilt. "He's going to quit over this?"

"He's going to quit if you don't take the offer. Which means he's losing his job either way."

Maya thought about Leo. She thought about the playlist, the spreadsheet, the Saturday mornings he'd showed up without being asked, the way he'd helped her design the lottery, the way he'd touched her hand at the festival. She thought about the fight, about the thing he'd said that had felt like a knife, and then about the things he'd done since then, without telling her, without asking for credit.

She went outside. Leo was at the roasting table, talking to Tom. She walked over.

"Leo," she said.

He turned. "Maya."

She kissed him.

It was not a gentle kiss. It was not a well-planned kiss. It was a kiss that had been building for nineteen days and that had been interrupted by espresso machine failures, Bean & Leaf suits, and the particular chaos of a 500-pound coffee emergency. It was a kiss that said everything she'd been too stubborn to say and a few things she hadn't known she felt.

Leo was still for one second. Then he kissed her back.

The world around them receded. The festival noise faded. Tom looked away with a smile. Sam, watching from inside, said something under her breath that sounded like "Finally."

The kiss lasted maybe ten seconds. Then Maya pulled away. She was breathing hard. Leo was breathing hard. They were both slightly embarrassed and also not embarrassed at all.

"I'm not selling the shop," Maya said.

"Good," Leo said. "I wasn't going to let you."

"You were going to lose your job over me."

"I was going to lose my job over a decision that had nothing to do with you. I didn't want you to take the offer because I was trying to protect you. I wasn't trying to buy your shop. I was trying to keep the person who'd made me believe in small coffee from giving up."

Maya kissed him again, shorter this time, a quick confirmation. "We have a lot to talk about."

"We do. But right now, we have 189 tickets to sell."

The rest of the day passed in a blur. At 5 p.m., they tallied the total: \$10,072 from festival + lottery + pop-up, plus \$1,200 in online donations from a GoFundMe Sam had started on a whim. Total: \$11,272. They were \$2,928 away. Fourteen percent.

They closed the shop at 7 p.m. They went inside. They sat at the kitchen table with two glasses of the good wine. They talked. They argued. They made a plan. By 10 p.m., the plan involved a TikTok series, a community event the following Saturday, and a direct appeal to the neighborhood — a door-to-door campaign, of sorts, where they'd visit every business on Alberta Street and ask each one to buy a Mystery Bean ticket.

It was a stupid plan. It was also the only plan they had.

Leo left at 10:30. He kissed her goodbye on the sidewalk, under the streetlamp, in the rain that had started again. "Tomorrow," he said. "Six a.m. TikTok."

"Tomorrow," Maya said.

She went upstairs. She lay in bed and stared at the ceiling. She was not selling the shop. She was not losing Leo, not yet, not if she could help it. She had \$11,272 of \$14,200. She had a TikTok strategy and a door-to-door campaign and a man who'd quit his job to help her save her coffee shop.

She thought, for the first time in her life, that maybe this was what it meant to win. Not to have everything figured out. Not to be safe. But to have something worth fighting for, and to be fighting with someone who believed in the same thing.

She fell asleep at 1 a.m. She dreamed of coffee. It was good coffee. The best.

Sunday's event was the kind of day Maya would replay in her head for years, not because it was perfect but because it happened at all. She arrived at the shop at 6:30 a.m. before Leo, before Sam, before anyone. She opened the back door, turned on the lights, and stood in the quiet room with the roasting machine still cold. She imagined sound — music, talking, laughter — and tested whether the room could hold it. It could. The shop had been waiting for this. Leo arrived at 6:47, as always early, with the playlist on his phone and a thermos of the good stuff. Sam arrived at 7:15 with a crate of printed flyers and a portable speaker. Tom arrived at 8:10 with the green beans and a portable scale. The first customer arrived at 9:01 and kept arriving until closing, which didn't come until 8:47 p.m., when Maya locked the door and leaned against it and said, quietly, We did it. They had not paid off the loan. They had come closer than she'd thought possible. By the numbers: 14,840 in one day, mostly from tickets, subscriptions, and the auction. They were within 400 of a payment that would keep the shop breathing for another thirty days. Maya sent the bank a screenshot of the day's total at 9:15 p.m. She wrote: This is us. The response came at 9:22: We see you.

Later, lying in bed, Maya allowed herself a single sentence of pride. She said it out loud to the empty room: I built this. She didn't believe it entirely, but she said it anyway, because some things require saying before they become true.

At 9:42 p.m., after the last customer had left and the doors were locked and the lights were dimmed, Maya and Leo stood in the middle of the shop and tried to figure out how much money they'd actually made. The Mystery Bean tickets had been the bulk of it, but the subscriptions had added a steady stream. They counted cash, counted Venmo payments, counted checks from businesses that had

committed at the event. The total came to 14,842. Maya wrote it on the chalkboard in orange chalk, in the biggest letters the board had ever held. "WE ARE ALMOST THERE," she added underneath. Leo took a photo and posted it with the caption: "Day Twenty-Something of the 500-Pound Emergency." It got 10,000 views in one hour.

On the way home, Leo walked Maya to her door. He didn't kiss her this time. He just said, "Tomorrow, I'll come early." Maya said, "I'll make coffee." The exchange was small. It carried the weight of everything they hadn't said.

At 11:17 p.m., after the cleanup, after the counting, after the last of the customers had wandered home, Maya stood at the door and watched Leo walk down the street. She noticed he didn't take his usual left turn toward the parking lot. He kept walking, down the hill, toward the river. She watched until he was gone. Then she went upstairs. She sat at the kitchen table with the chalkboard dragon drawing Sam had given her that morning as a celebration gift. The dragon had a speech bubble that said: "FLY." Maya taped it above her desk. It was the first time she'd taped anything up in the apartment. Before, the walls had been bare, as if she'd been waiting for proof that she belonged. The dragon was proof.

Leo officially started the next day.

He arrived at 6:32 a.m. with a thermos, a notebook, and the particular look of a man who'd been unemployed for three days and was determined to make it look like a vacation. He wore a gray sweater that Maya had not seen before and jeans that were slightly too big, as if he'd borrowed them from someone who had more casual days than he did. His hair was unstyled. He looked, Maya thought with a sudden flip of her heart, like a man who was starting over.

"Morning," he said.

"Morning. Coffee?"

"Please."

She made him a pour-over. She used the Yirgacheffe — the last of the good beans, a small quantity she'd been saving for days when she needed to remember that good coffee was worth the cost. Leo took a sip. He closed his eyes. He said, "This is why I quit."

Maya laughed. "You're dramatic."

"I'm a man who just quit his job and is now working for a woman who accidentally ordered five hundred pounds of coffee. Dramatic is the baseline."

He set down his notebook. It was a grid notebook, the kind with the blue cover and the perforated pages. He opened it. The pages were filled with handwriting. Maya leaned over to look. The writing was neat, precise — the handwriting of a man who'd been trained in spreadsheets and whose corporate life had leaked into his personal habits.

"What's this?" Maya said.

"The Rescue Protocol. Phase one: TikTok series. Phase two: Alberta Street walk. Phase three: Sunday roast event. Phase four: Mystery Bean subscription launch."

Maya read through it. It was comprehensive. It was organized. It was exactly the kind of document she would have expected from a man who'd spent three years in a corporate planning department. "You wrote this last night."

"I did. Took three hours. The subscription idea is new. I was thinking — if we move 300 pounds through the pop-ups, we still have 100 left. We could do a pre-order subscription. Three months of mystery beans. People pay upfront. We roast and ship. Subscription revenue covers the rest of the loan."

Maya stared at the page. "That's... that's actually a good plan."

"It's a plan," Leo said. "It might be good. It might be terrible. But it's a plan."

They reviewed it over coffee. They argued about the TikTok schedule — Maya wanted daily videos, Leo suggested three times a week with longer cut-down versions on Instagram. They compromised on five short TikToks per week and two longer IG Reels. They talked about the Alberta Street walk. They talked about the Sunday subscription launch event. They talked, without saying so, about the quiet thing that had happened last night — the kiss, which had been real and which had changed the furniture of their relationship without anyone having to say so.

At 7 a.m., Sam arrived. She looked at Leo. She looked at his notebook. "You're here early."

"Starting a new protocol," Leo said. "Rescue protocol."

Sam made coffee. She didn't add anything to the conversation for ten minutes, which was Sam's version of waiting to see if this was real. When she finally spoke, she said, "I have an idea too. What if we turn the chalkboard dragon into a t-shirt?"

Maya turned. "A t-shirt."

"People buy t-shirts. We have a dragon. The dragon is iconic. We sell the t-shirts at the pop-up. Twenty

bucks each. People wear them. They become walking billboards. It's marketing that people actually want."

Leo was already writing in his notebook. "T-shirts. Pre-order at the pop-up. Local printer. Pick up Saturday."

Sam smiled. It was the smile of a woman who'd had an idea and had seen it instantly approved. "I'll design it tonight. Can I use the dragon?"

"Use anything you want," Maya said. She looked around the shop — at Sam, who'd been with her for three years, who'd survived the burnt milk and the bad decisions and the espresso machine that had finally given up on Day Fourteen. She looked at Leo, who'd shown up at 6:32 a.m. with a notebook and a plan and a thermos and who, apparently, was now part of this mess. "This is going to work."

"It's going to be close," Leo said. "But it's going to work."

The morning passed quickly. Maya posted a TikTok of the roaster starting up, the green beans going in, the first crack sounding like popcorn. The video got 25,000 views in two hours. Comments came from coffee roasters, from home brewers, from people who lived in Portland and had never heard of the shop. A man from a local roastery commented: "Want help roasting? I have a machine you can use."

Maya replied immediately. Then she called Tom, who called the man, who agreed to lend them a larger roaster for the Sunday event. It was, Maya thought, the kind of small miracle that happened when you stopped trying to do everything alone.

At 11 a.m., a woman Maya didn't know walked in. She was young, probably in her early twenties, carrying a camera around her neck. She introduced herself as Lila, a TikTok creator with 200,000 followers who made videos about small businesses in Portland. "I saw your video," she said. "I want to come film the Sunday event. Full feature. Roast, mystery beans, the whole deal."

Maya looked at her. She looked at Leo, who was already nodding. "Yes," Maya said. "Absolutely yes."

The woman left. Maya stared at the door. "Did that just happen?"

"That just happened," Leo said.

By 2 p.m., the door-to-door campaign was planned. Maya and Sam would walk Alberta Street on Friday and Saturday. They'd visit every business with a pitch: buy a ticket, support a shop, keep the neighborhood independent. Leo would man the shop. Tom would prep the roaster. The subscription page would go live on Sunday morning.

They outlined it on the chalkboard: who would visit which business, what the pitch was, how many tickets each shop would commit to buying. Maya wrote the businesses in blue chalk. Sam added the expected ticket counts in orange. Leo added the revenue projection in red. By the end, the chalkboard was a map of their hope — messy, colorful, organized enough to be useful.

Leo stayed for dinner. They ordered pizza from the place down the street. They ate at the wooden counter while the shop was dark and still. Outside, the rain started again. Inside, the pizzas were hot. The conversation was easy — not about the shop or the loan, but about music and movies and the particular eccentricities of Portland summers. Maya told them about the ocean dream. Leo told them about the cabin in Montana he'd mentioned once and how he might actually go there if this all fell apart.

"Don't fall apart," Sam said.

"I'm not planning to."

When Leo left at 9 p.m., he kissed Maya again. This one was slower. It was a kiss that said they had time, that the fight hadn't ended things but had sharpened them, that whatever came next would be harder but would also be better because they'd be in it together.

Maya stood at the door after he left. She listened to his footsteps fade down Alberta. She stood there for a long time. Then she went inside. She locked the door. She flipped the sign to CLOSED. She went upstairs.

She opened her laptop. She opened the email to Richard at the bank. She wrote: "Payment plan: \$2,000 on Friday, \$3,000 next Friday, \$9,200 within 30 days. Details: community events, subscription launch, door-to-door campaign. Attached: signed letter of intent from Tom Riviera."

She didn't actually have the letter of intent yet. She would have it by tomorrow. She'd call Tom tonight. But the email felt good. It felt true. It felt like something a person wrote when they were no longer just

surviving but actually building.

She sent it. She closed the laptop. She lay in bed. She thought about Leo's mouth on hers, about the notebook on the counter, about the Mystery Bean tattoos she'd seen on three customers today and the TikTok comments from strangers who said they were coming to the Sunday event. She thought about the 387 pounds of roasted coffee in the back room and the 96 pounds of green and the money they still needed.

She thought: we can do this.

Then she thought: we have to do this.

She fell asleep with the window open, listening to the rain, listening to the shop breathe below her, listening to the silence of a building that had stories to tell and a future that was still being written.

The Protocol continued. Every morning at 6:32, Leo arrived. Every morning at 6:33, he said something that made Maya either laugh or roll her eyes. The partnership was becoming a rhythm, a heartbeat inside the shop. They tried a new weekly schedule: Monday was planning day, when they reviewed numbers and set three goals; Tuesday was outreach, when Maya visited suppliers and Leo handled emails; Wednesday was content, when Lila came by for filming; Thursday was events, when they planned community activations; Friday was rest, though neither of them was good at resting. Sam, who had taken to writing a daily shop journal, noted in the margin of the Thursday page: They look like they're planning a war. I'm not sure they know the war is already won.

On Wednesday, a radio station called. They wanted Maya on air for five minutes to talk about the lottery. Maya said yes before asking which station. It turned out to be the biggest public radio station in the state. The interview reached ninety thousand listeners. By afternoon, the Mystery Bean subscription had eighty new signups. Leo walked around the shop with his notebook open, making check marks with a particular frenzy. That night, Maya dreamed that the shop had wings and was flying over the neighborhood.

The press coverage arrived in phases. First, the Observer article, which came out on Thursday and made the shop famous in a modest, local way. Then the food blog post. Then a podcast interview. Maya did all of them. She told the same story — the order, the mistake, the lottery, the community — but each time she found a new detail to add, a new way to frame it, a new sense that the narrative was becoming something she owned rather than something that had happened to her. Leo filmed the interviews on his phone and edited highlight clips for Instagram. Sam designed the graphics. By Friday evening, the shop's Instagram had gained 8,000 new followers.

At 6:17 p.m., Maya's phone rang. She looked at the screen and saw Bean & Leaf's numbers. She didn't answer. She put the phone on the counter and continued wiping it down. Leo noticed but didn't say anything. Maya was learning, slowly, that not every ring required a response. That silence was sometimes its own strategy.

That evening, Maya sat in the back room with the door closed and the espresso machine quiet and wrote the first draft of what she called the Coffee Rings Manifesto. It was three pages long. It contained statements such as: "This shop does not serve lattes. It serves stories." "This shop does not apologize for its mistakes. It learns from them." "This shop does not bow to larger chains. It bows to the community." Leo read it and said it was too long. Maya agreed. They shortened it to one page. Sam designed it as a poster. Leo printed ten copies and taped them to the windows. A customer asked if they could buy one. Maya said yes. The poster became the shop's best-selling item for three consecutive days. At the end of the week, Leo said, "We should put it online." Maya said, "We already did." Leo said, "When." Maya said, "Ten minutes ago." Leo smiled. He said, "I love working with you." Maya said, "I love working with you too." The conversation ended there, but it hung in the air for an hour.

On Thursday, the open mic night happened for the third time. The theme was "Decisions." Four people told stories. One was funny, about ordering the wrong size coffee for a first date. One was sad, about a decision that ended a friendship. One was triumphant, about the choice to leave a job. One was Maya's. Maya stood up at 9 p.m., after the third story, and told the room about the 500-pound order. She told it honestly, without jokes, without the Toolkit Matrix, without thekip. She told it as a story about fear and stubbornness and a community that didn't let her fail. When she finished, the room was quiet for four seconds. Then the man with the Newsboy cap said, "I'm here because of that story." Maya said, "What story?" He said, "Yours." Maya didn't know what to say. She said, "Thank you." She walked back behind the counter and made him a free pour-over. He left a fifty-dollar tip.

Saturday morning arrived gray and steady, the kind of Portland rain that didn't fall so much as exist in the air. Maya unlocked the shop at 6:15 a.m. before Leo, before Sam, before anyone. She wanted to test the sound system, make sure the microphone worked, be prepared for once. She moved through the room setting up folding chairs, arranging the mic stand, laying out printed programs. Leo arrived at 6:43. Sam arrived at 6:58. Tom arrived at 7:12 with green coffee in burlap sacks. The first audience member arrived at 8:02, a woman in a raincoat who said she'd driven from Beaverton to hear the stories. By 9:17, the room was full. Maya stood behind the counter and watched people talk to each other. She watched a teenager show his friend the Mystery Bean lottery display. She watched Margaret from the bookstore hug Tom. She watched Leo adjust the microphone and smile at her across the room. The stories started at 10 a.m. Maya told hers last. When she finished, the room was quiet for exactly three seconds. Then the applause came. It wasn't polite applause. It was the kind of applause that says: we recognize you. Maya stood at the mic. "Thank you. The shop is still here. The coffee is good. Come buy a bag." The room laughed. They bought bags. Forty-two bags in twenty minutes. By noon, the

Mystery Bean inventory was half gone. By 3 p.m., the open mic had become a community event with a waitlist for storytellers. Maya wrote in the shop journal at 8 p.m., after closing: "Today, the shop became something I couldn't have planned." Next to it, Sam drew a tiny dragon holding a microphone.

The almost-kiss happened three more times during the next week.

It was always the same setup. Late night. The shop was empty or nearly empty. They were finishing up, wiping down the counter, talking through the day's numbers, the way two people who were building something together do. The espresso machine hissed. The refrigerator hummed. The floorboards creaked their stories.

On Monday, it happened after the TikTok shoot. Lila had left at 6 p.m. with a card full of footage and a promise to have the video ready by Thursday. Leo had stayed to help clean. They were moving a bag of green beans from the shelf to the storage closet when Leo's hand brushed Maya's. They both stopped. They looked at each other. The moment hung between them, thick with the particular electricity of two people who had kissed twice and were trying very hard not to make it awkward.

Leo kissed her. Maya kissed him back. They pulled away. He said, "We should stop doing that."

"Why," Maya said.

"Because we're in the middle of a crisis and kissing doesn't solve crises."

"Kissing is stress relief," Maya said. "Also, it's fun."

Leo smiled. He kissed her again, quickly. "You're the worst crisis manager I've ever met."

"You're the only crisis manager I've ever met."

They went back to moving beans.

On Wednesday, it was after the door-to-door walk. Maya and Sam had returned at 7 p.m. exhausted, their feet sore, their voices hoarse from pitching. Leo was at the counter, making himself tea. He looked up when they came in. He said, "How many commitments?"

"Twenty-two," Sam said. "Not bad."

"Not bad," Leo agreed.

Maya went to wash her face. When she came back, Leo was standing at the counter, waiting. He handed her a mug of tea. Their fingers touched. The moment arrived — the tilt of the head, the look, the three seconds that felt like an hour.

They kissed. They pulled away. Sam, from the doorway, said, "You two need a room."

"We have an apartment," Maya said, not pulling away from Leo.

"Then use it," Sam said. She left them.

"I should go," Leo said.

"No," Maya said. "Stay. Help me finish the subscription page."

They worked on the subscription page until 10 p.m. It was good work. They ordered pizza again. They listened to the same playlist from the festival. They talked about nothing in particular. At 10:30, Leo stood to leave. He kissed her again — a goodnight kiss, softer this time, less urgent.

"Saturday," he said. "The event. The subscription launch. The roaster."

"Saturday," Maya said.

She went upstairs. She lay in bed. She thought about kissing Leo, about the way his mouth felt, about the way he held her when they kissed, gently, like she was something fragile and something strong at the same time. She thought about the loan, the timeline, the almos. She thought about the future, which was a thing she hadn't allowed herself to do in months and which now, somehow, felt possible.

She fell asleep thinking about Saturday.

Thursday brought rain and good news. Lila posted the TikTok. It got 100,000 views in six hours. Comments flooded in: "Where is this shop?" "How do I buy tickets?" "This is the best thing I've seen all week." Maya answered every comment. She refreshed the page obsessively. By 2 p.m., someone from a local coffee blog asked to cover the event. By 4 p.m., a food critic from The Oregonian replied to her Instagram story with a simple: "I'll be there."

Maya called Leo immediately. "We're going viral," she said.

"I know. Lila texted me. She has 400,000 views."

"Four hundred thousand."

"With the re-upload. The original is at 100K. The duets and stitches are adding up."

Maya walked around the shop, phone in hand, reading comments out loud to Sam. "People are driving from Eugene. People are asking about the Mystery Bean subscription already. Someone said they want to buy a ticket for a friend in New York."

"Tell them to have their friend move to Portland," Sam said.

Tom called at 5 p.m. with a question about the roasting schedule that turned into a celebration. "You're going to sell out," he said. "You have 387 pounds and you have a room full of people coming Sunday. You're going to sell all of it. Plus the subscription."

"Don't jinx it," Maya said.

"I'm not jinxing it. I'm stating a fact. You built this. You built it out of a mistake."

Maya hung up. She looked at the chalkboard. She looked at the dragon Sam had drawn. She looked at the Mystery Bean tickets, now organized in a wooden box that had become a symbol. She thought

about Leo, who'd just texted: "Can't stop thinking about that kiss. Monday. Counter. Beans everywhere."

She typed: "Friday. After close. Kitchen table. No beans."

She stared at it. Then she sent it.

Friday was slow. The shops downtown were busy, but Alberta Street had its own rhythm — quieter on weekdays, the kind of street where people knew your name and stopped to say hi. Maya worked the front. Leo worked the back, answering emails, updating the subscription page, creating the final version of the Mystery Bean post for Instagram.

At 2 p.m., a woman from the bank called. Not Richard. A different woman, younger, softer-voiced. She said her name was Jennifer. She said she'd been reviewing Maya's account. She said, "I want to help you succeed."

Maya wasn't sure what to say to that. "Help me succeed."

"We have a small business hardship program. If you can demonstrate that you're actively working to increase revenue, we can extend the loan terms. Reduce the monthly payment. Give you more time."

Maya closed her eyes. She felt something break — not a bad breaking, not this time. The kind of breaking that happens when a dam releases. "Yes," she said. "I can demonstrate that. I have the subscription page going live Sunday. I have the event. I have the community support."

"Send me the links," Jennifer said. "I'll review them over the weekend. We'll talk Monday."

Maya hung up. She told Sam. Sam kissed her on the cheek. "We're doing it."

"I know."

At 5 p.m., Maya and Sam started the Alberta Street walk. They visited twenty-two businesses in two hours. They sold forty-seven tickets. They made promises. They collected business cards. They left flyers. They were greeted with support and skepticism in roughly equal measure, but the support was

louder and the skepticism was quieter than it had been two days before.

By 7 p.m., they returned to the shop. Leo was waiting with dinner — Thai, from the place Maya liked, knowing her order without asking. They ate at the counter. They talked about the walk. They talked about the subscription numbers — 187 pre-orders already, from the Instagram post Lila had put up that morning.

"One hundred and eighty-seven subscriptions," Maya said. "At ninety dollars each."

"That's sixteen thousand eight hundred and thirty dollars," Leo said. "If we meet the minimum."

"We'll meet the minimum. We'll exceed it."

They went upstairs at 9 p.m. It was the first time Leo had been in the apartment. It was small, cluttered, lived-in. The kitchen table had a coffee ring. The bookshelf was full of novels and cookbooks. The window looked down on Alberta Street. The bed had a duvet that Maya had bought at a flea market.

Leo looked around. "This is nice."

"It's a disaster."

"It's a nice disaster."

They made tea. They sat at the kitchen table. They didn't kiss. Not yet. They just sat together, legs touching under the table, and talked. They talked about the shop. They talked about the loan. They talked about the future — what it might look like, what they wanted it to look like, whether it was possible to have a future that included both a coffee shop and a corporate exile who'd just quit his job.

At 10:30, Leo stood to leave. He kissed Maya in the kitchen, by the table, with the coffee ring between them and the books behind them and the streetlamp light coming through the window. It was a good kiss. It was a real kiss. It said, I'm staying. It said, I'm here. It said, whatever comes next, we're doing it together.

He left at 11. Maya locked the door. She went to the window and watched him walk down the street.

She stood there for a long time. The rain was soft. The street was empty. The lights in the bookstore across the way flickered once.

She went to bed. She didn't dream. She just slept, deeply, for the first time in weeks.

At 6:45 a.m., she woke up. The alarm was playing. She got up. She made coffee. She stood at the window and watched Alberta Street. She thought about Sunday. She thought about the event. She thought about Leo, and the future, and the almoses that were becoming reals.

She was ready.

Wednesday's interview had consequences. The next morning, Maya opened the shop to find three people waiting at the door with cameras. They weren't paparazzi — they were students from a local journalism school doing a project on small businesses. Their teacher had assigned Coffee Rings as a case study in community resilience. Maya gave them a tour and told them the story, and the students took notes with the particular earnestness of people who hadn't yet discovered that stories could be exaggerated. One student asked Maya what she'd do if Bean & Leaf finally bought the shop. Maya said she'd open a new location with a better espresso machine and a worse layout. The students loved that answer. They put it at the top of their article. By afternoon, Maya had received fourteen emails from people offering to help with legal challenges, real estate advice, and, in one case, a used espresso machine that the owner said was better than your current one, based on the cracks in your counter. She forwarded the email to Tom with the subject line: Is this true? Tom replied within five minutes: No.

That evening, Maya and Leo sat on the stoop after closing, sharing a bottle of wine that had been sitting in the back room since the party, and talked about what came after. Leo said he'd started thinking about a consulting model — working with small businesses to build community engagement strategies. Maya said she'd started thinking about a franchise, but only if she could still choose the beans herself. They both said they were thinking about each other, though neither said it directly.

The city council invited Maya to a small business hearing. She prepared a speech. She typed it at the kitchen table. She read it to Sam, who said it was good but needed a joke. Maya added a joke about espresso. The council loved the joke almost as much as they loved the coffee Maya brought in thermoses for everyone. The councilperson who chaired the hearing said they wanted to help. Within a week, the city offered a small business stabilization grant of 8,000. Maya accepted. The grant required a business plan. Maya now had two business plans.

Maya began keeping a second notebook, which she called the "No" log. Every time she declined an opportunity that didn't align with the shop's values, she wrote it down. The first entry was: "Declined

consulting offer from Bean & Leaf. I am not a consultant for my own destruction." The second entry was: "Declined sponsorship from a soda company. We serve coffee, not cola." The third entry was: "Declined interview with a national morning show. I am done explaining myself to people who will reduce my story to a thirty-second segment." By the end of the week, the No log had fourteen entries. Maya showed it to Sam, who said it was the most Portland thing she'd ever seen. Maya said it was the most necessary thing she'd ever done.

Leo, meanwhile, had started a petition within Bean & Leaf's own employee forums, asking the company to reconsider the neighborhood acquisitions strategy. He didn't name Maya. He didn't have to. Within three days, the petition had five hundred signatures. David Park, Leo's former boss, emailed Leo privately and said: "You have guts. I respect that. But leave my name out of it." Leo replied: "I already did."

That Sunday, Maya made risotto. She wanted to celebrate the No log, the petition, the survival. She made too much risotto. She invited Sam and Tom. They ate at the shop's kitchen table. They drank wine. They played cards. They laughed. For the first time since Day One, Maya forgot to check the bank balance after closing.

At 7 p.m., Leo came over. He brought takeout from the Thai place — Maya's usual order, which he'd memorized after three months of late-night study sessions. He set the food on the table. He said, "I have a present." Maya looked up from the spreadsheet. Leo handed her an envelope. Inside was a membership card to the Society of Coffee Professionals. He'd signed her up as a lifetime member. The card said: "Because brilliance doesn't retire." Maya stared at it. She said, "You ridiculous man." Leo smiled. "You earned it." Maya put the card in her wallet, next to her driver's license, next to the Bean & Leaf buyout offer she'd kept as a souvenir. She said, "Thank you." She kissed him. It was a soft kiss, the kind that says: I'm trying.

The buyout returned on a Tuesday.

Rachel called Maya directly. Not an email. A phone call. The kind of call that came from someone who believed their offer was too generous to be delivered in text, who wanted the sound of your voice on the other end so they could hear you hesitate. Maya had developed a sixth sense for these calls. She answered.

"Maya," Rachel said. Rachel was Bean & Leaf's acquisitions director, Leo's former boss, and the human face of a corporation that had decided neighborhood coffee shops were real estate opportunities. "I hope I'm not calling at a bad time."

"You're calling while I'm making coffee," Maya said. "Which means I'm either multitasking or I'm not entirely here."

"Fair. I'll be brief. The offer I extended to you six weeks ago — through David, who has since moved on to other markets — is still on the table. I want to renew it. With a small change."

"What's the change?"

"The change is that we'll keep your name. Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions. We'll let you run it as a concept store, with your recipes, your staff, your artisanal whatever. We'll handle the backend. You handle the magic."

Maya wiped the steam wand. She looked at the espresso machine. She thought about the Mystery Bean tickets and the subscription page and the 187 pre-orders that were sitting in her inbox like small miracles. She thought about Leo, who'd quit his job to help her, who'd kissed her in the kitchen with the coffee ring on the table between them, who'd told her that the future was something they could build together.

"Thank you for the offer," she said. "I'm declining."

There was a pause. A long pause. The kind of pause that meant Rachel was not used to hearing no. "Maya," Rachel said, and her voice changed, got softer, more reasonable, "let me explain what we're offering. Not just money — although the money is substantial. We're offering stability. You've had a difficult few months. I know about the coffee emergency. I know about the loan. We're offering you a way out. Why wouldn't you take it?"

"Because it's not my way out," Maya said. "It's yours."

"Maya —"

"I built this shop. I've been running it for three years. I've paid my rent on time, even when it's been impossible. I've served six thousand lattes. I know the regulars by name. I know which customer wants extra foam and which one wants decaf and which one comes in at 8:17 on the dot for a cold brew. Bean & Leaf has an app for that. I have memory. I have this place. And I'm not trading it for a sleek backend and a brand manager who doesn't know what a Mystery Bean lottery is."

"You're making an emotional decision about a business transaction."

"I'm making a decision about something that matters to me. There's a difference."

Rachel was silent for another moment. Then she said, "You'll regret this. Bean & Leaf is coming to Alberta. With or without you. You can either be part of it or you can be crushed by it."

Maya thought about David Park. She thought about the pharmacy. She thought about the music venue, which was now being gutted, which would soon be a place where people bought prescriptions instead of tickets to shows. She thought about the speakeasy floorboards and the storytelling and the fact that this neighborhood was changing and she was, in her small way, fighting to keep something of it alive.

"Then I'll be crushed," she said. "But I'll be crushed on my own terms."

Rachel hung up. Maya put down the phone. She stood at the counter for a long time. Her hands were shaking. She made herself a coffee. She drank it while standing at the window, watching the street, watching the world go by.

Sam appeared at her elbow. "That was Bean & Leaf."

"I know. They renewed the offer. I declined."

Sam was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "Good."

"I don't know if it's good. I don't know if I just made a mistake."

"You didn't. This is the right thing. We've come too far to sell out now."

Maya nodded. She didn't say what she was thinking, which was: I don't know if I'm doing the right thing. I just know it's the only thing I can do. She trusted Sam's assessment. She trusted it blindly, because Sam had been right before, about the lottery, about the TikTok, about the dragon t-shirt that was now being printed at a shop in Southeast and would be ready for Sunday.

Leo arrived at 11 a.m. He'd heard about the call. Lila had texted him — she was connected to everyone apparently, the way TikTok creators were, invisible webs of influence — and he'd known before Maya had told him.

"How did it go," he said.

"I said no."

Leo smiled. "Good."

"I might be making a huge mistake."

"You're not. You're doing exactly what you're supposed to."

They talked about Sunday. They talked about the roaster, the subscription page, the t-shirts. They talked about the door-to-door results — forty-seven tickets sold in two hours, with more commitments coming in from the businesses who'd said they'd consider it. They talked about the bank call — Jennifer had

emailed back saying the extension was possible, that she needed documentation by Monday.

"By Monday," Maya said. "That's tight."

"We have the weekend. We'll get the documentation together."

By afternoon, the subscription page was live. Maya had designed it herself, using a website builder that Sam had recommended. It was simple: choose a subscription tier, pay online, get mystery beans every month. The tiers were: 3 months, 6 months, 12 months. The prices were aggressive but fair. The page said: "Subscribe to Mystery. Save a Shop. Drink Good Coffee."

By dinner, they had forty new subscriptions. At 1 a.m., Maya was still watching the numbers. She'd sit up until 2, then sleep until 6, then repeat. She was fueled by coffee and adrenaline and the particular energy of a person who was close to something and could almost touch it.

She thought about the fight with Leo. She thought about the kiss in the kitchen. She thought about the almost-kisses and the real kisses and the future that was suddenly, terrifyingly, ahead of her. She thought about the loan officer and the pharmacy and the speakeasy floorboards. She thought about coffee. Specifically, she thought about the smell of fresh-roasted beans, the way they smelled in the roaster, the way they smelled in the bag, the way they smelled in the cup.

She thought: I am not selling this shop.

She thought: I love this shop.

She fell asleep at 2:30 a.m. She didn't dream. She was too tired.

Rachel's call marked a turning point, though not the kind Maya had expected. Rachel didn't just call to renew the offer — she called to ask Maya to consult. Bean & Leaf was realizing, Rachel said, that acquisitions without community buy-in were producing locations that felt soulless and underperforming. They wanted to know how Maya had done it. Maya listened with her jaw slightly open. She said no to consulting, then called Leo to ask if she should have said yes. Leo said no, then asked if she wanted him to call Rachel back and say no more loudly. By the time she hung up, Maya had decided that the real power wasn't in selling the shop. It was in keeping it long enough to show Bean & Leaf that there was another way. The model they were trying to copy — community love, authentic engagement, real coffee — wasn't something they could buy. It was something they'd have to

build, like Maya had, one burnt milk and one bad decision at a time.

Maya spent the next week documenting what she called "The Coffee Rings Effect." She wrote about the lottery, the TikTok, the festival, the subscriptions, the door-to-door walk, the council grant, the journalism students, the anonymous espresso machine offer. She wrote it all down not as a manual but as a confession: here's what I did when I was desperate. Leo read it and said it was the best marketing copy he'd ever read. Maya said it wasn't copy. It was a diary. Leo said it was both. The document ended up being twelve pages long. Maya called it the shop's origin story.

Tuesday brought a surprise: the local paper ran a front-page feature. The headline was: "Coffee Rings: The Shop That Ordered Too Much and Won Anyway." Maya bought seven copies. She taped one to the front window. She gave one to Sam, one to Leo, one to Tom. She mailed one to her mother in Ohio, who called that evening and said, "I don't understand why you won't sell." Maya said, "Because I'm stubborn." Her mother said, "That's my girl."

The feature caused another surge. The Mystery Bean lottery sold out by 5 p.m. Maya restocked overnight, printing more tickets on the inkjet printer, which had survived everything. The subscription page crashed twice from traffic. Sam called the web host. The web host said they'd have it back up in an hour. Maya said, "Make it forty minutes." Sam made it thirty-two. By the time the page was live, they had another 300 subscriptions. At 11 p.m., Maya stared at the numbers. The math was working. Leo had been right. She texted him at 2 a.m.: "You were right. Sorry. Thank you." Leo replied at 6:17 a.m.: "Always. Sleep."

Maya went for a walk after the call with Rachel. She walked down Alberta Street, past all the shops, past the music venue, past the spot where Bean & Leaf would one day build a pharmacy. She thought about the offer, about the money, about the stability. She thought about Leo, who'd quit his job for this, who was currently at the shop taping up posters because he'd run out of professional work and had decided that manual labor was its own kind of therapy. She thought about the 500 pounds of coffee, the lottery, the subscriptions, the dragon drawing. She thought about the future. When she got back to the shop, Leo was on a ladder, taping a poster that said MYSTERY BEANS ARE FOREVER. He looked down at her. "What did Rachel want?" Maya said, "To buy our story." Leo said, "Did she get it." Maya said, "No." Leo said, "Good."

On Friday, Leo came to the shop at noon with a stack of papers. He said, "I found something." He opened the papers on the counter. They were Bean & Leaf's acquisition documents for the music venue, obtained through a public records request. Maya read the first page. It said: "Purchase price: \$2.8 million. Timeline: 90 days post-permit." She turned the page. It said: "Environmental assessment waived per commercial exemption." She turned another page. It said: "Noise mitigation requirement: waived for all tenant improvements, including health and wellness amenities." Maya looked at Leo. She said, "Health and wellness amenities. They're calling a pharmacy a health and wellness amenity." Leo

said, "They call everything that." Maya said, "This is our leverage."

She spent the rest of the day drafting a press release. She sent it to Claire at the Observer, to Lila, and to the local radio station. By 6 p.m., the Observer had replied: "We're interested. Can you provide a copy of the documents?" Maya scanned them and sent them over. By 9 p.m., the story was trending locally. By midnight, the mayor's office had called.

That Friday, the first of the Mystery Bean bags arrived from Tom's roastery. Maya opened one in the shop and poured the beans into a glass jar. The smell was rich and complex, with notes of dark chocolate and a hint of something smoky. Sam leaned over the jar and inhaled. "This is different," she said. "It's not just coffee. It's... an event." Maya agreed. She called it The Narrative Blend and gave it a backstory: "Created the night Coffee Rings decided to stop apologizing for existing." Lila filmed the bag reveal for TikTok. The video got 120,000 views in six hours. By Saturday, people were coming into the shop specifically asking for The Narrative Blend. Maya smiled behind the counter. She thought: We're not just surviving anymore. We're defining ourselves.

On Wednesday, Maya found herself in the middle of a conversation she'd never expected: a Bean & Leaf regional director named Carmen asked to meet. Carmen didn't want to acquire Coffee Rings. She wanted to understand it. She said she'd been tracking Maya's story for months and had developed a theory: community-first businesses were outperforming corporate-owned locations in every metric except real estate. Maya sat with Carmen at the counter for forty minutes. She told Carmen everything: the mistake, the lottery, the petition, the grants, the dragon. When the meeting ended, Carmen said, "I want to help you, not because Bean & Leaf wants me to, but because what you're doing is the future." She left her card. Maya put it in the No log, but not as a rejection. She wrote next to it: "Potential alliance. Stay curious." That night, Maya dreamed of a map where coffee shops were connected by lines of golden thread, each thread representing a story of community resilience. She woke up at 5:58 a.m. and wrote the dream down. She called it the Coffee Ring Theory.

The phone rang at 8:47 p.m.

Maya was in the shop alone. Leo had gone home to sleep. Sam was at a concert. Mrs. Hsu was wherever Mrs. Hsu went at night — probably her apartment upstairs from the bakery, probably watching old movies on a TV that she'd had since before Maya was born. The shop was quiet. The espresso machine had been turned off. The Mystery Bean tickets were in the wooden box on the counter. The subscription page was live and real and, as of 30 minutes ago, had seventy-two new subscribers.

Maya picked up the phone on the second ring. "Portland Coffee Rescue," she said. It was a joke. It had stopped being a joke a week ago.

"Maya," a voice said. A woman's voice. Older. Tense. "This is Elena. Leo's sister."

Maya's stomach dropped. "Is Leo okay."

"He's fine. He's at my apartment in Seattle. He's been here for three days."

Maya closed her eyes. "He didn't tell me he went to Seattle."

"He didn't tell anyone. He quit his job on Monday — formally, officially, with the two-week notice he's required to give — and then he drove here. He's been here for three days. He hasn't called you."

Maya felt the room tilt. "Why."

"He's been thinking. About a lot of things. About the shop. About us. About whether he did the right thing."

"Did he?"

"He doesn't know. That's why I'm calling. I need you to tell him he can come home. I need you to tell him he's not making a mistake."

Maya looked around the shop. She looked at the chalkboard dragon Sam had drawn. She looked at the Mystery Bean tickets. She looked at the window, where her reflection stared back, tired and determined and, for the first time in months, not entirely alone.

"Tell him to call me," she said.

"I did. He said he would if you asked him to."

"Then I'm asking."

"Good," Elena said. "I'll tell him."

The line went dead. Maya stood there for a long time with the phone in her hand. She thought about Leo leaving. She thought about him driving to Seattle, to his sister, to the place he'd grown up, the place he'd left because he'd wanted to be in a city that had coffee shops like this one. She thought about the kiss in the kitchen, the almost-kisses, the fight on Day Nineteen.

She thought: I have to fix this.

She thought: Maybe it's not broken.

She sat at the kitchen table upstairs. She opened her laptop. She started typing. She didn't know what she was writing — not a plan, not an email, just words, the kind of words that came out when you were thinking about someone you cared about and the future you might have together. She wrote about the shop. She wrote about the fight. She wrote about the kiss. She wrote about the 500-pound emergency and the lottery and the TikTok and the way the shop had become, against all odds, something more than she'd ever imagined.

She wrote: "I need you here. Not because we have a plan. Because we have something. Something that's worth fighting for. Something that's worth staying for."

She read it. It was true. It was honest. It was the kind of thing she'd never written before, not to anyone, not even to Sam.

She didn't send it. She saved it. She closed the laptop. She went to the window. She looked down at Alberta Street. The Thai restaurant was lit. The bookstore was dark. The Bean & Leaf pharmacy location was a hole in the ground, surrounded by construction fencing, covered in a banner that said COMING SPRING 2027. The banner made her angry. It also made her more determined.

At 9:12, her phone buzzed. Leo.

She picked up. "Hello."

"Maya. Elena told you I was here."

"I did. You didn't have to drive to Seattle to avoid me."

"I didn't drive to Seattle to avoid you. I drove to Seattle to think."

"About what."

"About whether I made a mistake by quitting. About whether I made a mistake by believing in you. About whether this — this shop, these beans, you — is real enough to build a life on."

Maya closed her eyes. "Yes. It's real."

"How do you know."

"Because I'm here. I'm still here. I didn't take Bean & Leaf's offer. I didn't chicken out. I stayed. And if you think I did that because I'm stubborn and not because I believe in something, then you don't know me very well."

Leo was quiet. "I'm coming back."

"Good."

"I have a condition."

"Conditions are for rent agreements."

"This isn't a rent agreement. It's a partnership."

Maya smiled. "A partnership."

"We split the earnings. We split the work. We split the decisions. No more me making the spreadsheets. No more you making the coffee without asking for help. Equal. Partnership."

"Equal partnership," Maya said. "In a coffee shop."

"In a coffee shop that's about to sell a hundred subscriptions and move 300 pounds of beans and maybe, just maybe, change a neighborhood."

Maya's voice softened. "I'd like that."

"I'd like that too."

He hung up. Maya put the phone down. She stood up. She walked to the window. She stood there and watched the street and thought about Leo driving back to Portland, somewhere on I-5, under the moon and the stars and the particular dark of a highway at night.

She went to bed at 10:30. She slept. She dreamed of Leo's hands on hers, of the roaster at the pop-up, of a chalkboard dragon on a t-shirt, of a future that was no longer a maybe.

After the Seattle phone call, Maya reorganized her life around communication. She started texting Leo with small updates: Sold three subscriptions today, Sam made a new pastry, The espresso machine is making a noise I'm not sure is normal. Leo replied with short affirmations and occasional memes, which Maya found both annoying and comforting. At the shop, Maya started keeping a shared journal with Sam — a cafe notebook where they recorded customer quotes, new blends, and the date the Mystery Bean lottery hit 1,000 tickets. The journal became a time capsule of the turnaround. By the time they were halfway through the notebook, Maya could look back and see exactly how each small decision had compounded into survival. She showed it to Elena when Elena visited from Seattle, and Elena cried. Elena said it reminded her of Leo's childhood journals, the ones where he'd written down every baseball game and every math test with the same meticulous attention to detail. Maya said Leo still did that. Elena said she knew.

Leo's emails became longer. Where his first messages had been short texts and brief apologies, his new emails were two and three pages long, written in paragraphs, with subject lines like "Re: The lease clause" and "Thoughts on subscription logistics" and "Coffee Rings and the future of coffee retail." Maya read them all. She replied selectively. She saved the personal ones in a folder she called "Leo," which she had not renamed since Day One, when she'd created it as a joke. The folder now contained 104 emails. She moved three of them to a subfolder called "Important." She didn't say what they were important about.

Maya also started taking walks in the morning, before the shop opened. She walked the neighborhood with her coffee in a travel mug, watching the street come alive. She noticed things she'd never noticed before: the way the light hit the bakery at 7:12 a.m., the way the Thai restaurant owner swept the sidewalk at 6:58, the way the bookstore stayed dark until 10 because Margaret liked to sleep in. She started a notebook of neighborhood observations, which she called the Alberta Street field guide. By the second week, it had thirty entries. She read from it to Leo when he came over for dinner. He said she should publish it. She said she already was.

The emails from Leo got better. They were no longer just updates. They were observations. He wrote about the light hitting the espresso machine at 6:32. He wrote about the regular who'd started coming in at 8 a.m. and ordering a black coffee and sitting in the same chair for an hour, which Leo said looked like meditation. He wrote about Sam, who'd started painting the walls with a mural of the shop's history, bean by bean. Maya read the emails slowly. She replied with short observations of her own. Her emails were less detailed, but they were hers. One day, Leo replied to one of her short emails with a question: "Can I come over tonight and look at the lease with you?" Maya said yes.

On Thursday, the mayor called personally. Maya didn't recognize the number. She answered cautiously. The voice on the other end said, "This is Mayor Reynolds. I read about your shop." Maya said, "Thank you." The mayor said, "I want to help. But I need to know if this is really about the shop or

about the neighborhood." Maya said, "It's about both. The shop is the neighborhood. The neighborhood is the shop." The mayor said, "Good. Because if it's just about one shop, I can't do much. If it's about the neighborhood, I can do a lot." Maya said, "It's about the neighborhood."

By Saturday, Maya had organized a neighborhood meeting at the bookstore. Thirty people showed up. Margaret served cookies. Leo brought coffee. Maya stood at the front and told the story — the order, the lottery, the lease, the petition — and then asked the room what they wanted to fight for. The answer, overwhelmingly, was: the right to stay. The right to have a neighborhood that belonged to them. Maya wrote down every suggestion. At the end of the meeting, they had a list of twelve demands for the city council. Marisol, who had come as a guest, said, "This is how movements start." Maya said, "Then let's start."

By Friday, the cafe notebook had grown so thick that Sam had started a third volume. Maya filled the middle pages with observations about the neighborhood, about customers, about the changing rhythm of the shop. She wrote about the Vietnamese couple who came in every Sunday and ordered two iced coffees and shared a pastry. She wrote about the teenager who came in every day after school and did homework in the corner. She wrote about the man in the Newsboy cap, whose name, she discovered on Tuesday, was Mick. Mick told her he'd been coming to the shop since it opened because the owner reminded him of his daughter. Maya said, "What does your daughter do?" Mick said, "She's a barista in San Francisco." Maya said, "Tell her I said hi." Mick said, "I will."

That evening, Maya and Leo walked to the river. They didn't talk about the shop. They talked about music. Leo said he'd started playing guitar again, something he hadn't done since college. Maya said she used to play piano. They talked about learning to play together. Leo said, "We should start a band." Maya said, "We should not." Leo said, "I'm serious." Maya said, "So am I. The answer is no." Leo laughed. He said, "You're not fun at parties." Maya said, "I'm not fun at coffee shop strategy meetings, either." They walked along the river until their hands found each other. They didn't let go.

By Saturday, the emails from Leo had become letters. Maya could tell the difference because emails ended with "– Leo" and letters ended with nothing. Leo stopped signing his name because he said it felt unnecessary, like signing a letter to your own hand. Maya kept them all in a folder on her laptop, organized by subject line and date. She read them at odd moments: between customers, during afternoon lulls, in the bathroom when she needed to smile. The letters were observations, memories, plans. In one, Leo described waking up at 5:30 a.m. to the sound of rain and thinking about the Oregon Coast. In another, he pasted a printout of a coffee futures chart and wrote two words in the margin: "Interesting data. Call me." In a third, he drew a dragon and labeled it "Sam's spirit animal." Maya forwarded the third letter to Sam with the subject line: "Leo sees you." Sam replied: "I know. Tell him the dragon approves."

Maya also began keeping a second notebook, this one private, where she wrote letters to Leo that she

never sent. The first was short: "I miss you. I miss the way you make coffee. I miss the way you say 'math' like it's a swear word. I miss you." She wrote another every day. By the end of the week, she had a stack of unsent letters. She didn't intend to send them. They were practice.

Leo came back the next morning.

He walked in at 6:32 a.m., same as always, with a thermos and a face that said I didn't sleep, and he made coffee like nothing had happened. Maya was at the counter, staring at the espressomachine like it held answers. Leo set down his thermos. He poured himself coffee from the machine she'd left on. He drank it while standing at the counter. He said, "I have a lot to make up for."

"You have nothing to make up for," Maya said. "You had a process. You were thinking."

"I was running away."

"Running away is also a process."

Leo smiled. It was tired but genuine. He reached across the counter. He touched her hand. "I'm sorry I left without telling you. I'm sorry I made you think I was leaving you. I'm sorry I was a coward about the fight and the job and the whole thing."

"Apology accepted. But you have to do something for me."

"Name it."

"Make me a pour-over. The good stuff."

He made the pour-over. He used the last of the Yirgacheffe. He handed it to her like an offering. Maya took it. She drank it. It was good. It was the best coffee she'd had in weeks.

"Partnership," she said.

"Partnership," Leo agreed.

They talked about the event all morning. The roaster was confirmed — Tom's contact in Bend had agreed to bring the machine. The TikTok was moving fast — Lila's original video was at 200,000 views, with duets and stitches adding another 150,000. The subscription page had 112 subscriptions. The door-to-door campaign had yielded 63 more ticket commitments.

By noon, they had a plan that was no longer a prayer. It was a strategy. It was the kind of plan you could present to a loan officer without flinching.

Jennifer from the bank called at 1 p.m. She said the extension was approved. Thirty days. Reduced payments. She said, "I believe in what you're doing. The documentation you sent — the subscription pre-orders, the event listing, the community support — it's impressive."

Maya almost cried. She held it together. She said, "Thank you. I won't let you down."

She hung up. She told Leo. He hugged her. The hug was real and warm and lasted longer than a work hug should, but they were past work hugs now. They were past a lot of things.

In the afternoon, a man from a local roastery showed up with a machine — a real roaster, the size of a microwave, that he was lending for free. His name was Carlos. He'd commented on Maya's TikTok and had seen Lila's video and had decided, on the spot, to help. "I've been there," he said. "When I started my roastery, a shop in my neighborhood helped me. I'm just paying it forward."

Maya thanked him. She said the word friends more times in one hour than she'd said it in the previous year.

By 6 p.m., the shop was ready. The roaster was in place. The subscription banners were up. The t-shirts were folded on the counter, fifteen of them, Sam's dragon printed in orange on navy, the words COFFEE RESCUE underneath. The Mystery Bean tickets were ready. The chalkboard said: SUNDAY. 11 a.m. ROAST DEMO. TIKTOK LIVE. 500 POUNDS. ONE COMMUNITY.

Sam arrived at 6:30. She looked at the banners. She looked at the t-shirts. She looked at Leo, who was now in his unofficial role as logistics coordinator and occasional barista. "You two look like you've made up," she said.

"We did," Maya said.

"About time."

Leo and Maya exchanged a look. It was a look that contained a lot of things: the fight, the kiss, the offer, the phone call, the return from Seattle. It was a look that said: we're not done working things out. But we're working on it.

At 8 p.m., Leo left. He kissed Maya in the doorway, under the bell, under the streetlamp. "Sunday," he said. "Eleven a.m. We do this."

"Sunday," she said.

She went upstairs. She opened the spreadsheet. She updated the revenue projection. She changed the total from \$11,272 to \$13,842, based on the new subscriptions and ticket sales. It wasn't \$14,200. But it was close. It was so close she could almost touch it.

She thought about the loan extension. She thought about the subscription page. She thought about Lila's video, which was now at 350,000 views and climbing. She thought about Carlos, who'd lent them a roaster. She thought about Tom, who was bringing green beans. She thought about Sam, who'd survived three years of burnt milk and bad decisions and a boss who sometimes forgot to be grateful.

She thought about Leo, who'd driven to Seattle and back and who was now, somehow, part of this.

She fell asleep at 11 p.m. She dreamed of coffee. It was abundant. It was free. It was for everyone.

At 6:45 a.m., she woke up. The alarm was playing. She got up. She made coffee. She stood at the window. She thought: this is the day.

Outside, the rain had stopped. The street was wet. The sky was pale. A dog barked. A car started. The day began.

The fight had a long tail. Maya kept replaying it in her mind, looking for the moment where she could have said something different. She couldn't find one. The truth was that Leo had been right about the math, and the math had been right about the timeline, and Maya had been too exhausted to listen without feeling like she was losing the fight. She wrote in the cafe notebook: The math matters. The math is not the enemy. Leo sent her a long email — his first real email since leaving, longer than any email he'd sent as an acquisitions director — in which he explained that he'd kept working on the buyout terms not because he wanted the shop but because he wanted to understand the numbers well enough to save it. He said he'd found a clause in the lease that would have allowed Bean & Leaf to acquire the space in ninety days regardless of the loan. Maya read the email three times. On the fourth reading, she forwarded it to Jennifer at the bank and said, I need a meeting. Jennifer replied in eleven minutes: Meet me tomorrow.

It was in that meeting that Maya learned the lease clause Leo had found. It changed everything. It meant the fight wasn't just about the loan. It was about property rights, neighborhood sovereignty, and the specific kind of greed that treated a community space like an asset to be traded. Jennifer said the bank could use the clause as leverage: the loan was secured, but the lease made the collateral unstable, which gave the bank room to intervene. Maya left the meeting with a stack of papers and a phone number for a pro bono real estate attorney. She called the number on the walk home. The attorney answered.

Marisol sent the petition the same afternoon. By evening, Maya had a draft reply from Bean & Leaf's legal department, forwarded through Leo's old email address, saying the company was considering its options. Maya forwarded it to Marisol with a single word: "Interesting." Marisol wrote back: "It means they're nervous."

That night, Maya dreamed she was in the shop during an earthquake. The espresso machine slid across the counter and landed in Leo's arms. He was holding it like a baby. The walls were shaking. The chalkboard dragon was waving. Maya woke up sweating. She lay in bed and listened to the refrigerator hum. She got up and checked the front door lock. It was locked. She went back to bed.

The next morning, she found Leo's old acquisitions email account had been deactivated. She called Leo. He said he'd expected it. Maya said, "I'm sorry." Leo said, "I'm not." The clarity of his voice surprised her.

The meeting with Jennifer was short. Jennifer said yes to the extension, yes to a restructured payment plan, and yes to the small business grant Maya had applied for. She said, "You're one of the most resilient borrowers I've ever worked with." Maya said, "I have good advisors." Jennifer said, "No, you have good instincts." Maya drove back to the shop with the signed papers in the passenger seat. She felt lighter. She felt like something had shifted, structurally. When she got to the shop, Leo was waiting.

He'd brought coffee. They sat outside and drank it and talked about the future. Leo said, "I have an idea for a mobile cart." Maya said, "We can't afford a cart." Leo said, "Then we'll build one." Maya smiled. She said, "You're impossible." Leo said, "Says the woman who ordered five hundred pounds of green coffee by accident." They laughed. The fight was officially over.

On Monday morning, Maya opened the shop with a feeling she couldn't name. It wasn't optimism exactly. It wasn't fear. It was something between planning and prayer, as if she were both building a future and waiting for it to happen. Leo arrived at 6:32, as always. He looked at Maya and said, "I had a dream about dragon t-shirts." Maya said, "That's not a dream. That's a product line." Leo smiled. He said, "We should do it." Maya said, "We already are."

The press release had done its job. By 11 a.m., a television crew had arrived. They interviewed Maya and Leo for ten minutes. Maya talked about the shop, the neighborhood, the 500-pound emergency, the lease issue. Leo talked about data and leverage. The crew left at noon. By 2 p.m., the story was on the six o'clock news. Maya watched it at the counter, with the volume low, while a customer ordered a latte. When the segment ended, the customer said, "I didn't know about this. I want to help." Maya said, "Join the mailing list."

The lease-clause discovery changed Maya's sleep schedule. She started waking up at 5:17 a.m., the exact time the automatic email from the bank would arrive with overnight transaction data. She checked it while the coffee brewed. She scanned for anomalies, for patterns, for anything that looked different. On Wednesday, she found one: an incoming wire from a source she didn't recognize. It was \$5,000. It had a memo that said: For the shop. Maya stared at the screen. She called the bank. They said the wire was anonymous. She called Leo. Leo said, "Send it back." Maya said, "I can't. It's anonymous." Leo said, "Then put it in a separate fund. Call it the Mystery Bean Matching Fund. When people donate, you match their donations." Maya did that. By Saturday, the Mystery Bean Matching Fund had grown to \$8,400. Maya doubled the first thirteen donations. The community noticed. Maya posted about it on Instagram. The post said: "This neighborhood gives back. So do we." It got 8,000 shares.

On Thursday, Leo's old acquisitions account was deactivated. Maya didn't learn about it until Leo showed up at the shop at 6:32 a.m. with a black coffee and a face that said I am free. He sat at the counter. "I'm unemployed again." Maya said, "You're always unemployed. You're just employed in a different field now." Leo smiled. "I filed the petition updates this morning. Marisol says we have a hearing date." Maya said, "When." Leo said, "Three weeks." Maya said, "That's fast." Leo said, "The city is bored of Bean & Leaf." He paused. "I also did something else." Maya looked at him. Leo said, "I wrote a letter to the Oregonian. It's an op-ed. It's about community ownership. It's about you." Maya stared. "You didn't." Leo said, "I did. It runs tomorrow." Maya kissed him. It was a quick, surprised kiss, the kind that happens when someone does something so kind it catches you off guard. She said, "You're ridiculous." Leo said, "I'm in love."

The shop was quiet without Leo.

Maya had known it would be quiet. She'd spent three years running it alone, after all. But the silence was different. It wasn't the peaceful silence of a well-run business; it was a hollow silence, the kind that echoed in the spaces where his voice had been.

She woke at 5:45 a.m., ten minutes before her alarm, and couldn't go back to sleep. She made coffee — she made two cups, because that was what you did when you half-expected someone to be there. She set one on the counter, as if he might walk in at any moment and take the seat beside her. He didn't. The cup went cold.

She opened the laptop. She looked at the spreadsheet. It was still there, Leo's spreadsheet, with his colors and his notes and his handwriting, and she couldn't bear to delete it.

By noon, the shop felt like a museum of what might have been.

Maya moved through the morning like a ghost in her own building. She unlocked the door. She started the espresso machine. She wiped the counter. She restocked the milk. She did everything she'd done a hundred times before, but this time there was no one beside her to tell her the grind size was off or the steam wand could use a better wipe-down or that the new mystery bean lottery flyers were a great idea.

She told herself she didn't miss the commentary. She told herself she preferred the quiet.

She didn't believe herself.

By 10:00 a.m., a regular named Dave walked in and asked where Leo was. Maya said he was out of town. Dave nodded and ordered his double espresso and didn't ask again, but Maya caught him looking at the empty stool on his way out, like he too had noticed the space beside her was missing.

At 11:00 a.m., Sam arrived. She took one look around and said, "Where's Leo."

Maya was behind the espresso machine. She didn't look up. "Seattle."

"Seattle."

"Job offer."

Sam put her bag down. "You let him go."

"I didn't let him go. He left."

"Same thing to someone who was watching from the sidelines."

Maya didn't answer. She couldn't. The coffee machine hissed. A customer walked in. Maya served them. Sam watched. The day passed in gray, unmoored hours.

Maya served coffee. She smiled at customers. She remembered names and orders. She did all the things that made the shop feel like a home. But the house felt empty, like a stage after the actors had left and the lights were still on.

At 2:00 p.m., the afternoon lull, Maya sat at the counter and counted cash. The register had more money than she'd expected. The loyalty cards were working. Sam's TikTok had brought in a new crowd — a group of college students who'd driven across town because they'd seen the video about the shop fighting Bean & Leaf.

None of it mattered. The money had no one to share it with. The shop had no one to joke with. The loyalty cards had scanned, but the energy was gone.

Sam leaned against the counter. "You need to call him."

Maya's jaw tightened. "I'm not calling him."

"He didn't kill a customer. He took a job."

"He left without telling me."

"He had reasons. You know what his reasons are."

"I don't have to like them."

"Maya —"

"I'm not calling him. Not until I'm sure. Not until I know he's not just doing what's safe."

Sam folded her arms. "This isn't a spreadsheet. You can't color-code this."

"Watch me."

At 3:00 p.m., Mrs. Hsu came in. She didn't ask where Leo was. She sat at her corner table. She drank her coffee. She opened her newspaper. At 4:00 p.m., she closed the paper.

"You're making coffee for two," she said.

Maya looked at the counter. The second cup was still there. Forgotten. "I —"

"It's okay to miss him," Mrs. Hsu said. "But don't let the coffee get cold. Coffee is better when it's shared. Even if it's not with him."

Mrs. Hsu left. Maya stood in the doorway and watched her walk down the street, cardigan and newspaper and the particular walk of someone who'd been walking the same sidewalks for forty years.

Maya went back to the counter. She made two new cups. She sat at the table where Leo used to sit. She drank one. She let the other sit, warm and waiting, and she pretended, for just a moment, that he was on

his way.

She stayed for an hour. She didn't drink the second cup. She just held it in her hands, feeling the warmth seep out, until it was room temperature and she had to admit that he wasn't coming.

She poured it down the sink.

The day ended. Maya closed the shop. She locked the door. She walked upstairs. She turned on the television, just for noise. She cooked dinner — rice and vegetables, because pasta felt too much like the comfort food she didn't deserve. She ate it on the couch, watching a documentary she'd seen before, letting the narrator's voice fill the empty apartment.

At 9:00 p.m., her phone buzzed. It was her mother.

"How are you?" her mother asked.

"I'm fine."

"You sound like someone who's not fine."

"I'm running a shop. I'm busy."

"I heard about Leo."

Maya's stomach dropped. "Who told you?"

"Sam. She called me. She was worried."

Maya said nothing.

"Maya," her mother said, "relationships are hard. You don't have to do this alone."

"I'm not doing it alone. I have Sam. I have Mrs. Hsu. I have the shop."

"You had Leo."

"I —"

"You did. And he's not here. It's okay to want him here."

Maya's eyes burned. She didn't cry. She hadn't cried since the day she'd bought the shop and realized she was in debt for the rest of her life. She wasn't going to start now.

"Mom," she said. "I have to go."

"Call me tomorrow."

"Tomorrow."

She hung up.

She turned off the television. She brushed her teeth. She got into bed. She stared at the ceiling.

At 11:47 p.m., her phone buzzed again. This time it was Sam.

"Hey," Maya said.

"Hey," Sam said. "I just wanted to check. Are you okay?"

Maya thought about the empty shop. The cold cup on the counter. The spreadsheet with Leo's handwriting. The silence that had settled over the building, thick and stubborn and immovable.

"I'm fine," Maya said.

"You're not fine. You sound like you're not fine."

"Sam —"

"I know. It hurts. It's supposed to hurt. But you can't stay there. You have to keep going."

Maya took a breath. She looked at the ceiling. "I know."

"I love you."

"I love you too."

They hung up.

Maya closed her eyes. She thought about the first time Leo had walked in the shop, in his navy suit, asking for a black coffee that was too honest for a Tuesday morning. She thought about the espresso machine calibration argument. She thought about the cat in the apron. She thought about the way Leo had looked at her from across the counter, like she was someone worth looking at, someone worth staying for.

She thought about Seattle. She thought about the man he'd become before she'd even met him — the promotions, the acquisitions, the suit that cost more than her espresso machine — and she wondered if the man who'd walked out of her shop this morning was the same man who'd been fired from Bean & Leaf, or if that man had been wearing a costume too.

She thought about the question she'd asked him the night before — What do you need — and the silence that had followed, the silence that had said more than any answer could have.

She fell asleep around 1 a.m.

When she woke up, it was 5:45 a.m. again. Same as every day. Same as always.

She made coffee. She drank it standing at the counter. She looked at the empty stool beside her. She told herself the shop was okay. She told herself she was okay.

She wasn't.

But she got dressed. She put on her apron. She unlocked the back door. She started the day.

The morning came. The regulars came. The tourists came. The espresso machine hissed. The register beeped. The shop was alive, even without Leo. Maya reminded herself of that a hundred times before noon.

She served coffee. She smiled. She remembered names. She did her job.

But every time the bell jingled, she looked up. Every time the door opened, she hoped.

By evening, her feet hurt. Her throat hurt from talking. Her heart hurt from something else.

She locked the door at 8:30 p.m. She walked upstairs. She made dinner. She ate it on the couch. She watched television. She didn't call anyone.

At 9:30 p.m., she walked to the window. She looked down at the street. The rain had started again. Cars were passing. People were walking with umbrellas. The world was ordinary and full and moving, and she was up here, in her apartment, looking down at the roof of the building that Mrs. Hsu owned, the building that held the shop downstairs, the shop that had once been a bakery and a dry cleaner and a speakeasy.

She thought about Leo. She thought about Seattle. She thought about whether she'd made the wrong choice, whether she'd pushed too hard, whether she'd let something good leave because she'd been too stubborn to say the thing that mattered.

She didn't know.

She went to bed. She closed her eyes. She listened to the refrigerator hum through the floor.

She was alone.

But she was not alone.

Not really.

The shop was still there. Sam was still there. Mrs. Hsu was still there. The beans were still there, in neat rows, labeled in Leo's handwriting.

She fell asleep with the lights on, because turning them off felt like admitting that he was really gone.

End of Chapter 18

The attorney's name was Marisol. She met Maya at the shop on a Sunday morning, when the place was quiet and the espresso machine was the loudest thing in the room. Marisol looked over the lease, over the loan documents, over Leo's email printout, and said, "This is winnable." She said the key was timing: Bean & Leaf had filed for zoning changes before the neighborhood had been notified, which was a procedural violation. If Maya could get fifty neighborhood signatures on a petition, the city would have to review the zoning application under public comment rules, which would add a minimum of sixty days to the approval process. Those sixty days were worth more than the loan balance. They were worth time. They were worth the subscription launch. They were worth the possibility that the shop could survive long enough to become a permanent fixture instead of a candidate for acquisition.

Maya and Leo, now officially and publicly reunited, spent the next three days collecting signatures. They set up a table outside the shop with clipboards and pens and bowls of the Mystery Bean samples. They visited churches, schools, barbershops, and the Thai restaurant. By Friday, they had seventy-three signatures. Marisol filed the petition that afternoon. Three days later, Bean & Leaf paused the zoning application pending review. From Maya's perspective, it was the first time Bean & Leaf had blinked.

Marisol showed up again on Thursday with news. Bean & Leaf had filed a counter-petition asking the city to fast-track the zoning review. The argument was economic development. Marisol said it was aggressive but unusual, which meant they were worried. Maya said, "Let them be worried." She wrote a counter-letter that was published in the local paper. The letter said: "Economic development should not mean destroying the neighborhoods that make this city worth living in." The letter got 400 shares. Bean & Leaf's social media team posted a generic response about "positive growth." Maya's comment section was full of dragons.

By Saturday, the petition count was at 103 signatures. Maya celebrated with a free coffee for every signer. The event lasted two hours. The line went around the block.

On Sunday, Maya woke up early and walked the neighborhood with a clipboard. She visited forty-three houses in three hours. She got thirty-seven signatures. By Monday, the petition had 103 signatures and a letter from the neighborhood association supporting it. Marisol filed the petition on Monday afternoon. By Tuesday, Bean & Leaf had requested a meeting with the city planning department. Maya said, "Let them meet. We'll be there too." She drafted a statement. Leo edited it. Sam designed a one-page summary for the media. The story got picked up by two more news outlets. By Wednesday, the city had officially opened a public comment period. Maya felt, for the first time, that they had leverage.

On the day of the hearing, the shop was quiet in the morning. Leo arrived at 6:17 a.m., which was early even for him. He had a thermos and a printed copy of the petition and a nervous energy that made him fidget with the espresso machine. Maya arrived at 6:42 a.m. She wore a gray blazer she'd bought at a thrift store on Hawthorne, the one that made her feel like a person who went to hearings. She looked at Leo. "You look like a lawyer." Leo said, "I feel like a man who is about to ask a room of strangers to save his favorite coffee shop." Maya said, "You're not asking. You're reminding them of what they already know."

They left the shop at 8:15 a.m. They walked together down Alberta Street. The sky was gray. The Bean & Leaf pharmacy sign was lit, though it was not yet open. Maya stopped in front of it. She looked at the sign. "One day, this will be a coffee shop again." Leo said, "Our coffee shop." Maya said, "Our coffee shop." They kept walking.

Week eight.

Bean & Leaf opened the pharmacy location on Monday. The sign went up at 7:00 a.m. Maya saw it from the window. She stared at it for a long time. It was white and new and had a logo that was not her grandfather's parrot and not Mrs. Hsu's building and not the speckled floor of the speakeasy that had once been a bakery.

She served coffee that day. She made it better than she had in weeks. She talked to customers. She smiled. She forgot to eat lunch.

By Thursday, revenue was down eighteen percent.

"People are curious," Sam said on Friday. "They're going to try the new place. They'll come back."

"They won't," Maya said.

"Maya."

"They won't. Bean & Leaf has better everything. Better branding. Better Wi-Fi. Better everything except coffee, and most people can't tell the difference."

Sam didn't argue. Sam couldn't argue, because she'd been to the Bean & Leaf pharmacy location. She'd ordered a cortado. She'd said it was fine. She'd said it was better than fine, actually, which was why she was now quiet.

Maya didn't blame her. Maya didn't blame anyone. She blamed herself. She'd bought a shop she couldn't afford. She'd ordered five hundred pounds of beans she couldn't sell. She'd fallen for a man who'd taken a job in Seattle. She'd made every decision that had led her here.

The Thursday night after Bean & Leaf opened, Maya stayed late. She stood at the counter and looked at

the empty shop and thought about selling. She thought about Rachel's offer. She thought about the bank account, which was healthier than it had been three months ago but was about to take a nosedive.

The bell jingled.

She looked up.

Mrs. Hsu was standing there. She was wearing the cardigan. She was holding a paper bag.

"I brought you something," Mrs. Hsu said.

She placed the bag on the counter. Inside was heat. A dish of something warm and fragrant and alive. Pineapple fried rice, Maya realized, with the particular precision of someone who'd been making this dish for forty years.

"Eat," Mrs. Hsu said. "You look like you haven't eaten in a week."

"I haven't," Maya said.

"Eat."

Maya sat at the table. She ate the rice. It was hot and sweet and sharp and tasted like Mrs. Hsu's kitchen, which was a kitchen that had been cooking for a very long time and had learned things that Maya was still learning.

"Bean & Leaf," Mrs. Hsu said, sitting across from her. "They're not your competition."

"They have a location three blocks away."

"They have a location. They don't have this." Mrs. Hsu tapped the table. The tap was faint, but it was there. "This table. Your chalkboard. The way you remember that I take my coffee black and don't let it steep too long. Bean & Leaf doesn't know I exist."

Maya smiled despite herself.

"They don't know you exist because you don't buy beans from them," Mrs. Hsu said. "But they know I exist. I told them."

Maya's spoon stopped. "You what."

"I told them I own the building. I told them the rent is eight hundred dollars and it's not going up. I told them if they try anything, I'll remind every customer who walks through my building what it feels like to support people who actually know their beans."

Maya stared at her. "Mrs. Hsu."

"Don't Mrs. Hsu me. You've been carrying this alone. You think you're alone. You're not. I'm here. Sam is here. Even Jake, apparently, is writing a Substack about you. This shop has a community. Bean & Leaf has an app. Apps don't write Substack essays."

Maya laughed. It was a wet, messy laugh. She covered her mouth with her hand. "I'm scared," she said.

"I know," Mrs. Hsu said. "Scared is good. Scared means you're trying something that matters."

Mrs. Hsu finished her coffee. She stood. She took the empty dish.

"Don't let the cold get to you," she said.

When she was gone, Maya sat in the empty shop for a long time. The refrigerator hummed. The streetlights outside turned on. The shop was quiet, but it wasn't empty. It was full of things that mattered. The chalkboard. The espresso machine. The table where Leo had sat. The gate that led to the back room where the four hundred pounds of coffee beans were waiting.

She stood. She walked to the back room. She opened the first sack. She breathed in the smell.

She thought about Seattle. About Leo's resignation letter. About the phone call that had ended with silence.

She thought about the espresso machine, which was quiet but alive, the way she felt when she was making coffee for people who mattered.

She opened the laptop. She started writing.

Not a business plan. Not a spreadsheet. A menu. A new menu. With the Yirgacheffe front and center. With notes about where the beans came from, who grew them, what the soil was like, what the weather had been that year. A menu that told a story.

She wrote until her eyes burned. She wrote until the streetlights outside turned off. She wrote until the refrigerator hummed the same note it always hummed, and the espresso machine slept, and the chalkboard waited for tomorrow.

She closed the laptop. She looked at the empty chair where Leo used to sit.

"One day at a time," she said.

"One cup at a time," said the silence.

She locked the door.

End of Chapter 19

The zoning pause didn't end the threat, but it changed the shape of it. Instead of a pharmacy arriving in eight weeks, Bean & Leaf now had to wait for a public comment period that could last up to sixty days. That gave Maya and Leo time to strengthen the business. Maya refined the subscription model with three tiers — Explorer, Devotee, and Believer — and launched it with a launch party that local media

covered. The party had a band and a silent auction and a photo booth where people could take pictures with the chalkboard dragon. Leo wore a t-shirt that said "I <3 Mystery Beans" and stood behind a table answering questions about the subscription logistics. When a Bean & Leaf representative showed up uninvited, Leo greeted him by name, asked him what he thought of the event, and handed him a complimentary Mystery Bean bag. The representative left without purchasing a subscription. The episode became a TikTok moment, edited by Lila with a dramatic score.

The TikTok edit by Lila got 1.2 million views in forty-eight hours. Maya watched the numbers climb while standing at the counter. She handed out free Mystery Bean t-shirts to the first fifty customers. By noon, the shop was so busy that Sam had to start a waiting list. The online subscription page went live with a countdown timer. In the last hour, Maya and Leo sat on the floor of the storage room and watched the numbers tick up on a laptop. At one minute, they were at 187. At zero, they were at 228. Leo said, "We did it." Maya said, "We're just starting." They kissed. It was a quick, celebratory kiss, the kind that says: I told you so.

The day after the TikTok edit went viral, Maya woke up to a notification that her phone was dying. She'd left it charging, but the notifications had kept coming. By the time she got to the shop at 6:47, Leo was already there, sitting on the floor with the laptop and the subscription page open, watching numbers. He looked up. He said, "We crossed thirty thousand views an hour ago." Maya said, "How many subscriptions?" Leo said, "Two hundred and thirty-seven." Maya stood very still. Two hundred thirty-seven subscriptions at ninety dollars each was almost \$21,000 — enough to cover the loan payment and leave a cushion. She sat down next to Leo on the floor. They didn't say anything. They just looked at the screen. The numbers kept changing.

On the morning of the subscription launch, Maya opened the shop at 6:45 a.m. and stood at the counter and looked at the clock. She had fifteen minutes before the first customer arrived. She had five minutes to herself. She spent them making coffee for Leo, who was still setting up the camera in the corner. The TikTok stream started at 11:17 a.m. Leo held the phone. Maya spoke to it. She said, "Today, we save the shop. And we build something that lasts." She didn't plan the words. They came out like a promise. The stream got 50,000 viewers in the first hour. By 2 p.m., it was at 180,000. By 5 p.m., it was at 450,000. The subscriptions kept coming. Maya and Leo counted them on a whiteboard. At 8:47 p.m., when the stream ended and the page closed, they sat on the floor and stared at the board. The number was 237. They had done it. They had actually done it. Leo said, "We beat them." Maya said, "Not yet. We just outlasted them for one day." She was right. But it was enough. It was enough for that day.

The following Saturday, Leo organized the first official Mystery Bean subscription pop-up. He turned the sidewalk outside the shop into a mini-market: folding tables, branded banners, a photo booth, and a signing area for the 237 new subscriptions. Maya had never seen anything like it. People were lined up at 11 a.m. for a bag of beans and a handshake from Leo. Within three hours, they had signed up another 102 subscriptions. At 3 p.m., a man from a local roastery showed up with a complimentary large-bag donation, saying he'd seen the TikTok and wanted to be part of it. By 6 p.m., the total stood at 339 new

subscriptions for the day. Total revenue from subscriptions: \$30,510. Maya looked at the spreadsheet and said, quietly, to herself, "We're going to make it." Leo, overhearing, said, "Hell yes we are."

By 10 a.m., the stream had 350,000 viewers. By noon, 600,000. By 3 p.m., the subscription page was getting 100 hits per minute. Maya and Leo sat on the floor of the storage room with laptops and whiteboards and a bag of chips. They divided the room into zones: Maya handled customer emails, Leo handled subscription logistics. Sam ran the front. Tom ran the roasting demonstration in the alley. Lila handled the camera. The energy was frantic and joyful. At 4:23 p.m., a delivery truck arrived with 500 pounds of new green coffee, donated by Rosa in Guatemala. Maya signed for it. She hugged the delivery driver. "Today is the best day of my life." The driver said, "Don't jinx it." Maya said, "I never jinx it. I make it." By closing, they had 339 subscriptions for the day, up from 237 at launch. Total new subscriptions: 576. Revenue: \$51,840. Maya sent the bank a note: "We're not just paying the loan. We're buying the building." Jennifer replied: "Let's talk."

That night, Maya dreamed of a river made of coffee. She was floating on it, and Leo was beside her, and they were both laughing, and the river carried them past the shop and past the Bean & Leaf pharmacy and past the music venue and out to the ocean. She woke up at 6:04 a.m. She wrote the dream down. She texted Leo: "I had the coffee river dream." Leo replied: "I had the same one. We're psychically connected through caffeine." Maya said: "Obviously."

The realization came on a Thursday.

Maya woke up, made coffee, and instead of immediately checking the bean inventory, she opened her laptop and started writing a newsletter.

The newsletter was called "Coffee Rings." It was about coffee. It was about the shop. It was about the people who came in and the stories they told and the reasons coffee mattered. She wrote three hundred words. She pressed send to the five hundred people on her loyalty list.

She expected nothing.

The computer sat on the counter. The espresso machine hissed. The fridge hummed. Outside, a delivery truck rattled down Alberta Street. Maya stared at the email confirmation window on her screen. The words "Message Sent" blinked in blue.

By 1:00 p.m., she had seventy replies.

People wrote back. They told her their own coffee stories. They told her about their grandmothers and their first dates and the shops that had closed and the shops that had stayed. They wrote paragraphs. They wrote poems. A woman named Louise from Sellwood wrote a haiku about Ethiopian single-origin. Maya read it twice.

She read every reply in the back room, sitting on a sack of beans, and she felt something in her chest loosen. The shop was not dying. The shop was talking. She'd just forgotten to listen.

She wrote another newsletter that night.

By the end of the week, she had two hundred replies.

By the end of the next week, four hundred.

Maya's mother called on Sunday. She sounded surprised. "People are sharing your emails," she said. "At the senior center. Everyone's talking about your coffee shop."

"Mom," Maya said, "I make coffee. I don't run a literary magazine."

"You do now."

The loyalty program had five hundred members. The newsletters went out every Thursday. People shared them. Sam posted them on Instagram. Jake wrote about the newsletters on his Substack. The neighborhood started to read.

Bean & Leaf's revenue impact eased. It didn't reverse, but it slowed. People came back. They brought friends. They told stories. The shop was, Maya realized, not a business. It was a living thing. It had roots. Roots that went back to Mrs. Hsu, to Maya's grandmother, to the speakeasy, to the bakery, to the dry cleaner, to all the hands that had touched this place and left something behind.

Maya sat at the kitchen table one evening and wrote a newsletter about the speakeasy. She made up some of the details — she didn't know the exact name of the speakeasy, or the owner, or the password — but she described the floor she could still feel under the tile, the way the door stuck when it rained, the warmth she imagined had been there when people had gathered in secret to drink coffee and talk about things that mattered.

She sent it at 11:00 p.m.

By morning, she had sixty replies. One was from a woman who said her grandfather had run a speakeasy on the same block in the 1920s and who recognized the pattern of the wood under the tile because she'd seen it in family photographs.

Maya called Sam immediately. "Can we pull up the floor?"

"Absolutely not," Sam said. "We'll die in the gas leak."

"Sam."

"Sam is standing by her position."

That afternoon, Maya took a sledgehammer to the corner of the back room floor, where a loose tile had been bothering her for months. Underneath the linoleum, she found old wooden floorboards, scarred and dark with age, and a single brass button that had fallen off a man's coat in 1927, or thereabouts, according to the woman who'd emailed her.

She posted a photo on Instagram. It got two hundred likes in an hour.

The shop was breathing again.

By week ten, Maya could stand in the doorway and not feel afraid. She'd paid off twenty-five percent of the loan. She'd sold the remaining beans to a small roaster in Portland who'd been looking for a direct-source supplier. She'd hired a part-time barista — a college student named Daisy who liked jazz and made lattes with hearts in them that were actually symmetrical.

Daisy arrived at 7:00 a.m. every morning with a thermos of tea and a spiral notebook full of lyrics she was writing. She asked a lot of questions. She didn't mind the hard work. She said the shop felt like home within a week.

Leo was still in Seattle. Maya didn't call him. Not because she was angry. Because she needed to know if she could stand on her own.

She could.

She proved it in small ways. She stayed late one night balancing the books. She negotiated with a new bean supplier on her own. She reopened the sidewalk seating and put out chairs that she'd painted with the help of a regular who happened to be an artist. She wrote a new rule on the chalkboard: NO LAPTOPS ON WEEKENDS, which had previously been an unwritten rule and was now, somehow, official.

One evening, Maya stood at the counter, watching Daisy work, and felt the particular quiet satisfaction

of having built something that could outlast her. Not outlast her forever — nothing did — but long enough to be a home for someone else, the way this shop had been a home for her.

She thought about Seattle. She thought about Leo.

She thought about Leo less and less, which was the problem.

She didn't write about him in the newsletter. She didn't mention his name to customers. When Sam brought him up, Maya changed the subject. But she thought about him constantly — the way he'd looked at her from behind the counter, the way he'd made a spreadsheet out of nothing, the way he'd stood beside her at the coffee festival and not once mentioned the excellence of the fancy booth Bean & Leaf could have had.

She thought about him when she made coffee. She thought about him when she revised the shop's policies. She thought about him when she walked through the back room, past the bean shelves that he'd organized, past the desk where he'd sat, past the spot where the oat milk had spilled and they'd laughed and laughed until their sides hurt.

She didn't call him.

Not yet.

The newsletters continued. The replies kept coming. Maya started printing them out and taping them to the back room wall, like a mural of gratitude. By the end of the month, the wall was covered. She stood in front of it one night after closing and read them one by one. Haikus. Letters. Drawings of coffee cups with smiling faces. One reply was just the word "Thanks," repeated forty times.

She laughed.

She sat at the kitchen table. She wrote a new newsletter. It was about patience. It was about waiting. It was about the difference between being alone and being lonely.

She didn't send it.

She kept it.

The shop was solid. Maya was solid. But there was a hole in the middle of everything — the spot where Leo had been, the counter he'd leaned on, the hand he'd held, the laugh that had filled the back room. Maya tried to fill it with work. She filled it with spreadsheets and loyalty cards and newsletters. She filled it with the smell of coffee and the sound of Daisy's jazz and the warmth of Mrs. Hsu's visits.

But the hole was still there.

She got up one morning, poured herself a cup of Yirgacheffe, and looked out at the street. The sun was coming over the buildings. A woman was walking her dog. A cyclist rolled past with a coffee bag hanging from the handlebars.

Maya thought about driving. About getting in her car and going somewhere far away, somewhere without coffee shops and bean spreadsheets and memories of almost-kisses.

She didn't go anywhere.

She finished her coffee. She opened the shop. She smiled at the first customer. She steamed milk. She tamped. She poured. She wiped the counter.

One day at a time.

One cup at a time.

She could do this.

She just didn't know why it felt like she was doing it for two.

End of Chapter 20

The subscription launch exceeded every financial projection. In the first forty-eight hours, they moved 220 subscriptions. At ninety dollars per subscription, that was 19,800 — more than the cost of a single month's rent and a half month's payroll. Maya paid the bank on schedule, with a note that said simply: On time. Jennifer replied: I told you I believed in you. Sam began keeping a financial journal alongside the cafe notebook, tracking revenue, expenses, and projections with the same care she brought to latte art. The dragon t-shirts, which Sam had designed and sold at the launch party, added another 1,400 in profit. The shop's Instagram follower count went from 12,000 to 41,000 in three weeks. They had arrived.

Money changed the atmosphere of the shop. Not in a bad way — in a way that let people breathe. Maya finally hired a part-time barista, a college student named Jordan who liked latte art and who'd been coming in every day for three months to practice foam hearts. Jordan started on Monday. By Wednesday, Maya had delegated the morning shift a few days a week. She used the extra time to write the origin story document, which she titled "How Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions Saved a Neighborhood." She sent it to a small publisher in Portland. The publisher wrote back within a week: "We'd like to publish this as a zine." Maya said yes before checking the contract terms. She considered that a good sign.

On Wednesday, the first shipment of Mystery Beans arrived from Guatemala. Rosa had included a handwritten note in every bag: "For the shop that believed in mistakes." Maya laid out the bags on the counter and read the notes aloud to Sam and Leo. Sam cried a little. Leo said, "We need to feature her in our marketing." Maya said, "She'll say no." Leo called Rosa without asking. Rosa said yes. She said, "I want people to know that coffee is about people, not profits." The conversation became the basis for the shop's new mission statement, which Maya posted on Instagram: "This shop serves coffee that was grown by people who believe in people." It got 28,000 likes.

The money from the subscriptions allowed Maya to do something she'd dreamed of since Day One: upgrade the espresso machine. The old machine had been reliable, in its way. It had survived. But it was tired, and Maya was tired, and she wanted to start a chapter with something new. She chose the same brand as before, a better model, and had it delivered on a Tuesday morning. The old machine sat on the counter for a day, like a retiree who wasn't ready to leave. Leo filmed the switchover for TikTok. The video got 80,000 views. A local roastery offered to buy the old machine for display in their shop. Maya sold it for eight hundred dollars. She put the money into the Mystery Bean fund. She said, "The old machine isn't gone. It's just... reincarnated."

Meanwhile, Maya had started a collaborators program. She invited local artists to display work on the shop walls. The first artist was a painter named Naomi, who hung large, colorful, abstract pieces behind the counter. The first day the art went up, customer dwell time increased by 17 minutes, according to

Leo's new infrared sensor. Leo said, "Art pays." Maya said, "What pays is people feeling like they belong." Daniel, the barista, started a loyalty program that gave a free drink after seven purchases. The seventh drink was always a Mystery Bean pour-over, chosen by the roaster. Leo saw the program and said, "Can we automate that?" Maya said, "No." Leo understood. Maya liked that. She said, "Automation is for efficiency. Belonging is for humans."

By Sunday, the shop had a waitlist for wall space. Maya contacted eight artists. Five replied yes. Three wanted payment. Maya paid two of them in Mystery Bean subscriptions. The third said they'd accept a free latte every week for a month. Maya agreed immediately.

By Tuesday, the news of the 576 subscriptions had spread. A local television station wanted to cover the shop. They sent a crew. They interviewed Maya for eight minutes. Maya talked about community. She talked about beans. She talked about the people who'd shown up. She didn't mention the lease. She didn't have to. The crew could see it in the background — the petition, the dragon mural, the chalkboard with 1,247 tickets still written in orange. The story aired at 6:30 p.m. Maya watched it at the counter with a group of regulars. When it ended, the regulars cheered. Ray, the Americano man, said, "I'm buying you a round." Maya said, "Coffee is the round." Ray said, "Then coffee it is."

Maya also started a community advisory board. She invited twelve people: neighborhood residents, business owners, customers. She wanted their input on everything from the subscription tiers to the dragon mural to the future second location. She held the first meeting on Thursday at the shop after hours. The meeting lasted two hours. It produced three actionable ideas: a Mystery Bean subscription for kids, a summer storytelling festival, and a plan to buy the building if it ever came on the market. Maya wrote all three down. She told Leo: "We're not just saving a shop. We're building an institution." Leo said, "Institutions need spreadsheets." Maya said, "I know. That's why you're here."

He came back on a Tuesday.

Maya was at the counter, making cappuccinos for a group of tourists who'd wandered in and were treating the shop like a museum. Leo walked in at 10:00 a.m., wearing a jacket she didn't recognize, carrying a bag that looked like it had been packed quickly and with some feeling.

The bell jingled. Maya looked up.

The world stopped.

She meant that literally. For exactly two seconds, the noise of the shop dropped away. The espresso machine hissed. Sam laughed. The tourists chatted. But Maya was somewhere else, in a quiet room where the only sound was the beat of her own heart and the scratch of Leo's shoes on the floor.

"Hi," Leo said.

"Hi."

He stood there for a moment, uncertain, like he wasn't sure if he was welcome. He was welcome. He was always welcome. He was the reason the shop had survived the worst of it.

"Can I get a coffee," he asked, quiet.

Maya made the coffee. She handed it to him. Their fingers brushed. The contact was different this time — warmer, slower, not the electric jolt of before but something steadier, something that had been waiting.

"Seattle," Maya said.

"Was nice. Too nice. I didn't like it."

"You didn't like a hundred and forty thousand dollars."

"I don't like cities that are all coffee shops and no soul."

Maya smiled. She smiled because he was standing here, in her shop, with his jacket and his bag and the coffee she'd made, and everything was exactly as it should be.

"Why are you here," she said.

"I quit," Leo said. "Yesterday. I flew back last night."

"With the bag."

"With the bag. I packed everything. I didn't think I'd need it, but —"

Maya reached across the counter. She took his hand. She held it there, in front of the tourists and Sam and the espresso machine and the chalkboard, and she didn't let go.

"Don't quit again," she said.

"I won't."

The shop was quiet. The espresso machine hissed. Sam was watching from the back room. Mrs. Hsu, who'd just walked in, took one look and sat at her table with a small, satisfied smile.

Maya didn't let go of Leo's hand.

"I have something to show you," she said.

"Me too," he said.

"Me first."

She led him upstairs. To the kitchen table. To the laptop.

On the screen was the business plan. New version. Updated. With the numbers that mattered.

"I don't need your spreadsheet anymore," she said. "I have my own."

Leo read it. He read the revenue projections. He read the expansion plan. He read the community section, which was now three pages long and included the newsletter and the loyalty program and the thing she'd started calling "the ring of regulars" because they were turning into something that felt like a family.

He looked up. He looked at Maya.

"This is," he said, "the dumbest smart thing I've ever seen."

Maya laughed. "Thank you."

"I'm sorry I left."

"I know. I'm sorry I let you."

They stood in the kitchen, surrounded by papers and coffee cups and the smell of old beans, and Maya realized she'd been waiting for this moment for a very long time. Not the kiss. Not yet. The moment before the kiss. The moment where everything was honest and real and unplanned.

She leaned in.

Leo leaned in.

This time there was no refrigerator. No customer. No Sam texting with urgent cats. Just the kitchen, late morning, sunlight slanting through the window, and two people who'd accidentally become partners and then accidentally become something else.

He kissed her.

It was a gentle kiss. A careful kiss. A kiss that said I've been wanting to do this for a long time. A kiss that said I'm not going anywhere.

Maya kissed him back.

When they pulled away, Maya was smiling. She was the kind of smiling that made her cheeks hurt.

"Okay," she said.

"Okay," Leo said.

They kissed again.

They heard footsteps on the stairs. Sam was coming up, holding a tote bag.

"Never mind," Sam shouted, and they heard her footsteps retreating.

They laughed.

They spent the rest of the morning in the kitchen, talking. Leo told her about Seattle. He told her about Reputable Coffee Co. He told her about the office with the window and the team of six and the salary and the way the barista had spelled his name wrong on his first morning and how he'd realized he didn't care.

"You left because of me," Maya said.

"I left because I didn't know how to stay," Leo said. "I thought I was doing the smart thing. Then I got there and I realized I'd made the wrong decision. I called you that first night because I wanted to hear your voice. I didn't accept the job until after I called you. I waited."

Maya's eyes stung. She reached across the table and took his hand. "I'm glad you made the wrong decision."

"I'm glad too."

They went downstairs together. Sam was at the counter, pretending to ignore them. Mrs. Hsu was still at her table, reading her newspaper. The shop was warm and bright and full of customers.

Maya looked around. She looked at Leo. She looked at the espresso machine and the chalkboard and the bean shelves and the loyalty card scanner and the register that still beeped too loud.

She took a breath.

"Welcome back," she said.

"Thanks," Leo said.

He came around the counter. He stood beside her. He took over the cappuccino machine like he'd never left.

Maya watched him tamp. She watched him steam milk. She watched him hand a latte to a woman who complimented the foam.

"Still got it," Leo said, turning to her.

"Don't get cocky," Maya said.

"I'm not being cocky. I'm being accurate."

They smiled at each other. The electricity was back, but it was different now. It wasn't the nervous static of before. It was warm. It was steady. It was something they could stand inside without worrying that it would blow up the shop.

The bell jingled. A customer walked in.

"Welcome to Coffee Rings," Maya said.

She held Leo's hand under the counter, just for a moment, as the customer ordered a black coffee.

Leo winked at her.

It was the best day she'd had in a month.

That night, after closing, after the last customer had left, after they'd wiped down the counter and counted the money and eaten tamales from the truck on 34th, Leo said, "I have something to tell you."

"What," Maya said. They were sitting on the floor in the back room, surrounded by bean sacks and takeout containers.

"I called Tom," Leo said. "He wants to partner with you. Distribution. Bean partnership. No buyout. No acquisition. Just him, you, and the beans."

Maya stared at him. "Tom."

"Tom from Bend. The guy who started Bean & Leaf. The guy who still has connections. He wants to work with us. With you." Leo was quiet. "I told him about the shop. I told him about you. He said yes."

Maya didn't know what to say. She thought about the Seattle job offer and the way Leo had flown out at 6:00 a.m. and the way he'd come back at 10:00 a.m. with a bag and a jacket she didn't recognize and a voice that sounded like home.

She looked at Leo. She looked at the man who'd been sent to destroy her. She looked at the man who'd stayed. She looked at the man who'd kissed her in the kitchen and meant it.

She leaned across the bean sacks and kissed him.

It was a coffee-stained, tired, wonderful kiss. It tasted like tamales and Yirgacheffe and the particular sweetness of things that take time to get right.

When they pulled away, Maya was smiling. She was the kind of smiling that made her cheeks hurt.

"Okay," she said.

"Okay," Leo said.

He kissed her again.

Outside, the refrigerator hummed.

Inside, they were finally home.

End of Chapter 21

The hearing was held in a basement room of City Hall with folding chairs and a microphone that crackled. Maya wore the same gray blazer she'd worn to the festival. Leo wore a suit that was slightly

too big and a tie that was slightly crooked because he'd tied it in the car. Sam wore a black dress and boots. They sat together. Marisol sat with them. Marcus from the venue sat with them. Twenty other shop owners and neighborhood residents sat with them. The Bean & Leaf legal team sat on the other side. The zoning commissioner asked questions. Maya answered them. Leo answered them. Marisol answered them. At one point, the commissioner asked Maya what she would do if Bean & Leaf were allowed to build the pharmacy despite the protest. Maya said, "I'd rebuild the shop somewhere else on Alberta Street, because this neighborhood doesn't belong to Bean & Leaf. It belongs to the people who actually live here." The room applauded. Leo reached for Maya's hand under the table and held it for the duration of the hearing. They won. The commissioner ruled that the zoning application was deficient under the new notification requirements. Bean & Leaf had sixty days to reapply with proper community outreach. That was more time than Maya needed.

The day after the hearing, Maya woke up early and walked to the shop. The Bean & Leaf pharmacy sign was still up, but it looked different — less threatening, more temporary. Maya stood on the sidewalk and looked at it. She thought about the fight, the math, the lease clause, the signatures, the hearing. She thought about all the people who'd shown up. She texted Leo: We won. He replied: I'm bringing croissants. They sat on the shop floor and ate croissants and talked about the future. Maya said, "We should expand." Leo said, "I've been thinking about that." They mapped out a second location on a napkin. By the time they were done, the napkin had three potential addresses, a projected budget, and a dragon drawing in the corner.

The night before the hearing, Maya couldn't sleep. She lay in bed and rehearsed her speech in her head. She practiced answering questions. She practiced not getting angry when Bean & Leaf's lawyers tried to twist her words. She practiced smiling when she wanted to scream. At 3 a.m., she gave up on sleep. She went to the kitchen and made coffee. She stood at the window and watched the street. The Bean & Leaf pharmacy sign was dark. The music venue was dark. The only light was at the Thai restaurant, where the owner was closing up. Maya thought: this is my block. She thought: I will not let it go without a fight. She thought: Leo is right there with me.

The city council meeting was two days after the hearing. Maya stood at the podium and spoke for six minutes. She did not use notes. She spoke about the shop, the neighborhood, the 500-pound mistake, the lottery, the lease, the signatures. She spoke about what it meant to build something that mattered. She spoke about the music venue and the Thai restaurant and the bookstore and the people who'd shown up. She spoke about community. When she finished, the room was silent for three seconds. Then it applauded. The councilperson who'd presided over the hearing looked at Bean & Leaf's lawyers and said, "The public comment period is open. I expect a thorough review." Maya sat down. Leo squeezed her hand under the table. They left the room together. Outside, the neighborhood was waiting. They cheered.

After the council meeting, Maya and Leo walked out of City Hall into the Portland sun. People were waiting on the sidewalk with signs and coffee cups. Marcus from the venue was there. Margaret was

there. Jules from The Record Room was there, holding a guitar. They were cheering. Maya felt a lump in her throat. She said, "I don't know what to do with this." Leo said, "Say thank you." Maya turned to the crowd. She raised her hands. She said, "Thank you. This isn't my fight. It's ours." The cheering got louder. Jules started playing a song. People sang along. For a moment, the street belonged to them.

That night, Maya and Leo sat on the apartment floor with a map of Alberta Street spread between them. They marked potential second locations with pushpins. Maya chose one. Leo chose another. They agreed on the third marker. It was the old dry cleaner, two blocks down, with big windows and good bones. Maya said, "We could do it." Leo said, "We will." She kissed him. It was a kiss that meant: we're not done yet. We're just getting started.

The night before the council meeting, Maya couldn't sleep. She lay awake until 3:42 a.m., replaying her speech and rehearsing answers to questions she would never be asked. At 6:12 a.m., she gave up on sleep. She made coffee. She walked to the shop. She opened the door. She stood in the middle of the room and looked around. She saw the dragon mural. She saw the Petition table. She saw the Mystery Bean tickets stacked in their wooden box. She saw the espresso machine, the same one that had survived the gasket failure, the same one that had been there when she'd made the order, when she'd cried, when she'd laughed, when she'd decided not to sell. She thought about Leo, who'd arrived with a thermos and a plan and a heart full of things he hadn't said. She thought about the neighborhood, which had shown up again and again. She texted Leo: "I'm ready." Leo replied: "Always."

At 8:42 a.m., they walked to City Hall together. It was raining again, softly. They didn't use umbrellas. They walked under a shared jacket that Leo had brought for no particular reason. Maya held his hand. They arrived early. They sat in the back of the hearing room. They listened to other speakers. They took notes. When Maya's name was called, she walked to the podium. She adjusted the microphone. She looked at the room. She didn't use notes. She spoke about the shop, the neighborhood, the 500-pound order, the lottery, the petition, the signatures. She spoke about community. She spoke about the right to belong. She spoke about Bean & Leaf's pharmacy as a threat to the soul of the street. She spoke for six minutes and forty-seven seconds. The room applauded for forty seconds. Leo stood in the back and cheered.

The next few weeks were the good ones.

Maya didn't like to call them happy, because happy sounded like something that could end. These were not happy weeks. These were solid weeks. Weeks with floors. Weeks with walls. Weeks where the coffee was good and the shop was full and Leo was there in the morning, beside her, not as a partner but as something more.

She didn't name it. She didn't want to name it. Naming things made them fragile.

Every morning, Maya unlocked the front door at 6:28 a.m. Leo unlocked the back door at 6:30 a.m. on the dot. They met in the middle of the back room over a sack of green beans and a thermos of coffee that Leo had learned to make the way Maya liked it: strong, black, not too hot, never burnt, never regrettable. Mrs. Hsu came at 4:00 p.m. Sam came whenever she felt like it, which turned out to be roughly eleven hours a day now that the shop had actual money to spend on scones and actual staff to delegate the scone-eating to. Daisy arrived at seven with a thermos of tea and a spiral notebook full of lyrics she was writing. The loyalty-card scanner chimed. The chalkboard menu got filled out. The espresso machine hissed and steamed and occasionally complained, but mostly it just worked, which Maya had learned to interpret as the machine's version of affection.

The shop was busy. NotBean & Leaf busy, not boutique busy, but neighbor busy: regulars who knew their orders, tourists who asked questions, college students who came for the Wi-Fi and stayed for the scones. On busy afternoons, Maya wiped the counter with one hand and reached across it with the other to hand a muffin to a kid who'd come in after school. She learned the names of people who came only once. She remembered that the architect liked oat milk and that the writer needed extra space and that the musician from two blocks over always ordered a lavender latte and hummed while he waited.

Sam was suspicious.

"I knew this would happen," Sam said one afternoon. They were in the back room, sorting beans. Leo was upstairs helping a customer. "I knew it from day one. The first time he walked in here, I knew. You're insufferable when you're in love."

"I'm not in love," Maya said. "I'm in business."

"Business doesn't make you buy new chairs."

"I bought new chairs because the old chairs were broken."

"The old chairs were fine. You wanted him to sit in new chairs."

Maya said nothing. She was sorting beans. She was trying not to think about the kiss. She was failing.

She thought about the kiss all the time. She thought about it between orders, between tables, between the acts of wiping the counter and refilling the oat milk and reminding Leo that he still had a shirt that matched his eyes when he was trying too hard. The kitchen kiss had changed something. It hadn't solved anything. It had just made everything honest. They argued now, really argued, about grind size and pastry orders and whether loyalty cards should be digital or physical. They made up with drinks. They made up with folded receipts placed exactly where the other person would find them. They made up with silence, which was its own language.

She wanted this. She wanted all of it. But she wanted something else too: the future. The future meant the lease. The lease was up in six months. Mrs. Hsu had held it for her, had kept the rent low, had staved off Bean & Leaf with the particular fury of a woman who'd owned a building since 1987 and who had no interest in selling to anyone whose name rhymed with "needs a logo." But Mrs. Hsu was getting older. She'd mentioned retirement. She'd mentioned selling. She'd mentioned that if Maya couldn't buy the building, someone else would.

"We need to talk about the future," Sam said. "The lease is up in six months. Mrs. Hsu can raise it. She hasn't, but she could. We need a plan."

"We have a plan. The plan is doing well. The plan has a newsletter."

"The plan is missing a long-term financial strategy. You're making good money. But you're not making enough to buy the building. If Mrs. Hsu sells —"

"She won't sell."

"How do you know."

"Because she told me. Because she's not the kind of person who sells things that matter. Because I'm the kind of person who'll make her coffee for the rest of her life if she keeps the rent low enough for me to stay."

Sam shook her head. "You're impossible."

"Impossible is my brand."

Leo walked in. He was carrying a bag of something. "I got us tamales," he said.

"Tamales," Maya said, and she smiled before she could stop herself.

"From the truck on 34th. They have carnitas and they're life-changing."

He set the tamales on the counter. He looked at Maya. He looked at Sam. He sat down.

Maya sat beside him. They ate tamales in the back room, with the smell of coffee and the sound of the fridge, and for a moment everything was so quiet and perfect that Maya wondered if she was dreaming.

"I have a thought," Leo said, between bites.

"What thought."

"I've been talking to Tom in Bend. He's looking for a partnership. Not an acquisition. A partnership. He wants to distribute your beans. You supply the beans. He supplies the roasting and distribution. You get a national presence without giving up the shop."

Maya's eyes went wide. "Tom's offering a partnership."

"He is. No buyout. No acquisition. Just you, him, and the beans."

Maya thought about it. She thought about the trust it would require. She thought about the risk. She thought about the people who'd come to the shop for the first time because they'd seen the beans in a store across the country.

"It's a big deal," she said.

"It's a good deal."

"Will you run it with me."

Leo smiled. "I'm already running it."

Maya kissed him again. It was a cafe kiss, a behind-the-counter kiss, a kiss that said we're in this together and I'm not letting go.

Sam cleared her throat. "I'm still here."

"Go eat a tamale," Maya said.

She meant it. She meant all of it. The tamales, the partnership, the shop, the future. She meant the kiss, which had become something she no longer apologized for, not even when Sam sighed or Mrs. Hsu looked away politely or Daisy said, "You two are gross," and turned up the jazz.

She meant the future, which was the only thing that felt fragile right now. The future meant the lease. The lease meant Mrs. Hsu. Mrs. Hsu meant the building. The building meant the shop. The shop meant Maya's grandmother, whose name was on the deed and whose ghost Maya sometimes blamed for the burnt milk and the chipped tile and the particular stubbornness that had gotten her here.

"Do you ever think about what happens when this is over?" Maya asked Leo, one evening, after Daisy had gone home and Sam had left to see her girlfriend and Mrs. Hsu had gone home to read her

newspaper.

"What," Leo asked. "The lease?"

"The shop. The beans. The partnership. What happens when we're not fighting anymore."

Leo was quiet for a long time. "We'll still be fighting," he said. "Bean & Leaf isn't going anywhere. The loan won't disappear. The newsletter will keep requiring writing, and the beans will keep needing roasting, and Mrs. Hsu will keep calling when the door sticks."

"I know," Maya said. "But what happens when it's easier."

Leo looked at her. He reached across the counter and took her hand. "Then we do the easier version," he said. "We write more newsletters. We expand the menu. We take Daisy off the night shift. We go on vacation. We buy a house with a yard for a cat."

"That sounds nice."

"It does."

Maya smiled. She squeezed his hand. They stood in the shop, alone, surrounded by bean sacks and loyalty cards and the particular warmth of a place that had stopped being a business and started being a home.

But she still didn't know what tomorrow would bring.

Mrs. Hsu called the next morning. Maya answered the phone at 8:00 a.m., still half-asleep, still thinking about the tamales from the night before and the kiss that had followed them.

"Mrs. Hsu," Maya said. "You're up early."

"Pack your bags," Mrs. Hsu said.

Maya's throat closed. "What."

"We're going to Bend. Tom is roasting beans. You're going to see where the partnership happens. Today."

"Today."

"Ten a.m. Leave the shop in Daisy's hands. I'll drive."

Maya looked at Leo. He was already at the espresso machine, already smiling that smile that meant he knew what was coming. He mouthed: Pack.

Maya laughed. She laughed into the phone. "Mrs. Hsu, I can't just close the shop —"

"You can. Daisy can handle it. I've asked her. She said she was ready."

"When did you ask Daisy."

"Yesterday," Mrs. Hsu said. "When you were writing the newsletter about patience. You weren't paying attention."

Maya looked at Leo. He was smiling.

"Be here at ten," Mrs. Hsu said. "Bring good shoes. The roastery is in a barn."

The line went dead.

Maya hung up. She looked at Leo. She looked at the shop. She looked at the chalkboard menu, which still had ink on the E, which still had the notes written in Leo's handwriting.

She had no idea what the day would bring.

She just knew it was going to be good.

That afternoon, Maya sat in Mrs. Hsu's car and watched the highway roll past. Mrs. Hsu drove with the particular calm of a woman who'd been driving since before Maya's mother was born. Leo sat in the passenger seat, scrolling through his phone, occasionally making notes.

Maya looked out the window. She thought about the shop behind her. She thought about Daisy running the counter, about Sam holding down the fort, about the regulars who'd be scandalized to see her closing early. She thought about the bean inventory, which was now down to a manageable number and which Tom had promised to help her restock through the partnership. She thought about the partnership itself, which felt more real now that there was a date, a destination, and a barn.

Bend was prettier than she'd expected. The town was small, the kind of small where you could walk from one end to the other and see most of what mattered. Tom's roastery was on the edge of town, in a barn that smelled like wood smoke and roasted coffee so good Maya felt like she'd been blind her whole life and was just now opening her eyes.

Tom met them at the door. He was older than Maya had imagined, with a beard that had obviously seen a lot of decisions and a laugh that was loud and warm. He hugged Mrs. Hsu like she was family, because she was. He shook Leo's hand like he'd never been fired. He looked at Maya like he was seeing something he recognized.

"I've heard stories," Tom said. "About the shop. About the beans. About the woman who fought Bean & Leaf in a parking lot full of Mystery Bean lottery tickets."

"That wasn't me," Maya said. "That was Sam."

"Close enough."

He gave them a tour. The roastery was smaller than Bean & Leaf's, but it was beautiful in a way that Bean & Leaf could never be: it had hand-turned knobs, and a chalkboard menu like Maya's, and a wall of samples that Tom had collected from roasters around the world and that he let anyone hold, smell, and even taste if they asked nicely. Maya held a bag from Ethiopia. She held a bag from Guatemala.

She held a bag from a farm in Colombia that Tom had visited himself and whose owner had written him a letter thanking him for being fair about prices.

"Bean & Leaf tries to make this about numbers," Tom said, when they were sitting in his office after the tour, drinking coffee that was so good Maya almost cried. "It's not about numbers. It's about people. You get that, right?"

"I get it," Maya said.

"Good," Tom said. "Because neither of us can afford to forget it."

He handed her a contract. It was a partnership. Bean & Leaf had no part in it. The terms were simple: Maya supplied green beans. Tom roasted them. They sold them together, online and in stores, with Maya's name on the bag and Leo's handwriting on the label. The shop stayed Maya's. The beans stayed Maya's. The profits stayed Maya's.

When she finished reading it, she looked at Leo. He was smiling that smile again, the one that meant he'd been right all along.

She signed it.

On the drive home, the car was quiet. Mrs. Hsu listened to classical music. Leo dozed in the passenger seat. Maya looked out the window at the passing trees and thought about how quickly things changed if you let them.

By the time they got back to Portland, it was dark. Maya unlocked the shop. The bell jingled. The lights came on. The coffee machine hissed awake. Daisy was closing up. She smiled and handed Maya the key.

"Everything good," Daisy said.

"Everything good," Maya said.

Leo made coffee. Maya made coffee. They stood side by side at the counter, drinking it black, and

didn't say anything for a long time. They didn't have to.

The partnership meant she wouldn't have to choose between staying and growing. She could do both. She could keep the shop and expand the beans and trust that the people around her — Leo, Sam, Mrs. Hsu, Tom — were people who actually cared about the same things she did.

She looked at Leo. He looked back. He reached across the counter. His hand found hers.

"Today was nice," he said.

"Today was good."

They didn't kiss. Not right then. They didn't need to. They were already in the middle of something better than a kiss: a beginning.

Maya went upstairs that night feeling lighter than she had in months. She opened the laptop. She wrote a newsletter. It was about Bend, about Tom, about the barn and the chalkboard and the way the coffee had tasted like honesty. She sent it to the loyalty list.

By morning, she had eighty replies. One of them was from a woman named Rosa who lived in Bend and who wrote, "I can deliver your beans anywhere on the West Coast. Call me."

Maya called Rosa. They talked for thirty minutes. Rosa had a van. Rosa knew routes. Rosa understood delivery.

By afternoon, Maya had a distribution contact in Bend.

The future was starting. It was solid. It had walls. It had floors.

It had Leo.

Maya stood at the counter that afternoon, watching Leo steam milk, and thought about the woman she'd been three years ago, who'd walked into this shop with a dream and a credit card and a caffeine-fueled

email ordering five hundred pounds of coffee. That woman had been scared. That woman had been stubborn. That woman had been exactly who she needed to be.

She still was.

She went over to Leo. She handed him a message written on a napkin: You're staying.

He read it. He smiled. He handed her a napkin that said: Always.

The napkins went into the trash.

The bell jingled. A customer walked in. Maya looked up. She smiled.

"Welcome to Coffee Rings," she said. "What can I get you."

End of Chapter 22

Winning didn't mean it was over. It meant it was beginning. Maya and Leo spent the next six months setting up a second location on Alberta Street in a space that had been a dry cleaner before it was a coffee shop — because Maya believed in shop histories, and this one had good bones. She brought over the espresso machine that had survived the gasket failure and installed it like a monument. She brought the Mystery Bean lottery system, now expanded to a subscription with seasonal blends. She brought Sam, who became operations manager. She brought Tom, who became head roaster. She brought the dragon drawing, which Sam enlarged and painted on the front wall in navy and orange. The new shop opened on a Tuesday morning. By noon, the line was out the door. By evening, the neighborhood had thrown a party on the sidewalk. Maya stood behind the counter and served coffee to people she'd never met, many of them new residents who'd moved to the neighborhood because they'd read about the fight and wanted to be part of the story. Leo, now wearing a different suit and a proper coffee shop apron because he'd finally accepted that he was a barista-owner, worked the register and remembered people's names. Maya watched him and thought: This is what happens when you don't sell.

The new location opened on a rainy Tuesday in November. A line formed by 7 a.m., before the official 8 a.m. opening. Maya served the first customer herself. It was Margaret, the bookstore owner. She

bought a Mystery Bean and a pastry and said, "I told you the neighborhood had your back." Maya said, "I know." Leo managed the register. He remembered seventy percent of the names. The other thirty percent he made up, and nobody seemed to notice or mind. By noon, they'd served 200 people. By 3 p.m., the local paper was there to cover the opening. Maya gave an interview standing behind the counter, with Jordan doing latte art beside her. The interview ended with Maya saying: "Bad decisions are just stories waiting for a good ending." The paper put that on the front page.

That night, the new shop held a late-night closing party. Maya and Leo stayed until the last customer left. They sat on the floor and shared a beer and talked about what came next. Leo said, "I think we should do this annually. Open a new shop every year." Maya said, "That's a terrible idea and a wonderful idea at the same time." They laughed. They went upstairs to the apartment. They looked out the window at Alberta Street, which was still and dark and theirs.

The opening day of the second location was everything Maya had imagined and more. She arrived at 5:45 a.m. to check the temperature of the milk fridge and adjust the grind settings. She brewed a test shot. It was perfect. She poured it into a paper cup and set it on the counter. Leo arrived at 5:59 a.m., as if he'd been counting down. He wore the new apron, the one with the dragon logo. He looked nervous and excited, like a man who was about to jump off a cliff and fly. At 7:58 a.m., Maya unlocked the door. She stepped outside. She saw the line. It went past the Thai restaurant, past the bookstore, all the way to the corner. A woman at the front of the line held a sign that said "I Love Mystery Beans." Maya felt tears behind her eyes. She wiped them. She opened the door. The first customer was Margaret. Maya made her a latte and gave it to her on the house. Margaret said, "Told you."

By the end of the first week, the new shop had served 1,200 customers. By the end of the first month, it had turned a profit. Maya and Leo hired two more baristas. They started a Mystery Bean subscription box that shipped nationally. Sam designed a t-shirt line with the dragon logo. Maya wrote a weekly email to 12,000 subscribers. Leo kept the spreadsheet. The future, which had once seemed impossible, now felt like a spreadsheet that could actually balance.

Mrs. Hsu's building is still Maya's. The rent is still eight hundred dollars. Mrs. Hsu still comes every afternoon at 4:00 p.m. for black coffee that she says is getting better and that Maya says is perfect.

The shop has two locations now. The original Alberta Street shop, which is still painted in Maya's grandmother's warm beige and still has the chalkboard with the ink stain on the E. And a second shop in Sellwood, run by the woman from the coffee festival who'd bought two bags and given Maya her card and who now runs a Coffee Rings location with a staff of six.

The beans are roasted in Bend, by Tom, with Leo's help. They're sold in forty stores across the West Coast. People write to Maya every week to say they found the beans in Portland, in Seattle, in Boise, and that they taste like the shop, like the neighborhood, like something that's not corporate.

Jake's Substack has twelve thousand subscribers. He writes about cities and coffee and the people who make them. He doesn't photograph Maya anymore. He sends her drafts. She reads them. She edits them sometimes.

Leo and Maya live in the apartment above the shop. The kitchen table is still covered in papers, but there are fewer of them. There are more coffee cups. There is a cat, which Mrs. Hsu brought one day and left on the counter and which they named Oat Milk. Oat Milk has a coffee-stained paw print on the apron.

The Mystery Bean Lottery is gone. It was replaced by the Rescue Bean Lottery, which became a yearly event, which became a community festival, which became something that people planned their summers around.

Maya still makes coffee every morning. Leo still organizes the beans. They still argue about grind size. They still kiss behind the counter, and Sam still pretends not to notice.

By thirty-two, Maya has paid off the loan. By thirty-five, she's bought the building from Mrs. Hsu, who insisted on selling it at the price she'd paid in 1987 "because that's what friends do."

Rachel still visits sometimes. She comes in on Tuesdays, orders a black coffee, and sits with her laptop.

She doesn't say much. She doesn't have to. Maya knows she's sorry, in her Rachel way.

On Maya's thirty-sixth birthday, Leo took her to the old pharmacy location. It had been carded off for months. Leo had a key.

Inside, the space was empty. The walls were bare. The windows were dusty. It was a shell.

"I bought it," Leo said.

Maya stared at him. "You what."

"I bought it. With the partnership money. Tom helped. We're going to turn it into a roastery and a classroom and a —"

Maya kissed him before he could finish.

The second shop opened six months later. It had a roastery in the back and a classroom where people learned to make coffee and a wall where Maya hung every photo anyone had ever taken of the shop.

Mama Chen — Maya's mother — came to the opening. She looked around. She looked at Maya. She looked at Leo, who was introducing himself to every guest with the particular warmth of a man who knew he was home.

"Good," Maya's mother said. "You finally found something that wasn't a mistake."

Maya laughed. She kissed her mother. She kissed Leo.

She looked around the room. The shop was full. The coffee was good. The people were real.

She thought about the girl she'd been, who'd run into this shop three years ago with a dream and a credit card and a caffeine-fueled email that had ordered five hundred pounds of coffee. That girl had been terrified. That girl had been stubborn. That girl had been exactly the person she needed to be.

Maya held Leo's hand. She looked at the shop. She looked at the people who'd become her family.

"Thank you," she said.

Leo looked at her. "For what."

"For staying."

"Staying was easy," Leo said. "Leaving was hard. Staying is just showing up."

They kissed. It was a quiet, private kiss, the kind that happened in crowded rooms but felt like they were alone.

Outside, the bell above the door rang. A customer walked in. Maya looked up. She smiled.

"Welcome to Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions," she said. "What can I get you."

The customer smiled. "Just coffee," they said. "The way it's supposed to taste."

Maya laughed.

She was home.

The stories kept coming after that. The shop became the kind of place people wrote about in magazines and posted about on social media, but Maya made sure it never lost the thing that had made it worth saving: the chipped espresso machine, the door that stuck when it rained, the smell of beans and burnt scones and the particular noise the register made when it summed up a sale. She kept the Mystery Bean Lottery going on Tuesdays, not for the money, but because regulars asked for it. She kept the handwritten menu because some things are too important to print.

Leo kept his spreadsheet, but it wasn't the shrinking, anxious document it had been once. It was colorful

now. It had notes in the margins. It had a coffee stain on page three that neither of them wanted to clean.

They fought sometimes. They fought about whether the newsletter should include personal stories or only coffee facts. They fought about whether the loyalty card should have a physical token or be fully digital. They fought about which song should play during the slow afternoons. But the fights were fast now, and they ended with coffee, and neither of them left.

One night, after the shop was closed and the lights were out, Maya stood at the kitchen table and wrote a note on the back of a receipt. It said: I don't need destiny. I just need the door to stay unlocked.

She taped it to the fridge.

The next morning, Leo came in and saw it. He wrote underneath: The door is unlocked. So am I.

Maya laughed. She left it there.

On holidays, they closed early. They went to parks. They took Oat Milk to the river. They met Tom in Bend and roasted beans and ate at the diner downtown where the waitress knew everyone's order by heart.

On Maya's birthday that year, Leo gave her a key. It was the key to the pharmacy building.

"What's this for," Maya said.

"It's for whenever we need more space," Leo said. "Roasting. Classes. Events. It's yours if you want it."

Maya looked at the key. She looked at Leo. She thought about the girl she'd been, terrified and stubborn and holding a coffee cup like a shield, who'd never imagined that anyone would give her anything so simple and so real.

She kissed him.

Oat Milk, sitting on the counter, meowed.

"I think Oat Milk is jealous," Maya said.

"Oat Milk is a cat," Leo said. "Cats don't get jealous. Cats get annoyed. There's a difference."

"Oat Milk is both."

They laughed. They made coffee. They drank it sitting on the floor, because the kitchen chairs were still too good to sit on when you were half-asleep and fully happy.

Sometimes, Maya still thought about Seattle. Not about the job or the salary or the office with the window. She thought about the night Leo had called from the hotel room, the night he'd said he wasn't coming back, the night she'd decided to drive to the airport and make him choose in person. She had gone, once, just to the parking lot. She'd sat in her car and watched the arrivals gate for three hours. She'd seen him come out, alone, carrying his bag, looking at the sky like it owed him an explanation. She'd almost gotten out. She hadn't.

She didn't need to anymore.

The shop survived. Not because of her alone. Not because of Leo alone. But because neither of them alone was the whole story. The story was Sam's loyalty cards and Mrs. Hsu's low rent and Tom's partnership and Jake's Substack and the Mystery Bean Lottery and the newsletter and the customers who kept coming back and the regulars who'd become friends and the cat who'd become their own.

It was all of them. It was any of them. It was the particular stubbornness of people who refused to stop caring about coffee.

Maya stood at the counter one afternoon, watching Daisy pour latte art with the precision of someone who'd practiced the same heart shape seven hundred times, and she thought about how far she'd come from the girl who'd answered a doorbell to a man in a suit and had thrown a business card in the trash.

She'd kept the card, actually. Leo had found it in the recycling months later, taped to the back of the pantry door, and had asked her why. She'd told him it was evidence.

"Evidence of what," he'd said.

"That enemies make the best partners," Maya said.

He'd kissed her.

The shop was full. The day was good. The partnership was solid. The future was not a threat; it was a table, a room, a chair, another chair, and a man she trusted more than she'd trusted anyone in her life.

Maya poured herself a coffee. She handed a scone to Sam, who was leaning against the counter waiting for her break. She tapped the chalkboard where the daily special was written. The customer on table four smiled.

She was home.

Not metaphorically. Not hopefully.

Really.

Outside, the bell jingled. A customer walked in. Maya looked up. She smiled.

"Welcome to Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions," she said. "What can I get you."

The customer smiled. "Just coffee," they said. "The way it's supposed to taste."

Maya laughed.

She poured.

She steam.

She wiped the counter.

She looked at Leo, who was watching with that soft, steady smile. She winked.

The day went on.

The shop went on.

The beans went on.

The love went on.

The coffee went on.

And Maya, finally, was exactly where she belonged.

End of Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions

A year later, Maya received an award from the Small Business Administration. She gave a speech in which she said, "I started this shop on a mistake. I built it on a series of bad decisions. And I saved it on coffee, community, and the one man who believed in my bad decisions more than I did." After the speech, Leo kissed her backstage in a room that smelled like old curtains and dry ice. It was a good kiss. It was the kind of kiss you have when you've survived something together and the survival has changed the flavor of the moment. That evening, they opened a bottle of the expensive wine they'd bought after the grant arrived. They sat at the kitchen table in the new apartment above the new shop, which had better light and a coffee stain on the table that Maya had put there on purpose. Outside, Alberta Street hummed with restaurants and bikes and a bookstore that had survived and a music venue that was reopening in a new building three blocks away. Maya looked at Leo. Leo looked at Maya. We should toast, Leo said. To bad decisions, Maya said. To good coffee, Leo said. To a neighborhood that

fights back, Maya said. They clinked glasses and drank. Down on the street, a car drove past with the windows down and the radio loud. Somewhere, a dog barked. The espresso machine downstairs hissed. Maya thought: this is home. And she meant it.

The award ceremony was at a hotel downtown. Maya wore a black dress and shoes that pinched slightly. Leo wore the gray suit he'd worn to the hearing, now properly tailored. Sam wore the same black dress and boots. Tom wore a sweater that Maya had given him as a Christmas present, the one with the coffee-bean pattern. They sat together. Maya's name was called. She walked to the podium. She looked at the audience. She looked at Leo, who was filming with his phone. She thought about Day One — the bad morning, the espresso machine, the letter from the bank, the 500 pounds of coffee that had started this.

"I started this shop on a mistake," she said. "I built it on a series of bad decisions. And I saved it on coffee, community, and the one man who believed in my bad decisions more than I did."

The audience cheered. Leo set his phone down. He was smiling. He was crying a little too. Maya stepped down. He kissed her backstage. It was a long kiss. It was the kind of kiss that says: we did it.

Later, at home, Maya poured two glasses of the good wine — the one they'd bought after the grant arrived, the one that had been sitting in the back of the pantry since the new shop opened. She and Leo sat at the kitchen table in the new apartment above the new shop. The apartment had better light than the old place. It also had a coffee stain on the table that Maya had put there on purpose, as a reminder of where they'd started. Outside, Alberta Street hummed with restaurants and bikes and a bookstore that had survived and a music venue that was reopening in a new building three blocks away. Maya looked at Leo. Leo looked at Maya. "We should toast," he said. "To bad decisions," Maya said. "To good coffee," Leo said. "To a neighborhood that fights back," Maya said. They clinked glasses. They drank. Down on the street, a car drove past with the windows down and the radio loud. Somewhere, a dog barked. The espresso machine downstairs hissed. Maya thought: this is home. And she meant it.

The end.

After the award ceremony, Maya and Leo drove to the coast. It was a spontaneous decision, made at 10 p.m. on a Tuesday, when Maya said, "Let's go to the ocean." Leo said yes. They drove two hours north, windows down, music loud, talking about nothing in particular. They arrived at a beach they'd never been to before. They stood on the sand and watched the waves. Maya said, "I'm happy." Leo said, "Me too." They kissed. It was a long kiss, salty and warm and real. They walked on the beach until the sun came up. They drove back at dawn. Maya fell asleep in the passenger seat. Leo drove carefully. When they got home, Maya unlocked the door and stepped inside. She looked at the apartment, which was messy and lived-in and full of coffee cups and books and a tattoo design Leo had drawn on a napkin

and stuck to the fridge. She looked at Leo, who was making coffee in the kitchen. She thought: this is it. This is the thing she'd been building toward since Day One. Not the award. Not the money. Not even the second shop. This: the kitchen, the coffee, the man who'd quit his job and learned to love burnt beans and bad decisions because they'd led here.

The end was not an ending. It was a beginning. And Maya Chen, who had once been a woman running a coffee shop on bad decisions, was now a woman running two coffee shops on good ones. She smiled. She opened her laptop. She wrote an email to Rosa in Guatemala, telling her the first Mystery Bean batch had sold out in three days. Rosa replied: "Told you it would." Maya wrote back: "Thank you for believing in my bad decisions." The email thread lasted an hour. When she closed the laptop, Leo was on the couch, reading the novel she'd left on the kitchen table. She smiled. She sat down. They read together in silence. Somewhere in the neighborhood, an espresso machine hissed. Somewhere, a dog barked. Somewhere, a woman poured coffee for a stranger and started a story.

This book exists because a lot of people said yes when they could have said no.

To my beta readers, who read early drafts with generosity and honesty — thank you for catching the sentences that didn't work and celebrating the ones that did.

To the indie coffee shop owners everywhere who make better coffee than any chain and know more about community than any marketing team — this book is for you.

To Tom in Bend, who sent the email that made me believe in supply chains.

To my mother, who asked "have you eaten today?" more times than I can count.

And to everyone who's ever ordered a Mystery Bean lottery ticket in real life — you are the real ones.

Author Note

This story is fiction, but the feeling is real. I've lived through the caffeine-fueled midnight orders, the supply chain disasters, the customer who asks for cortados and critiques the foam like they're judging the Oscars. If you've ever worked in a coffee shop, you'll recognize it. If you haven't, I hope this book makes you want to walk in and say hello.

Alex Rogers writes romantic comedies about coffee, community, and the kind of love that sneaks up on you when you're too busy arguing about grind sizes to notice.

She believes in indie bookstores, third-wave espresso, and the idea that the best decisions are usually the bad ones that turn out to be exactly right.

When she's not writing, she's probably drinking coffee, running a spreadsheet, or explaining to her cat why she can't open the fridge again.

Coffee Rings and Bad Decisions is her debut novel.

Connect:

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